This Is What *Inequality* Looks Like

ESSAYS BY

Teo You Yenn

Inequality

This book is a remarkable rarity—a vivid ethnography of the lives, dreams and disappointments of low-income Singaporeans, skillfully intertwined with the implicit and explicit mental ideologies, social structures and bureaucratic institutions that both bind and separate us from each other. Delivered in slender, evocative prose with insight and empathy, yet informed by analytical distance and infused with theoretical rigor, it shows that the lives of our often-forgotten fellow citizens reveal larger truths about ourselves and our society, and the nature of humanity in our affluent post-industrial state. The highly accessible narrative both touches the heart and engages the mind, and deserves to become the basis for a wideranging public discourse on the soul of our nation.
—Linda Lim, Professor Emerita of Corporate Strategy and International Business at the Stephen M. Ross School of Business, University of Michigan

With courage, integrity and scientific tools, Teo You Yenn enters the hidden abode of inequality. Immersing herself in the underside of Singapore society, she makes the invisible visible—contrasting the hardships and precarity of family life, schooling, parenting, housing among low-income residents with the taken-for-granted comforts of the middle class. She disrupts widely-held national mythologies, calling attention to the defects of Singapore's welfare state and how these might be repaired. Sociology at its best!
—Michael Burawoy, Professor of Sociology, University of California, Berkeley

This Is What Inequality Looks Like is a refreshing, provocative, eye-opening book that is written with passion and insight. Highly readable and accessible, it will make for stimulating reading for anyone interested in the problems of poverty and inequality in and beyond Singapore. Teo's work is grounded in sociological sensitivity and shaped by three years of intimate interactions with Singapore's poor. This book disrupts the image of Singapore as merely a place of prosperity and progress and points instead to the day-to-day experiences of Singapore's disadvantaged residents, the challenges they face, and the embedded presumptions

about them that undermine their access to assistance with dignity. Teo invites her readers to confront inequality head on and to consider where they fit into the social matrix. Singapore's overly-simplistic discourses of "social inclusion" and "the greater good," she argues, serve in fact to valorize the market and self-reliance at the expense of meaningful and transformative change aimed at reducing social inequalities.

—Nicole Constable, Professor of Anthropology and Research Professor in the University Center for International Studies, University of Pittsburgh

This Is What Inequality Looks Like is a masterfully crafted text. Consciously avoiding academic frames, Teo You Yenn's ethically and politically grounded narrative unfolds through vignettes of lived experiences that stand in sharp, stark contrast to the dominant imaginings of Singaporeans as mobile, cosmopolitan, free, agentic, affluent global citizens. Drawing on everyday lives of individuals and families, privileging their voices through the choice of ethnography—the book's chapters communicate the pathos and experiences of being poor and living under conditions of inequality in a cosmopolitan city-state. The book's lens is focused critically on popular, academic and state discourses about Singapore society. The book is a much needed intervention in hitherto un-problematised, taken-for-granted conclusions about poverty (its absence and then its causes), about inequalities, about responsibilities of the state and social structures in Singapore—regnant amongst Singaporeans—academics included. The book will no doubt resonate globally and has obvious analytical reverberations that are delivered through the empirical richness of a veiled segment of everyday Singaporean lives. The book disturbs deliberately, asking difficult questions that demand considered moral responses, highlighting above all the role of institutional structures in producing the context for the unfolding of experiences of poverty and inequality. Teo's voice, heard powerfully and honestly throughout the text, is a provocation; each page is etched with an inspiration and moral compulsion to engage—an invitation that is impossible to resist.

—Vineeta Sinha, Professor of Sociology, National University of Singapore

This is a remarkable book in so many ways. Teo You Yenn encourages all of us who live in Singapore to ask hard questions about the structural and psychic elements of inequality, and to challenge the comforting and yet ultimately self-defeating stories that many of us who have benefitted from Singapore's economic progress tell ourselves. *This Is What Inequality Looks Like* is also beautifully written. It is an inspirational model of how an academic scholar can address a popular audience through a deep reflection on her position as a Sociologist, inviting readers to embark on parallel learning journeys commencing in the often overlooked experiences of people who inhabit other social worlds.
—Philip Holden, Professor of English Language and Literature, National University of Singapore

In this accessibly written and closely observed new book, Teo You Yenn takes the reader beyond the statistics and into the everyday lives of the less fortunate in Singapore. A timely and necessary book for a city in a hurry.
—Philip Gorski, Professor of Sociology, Yale University

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ESSAYS BY

Teo You Yenn



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Foreword to the New Edition

by Kwok Kian Woon

"MY RESEARCH BEGAN as one of poverty, of the low-income, of *them*. Over time, I have come to realize that the story I have uncovered is one of inequality, of relative wealth and poverty, of *us*." Thus Teo You Yenn traces the arc of her intellectual journey in writing "an ethnography of inequality rather than a catalog of poverty" in *This Is What Inequality Looks Like*—a journey which she invites us to make with her, on our own, and with others.

A line came to me in contemplating the significance of this book, but I hesitated in using it because it sounded clichéd. Still, the line keeps coming back when I re-read pages of the book—indeed, almost any page—only to be struck again by its unique qualities, which taken together are rarely found in a book written by a sociologist or an academic. *This is a beautifully written book on an unbeautiful subject matter.*

Beautifully written because reading it resembles listening to a musical composition with multiple melodies, overlapping and cascading, and yet interrupting and challenging each other. In particular, there are two major melodic lines in interaction and tension, springing from contrasting class positions: the professor's constant questioning and her respondents' generous sharing of their lived experiences, both equally important, with the former seeking to understand and amplify the latter. And this in counterpoint to the dominance and didacticism of a singular, louder, mantra drumming repeatedly in the background—the national narrative of meritocracy and mobility, which is also embedded and re-enacted in personal narratives of self-worth.

An unbeautiful subject matter because inequality and poverty exist jarringly amidst progress and affluence, and out of sync with the profound universalist ideals enshrined in the National Pledge: "… to build a democratic society based on justice and equality…." Beneath Singapore's avowed communitarianism lies a deeply

individualist core, inscribed in meritocracy as an unassailable and sacrosanct ideological bedrock. You Yenn speaks of "our bifurcated consciousness—greater-good-society-before-self on the one side; survival-of-the-fittest-care-for-my–family-first on the other." To confront inequality is to confront this incoherent ideology, and ultimately to confront ourselves, our incoherent selves.

One senses that the author had to put herself into—and through—this confrontation, and in an environment that is inimical to intellectual confrontation, where critical discourse can even be equated with disloyalty to the nation. Hence the searching and self-reflective, in some parts ambivalent quality of her prose, posing and reprising questions at every turn. Just pages into the book, she asks, as if she feels the need to pull back: "Why am I inserting myself in what I write? This is not typical practice in academic writing. It is actually tremendously uncomfortable." But a writer cannot draw her readers into an uncomfortable conversation if she herself does not carry the discomfort so palpably. She understands that the subject matter engenders emotions, including her own; she speaks of agitation and impatience in working towards change, and even anger when a conference participant kept referring to the low-income as "those people." Here is a researcher whose own vulnerabilities are honestly revealed and worked through as she makes sense of the precariousness of the low-income, whose inherent dignity as persons are neither recognized nor respected.

Indeed, this book is not conventional academic writing as much as it is based on detailed empirical fieldwork and the critical evaluation of scholarly literature. When narrow "key performance indicators" are used in assessing a professor's "research output," questions might be raised about a book's merit if it is not written for a highly specialized academic readership. An intellectual, however, must make choices about how to live out one's vocation. This explains the impact of You Yenn's book and why it has become a publishing sensation in Singapore, and more importantly how a single book—academically rigorous but written for a general audience—could stimulate a widening and deepening public debate on inequality in the country.

This book has reached diverse sectors of the reading public, ranging from those in their late teens to senior citizens—in part because it gave form to ideas and sentiments that many were finding ways to articulate, albeit inchoately. You Yenn's introspective voice and insightful analysis lead to lucid conclusions for readers to consider as they reflect on their own society and question what it means to relate to fellow members who face very different life circumstances.

Here I would like to make an observation about readers in their twenties and thirties, either studying in tertiary institutions or working in the public and private sectors. In other words, these are the beneficiaries of Singapore's meritocracy, the majority of whom are first-generation graduates experiencing upward mobility and, perhaps along with that, a mixed sense of security and insecurity in the face of a highly competitive job market and rising costs of living. I have personally witnessed their responses to the book in public discussions; they were learning to frame their questions in new and nuanced ways, not divorced from the shape and substance of human lives. Many reflected on their work in social service, housing, education, technology, and finance; and it seemed that they too were searching for ways to better understand the experiences of low-income families as persons with human needs, and not as clients and recipients of help and charity. Their idealism defied the stereotypes of millennials as apathetic, cynical and self-entitled. Yet, it may also be summarily dismissed as naïve, impractical, softheaded or, worse, unpatriotic because it is anathema to the hard truths that underpin Singapore's success.

Who is to say whether this precious idealism will be short-lived or sustained—and what difference it will make to the moral life of a people? I draw a lesson from a few of the many thought-provoking lines in the book: "Dignity is like clean air. You do not notice its absence unless it is short supply. You do not realize how much you need it, how important it is to you, until you don't have it." We could also say, idealism is like clean air.

You Yenn invites us to participate in a conversation, an evolving set of interlocking conversations that goes beyond her book and beyond Singapore. This is already

intimated when she refers to inequality between and within societies and particularly in cities—"in the contrasts between skyscrapers and slums; in the contrasts between shopping malls and ghettoized migrant worker dormitories." Although Singapore is a city-state without a rural hinterland, it draws hundreds of thousands of migrant workers from its neighbors and the wider Asian region. The phenomenon of inequality takes on greater complexity when we figure in the human needs of guest workers who contribute to the city's economic growth, which is why You Yenn's analysis can be extrapolated to a wider canvas. If a significant level of inequality among Singaporeans is tolerable, what does this say of our regard for more remote *others* in our midst? And if urban inequality is pronounced in the model state of Singapore, the dynamics and perspectives crystallized in this book have theoretical implications for major cities across Asian countries with rising middle classes and growing urban poverty. Kuala Lumpur, Jakarta, Bangkok, Manila, and the many cities in India and China come to mind, each manifesting a specific configuration of human costs.

This is What Inequality Looks Like is an exemplar of not just a new and impactful kind of academic writing, but also a mode of public engagement that connects us with each other—across classes, across cities, across countries. In its abiding concern for recognizing and respecting human dignity across the unequal circumstances that we find ourselves in, perhaps the profoundest question that it poses is: What does our shared humanity look like?

January 2019

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Preface

A SOCIOLOGIST cannot really begin with the question—is there poverty in contemporary Singapore? The answer to that question, based on what she knows about the world, has to be yes. But a Singaporean, a Singaporean can hear the question and think, hmm, I'm not sure.

I began this project as a sociologist, and also as a Singaporean. In my sociologist's mind, I knew that I only had to look to find. In my Singaporean imagination, I could not picture what I would see if I looked. These two facts underpin the architecture of this book. No matter what it is we know, and regardless of what empirical truths have informed our knowledge, we retain blindspots. These are remnants of some earlier learning; they are deeply embedded prejudices; and they are ways of seeing (or not seeing) that we share with many others in our society.

This is a book written for an audience outside of myself. It has come about partly because I inhabit some of the same mental spaces as the Singaporeans I would like to speak to. I hold in my head some of the same images and assumptions about who we are and what this place is. This book is like a big torchlight: shining and searching, introducing pieces of empirical evidence so that we can identify blindspots and reexamine assumptions. It is a dialogue externally directed *and* internally conducted. The sociologist is asking the Singaporean: look at this, what do you see?

This is a book about what I found when I looked. It is a book about what a sociologist Singaporean sees. It is about how seeing poverty entails confronting inequality. It is about how acknowledging poverty and inequality leads to uncomfortable revelations about our society and ourselves. And it is about how once we see, we cannot, must not, unsee.

*

The essays in the book are written to be read individually, but have been arranged to be read as a totality and in sequence. Each piece aims to accomplish two things: first, to introduce a key aspect of the experience of being low-income to the reader; second, to demonstrate that people's experiences must be understood in relation to structural conditions of inequality—in which people of varying class circumstances can do the same things and yet face very different outcomes. The essays draw on data from three years (2013-2016) of conversations, observations, and in-depth interviews with people who live with very limited income, as well as a decade of research on family, social welfare, gender, and public policy in Singapore. I analyze low-income persons' experiences in order to shed clearer light on the logic and principles embedded in Singapore's structures of care, its welfare regime, its school system, and its labor conditions.

In situating the lives and experiences of a group within the larger social context, the book is an ethnography of inequality rather than a catalog of poverty.

Why ethnography? Studies of inequality often treat it primarily as a question of numerical trends. It is that of course, but it is also, importantly, experiential. The everyday experiences of inequality are crucial for shedding light on how it is enacted and the price paid by people low on the social hierarchy. An ethnography of inequality informs us of the structural scaffolding that perpetuates and deepens its existence, as well as the dance between the structural and cultural that exists between the scaffolds.

Why inequality and not *just* poverty? Contrary to popular discourses in Singapore, and other cases where inequality is widening, 'the poor' are not outside of systems, nor exceptions to dominant trends. Their circumstances are key components of shared social realities; their lives and livelihoods exist in direct relationship to those who are wealthier; their constraints reveal the logics of the broader social landscape and political economy.

To study poverty without inequality leads to tendencies to misrecognize structural issues for individual failings. On the other hand, to study inequality without poverty, particularly through focus only on trends and numbers, is to allow

for research devoid of humanity insofar as we merely cite phenomenon without naming the injustices as enacted on real persons.

In the contemporary world, we see crises of inequality, breakdowns of welfare regimes, and deterioration of social contracts and trust. What we have in Singapore embodies key tensions and contradictions faced by highly wealthy and yet highly unequal societies. It brings into view the ecology of issues contributing to the everyday reproduction of poverty and inequality. Ultimately, confronting poverty and inequality means confronting questions of ethics and morality—questions about what it means to be deserving, questions about what a society is, and questions about what the greater good can, or should, entail.

*

The way we frame our questions shapes the way we see solutions. This book does what appears to be a no-brainer task, but one that I believe is missing and important—it asks readers to pose questions in different ways, to shift the vantage point from which they view 'common sense,' and in so doing, to see themselves as part of problems *and* potential solutions.

In the process of working on this project and writing this book, I have sometimes become agitated and impatient. Many of the lacks that I see in our society seem to me to be solvable problems. Yet, I do not see how they will be solved. Like many other Singaporeans, I want to know: what can the government do about this? Like many other sociologists, I ask more generally: what can everyone, but especially people in positions of power, do differently that would lead to different outcomes?

A wise friend of mine reminded me of the resilience of systems. He told me that often people who appear to sit in positions of influence feel powerless. He gave an analogy: do you ever take the MRT, he asked. You know how sometimes the train jerks really suddenly and yet no one falls and somehow everyone is still standing? Systems are like that—individual persons cannot change it.

I have spent many years of my research life talking about how people have limited agency—that we make choices and live lives in specific conditions in which we have little control. This is a fundamental starting point for sociologists. But after my friend finished speaking, I reminded him: that's a great analogy, but there are important differences. The laws of physics do not care for considered action. Molecules, atoms, gravity, force—these are not moral actors. But we are.

This book is an invitation. If you are reading it, you have your reasons. I am audacious enough to write about what I saw but not so audacious as to think I know how you will interpret these essays and what value they will have for you. This book is an invitation to everyone interested in reading it—an invitation that in the years to come, we will open up the conversation, we will deepen it, we will turn words and ideas into action. We may choose to act or we may choose not to. But both are choices, because we are not just molecules.

Step 1: Disrupt the Narrative

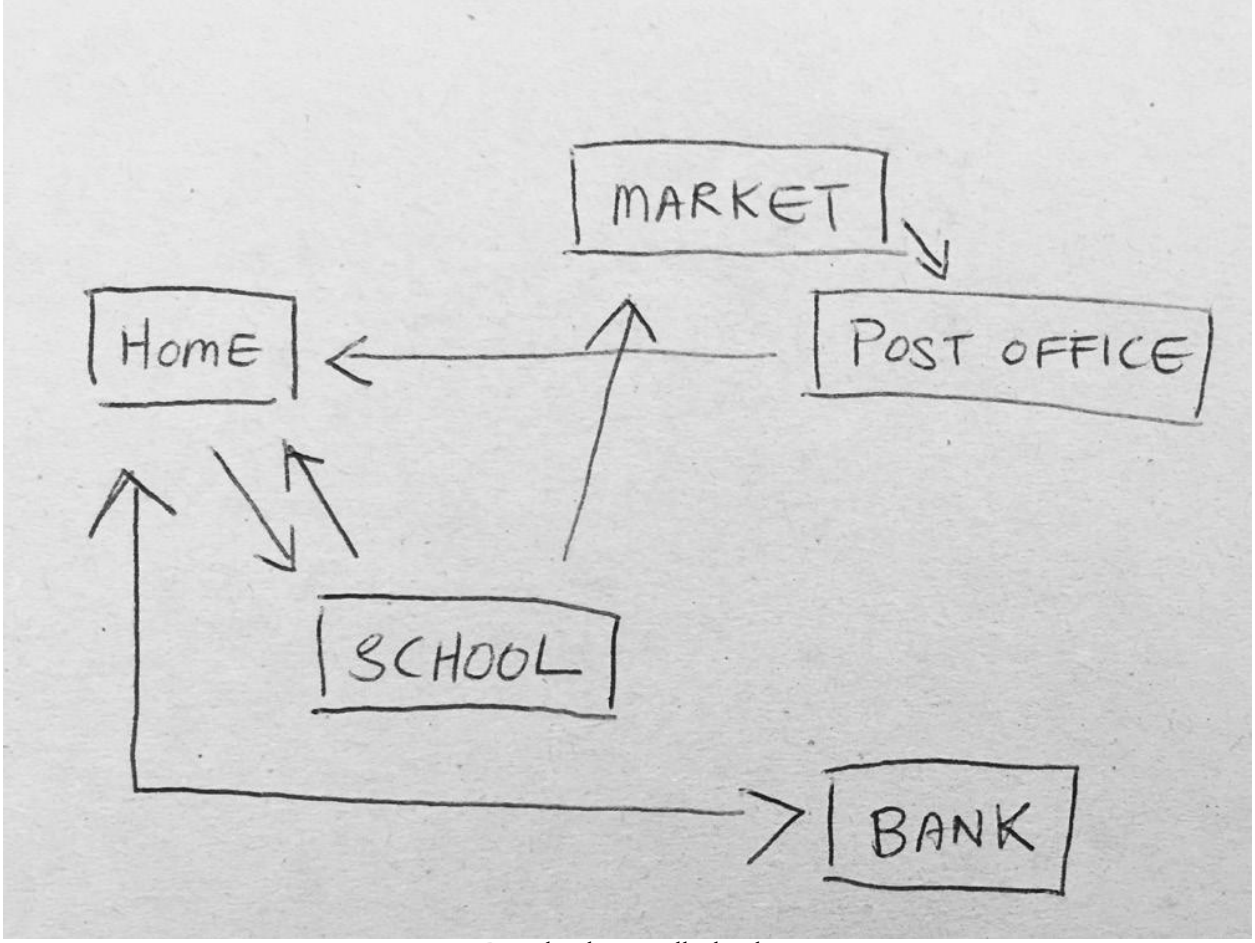
WHEN I THINK about my research, a memory that often returns, and which evokes complicated feelings, is an image of myself driving away from the blocks of HDB[1] rental flats where I do my field work. I have done this countless times—got into my car at the end of a few hours of hanging out at various field sites, turned on the ignition, taken a sip of water from my bottle, and driven home.

Home is a comfortable apartment, barely half an hour away, a world apart.

When I get in the car, I am usually still thinking of the people I just met, recalling the stories they've shared. Sometimes I am sweaty from walking around for a few hours; if the topic of bed bugs had come up, I feel phantom itches on my arms and legs.

As I start driving, I transpose myself back into a radically different reality—one where my profession brings me status and recognition; where I can easily say to my family, "I'm too tired to cook tonight, let's eat out"; where I can walk into any shop, museum, or restaurant, and be greeted as a potential consumer. It is a reality that fits into the image of Singapore as Global City and I its global citizen—footloose, cosmopolitan, mobile.

The first time I drove away was after a group conversation in which several women charted for me their movements through space on an average week. It looked something like this:



Big island or small island?

That afternoon, as my car entered the highway, it dawned on me that what was for me just another drive, a journey I could take whenever I wanted, was for the people I had just met, an irregular occurrence. It was a surprising revelation.

When I speak with people who are not from Singapore, one of the things that comes up is how small it is, how it is *just* an island. I often perpetuate this truism when I describe Singapore to friends who have not been here. Yet here I was, meeting people for whom the island is in fact large and rarely explored beyond a few must-go places—the schools their kids attend; the market to buy food; the bank to deposit money; the post office to top up their pre-paid utilities cards or pay other bills. While people in my social circle go wherever they wish on a regular basis and complain about running out of things to do on weekends, I was meeting people whose experiences of space in Singapore was limited to a radius of a few kilometers.

If they traveled longer distances, it was to get from home to work and not necessarily to use leisure or consumption spaces.

Soon after my initial visit, I would meet many others who have lived in Singapore their whole lives and yet not been to many of the places I give little second thought to.

Mobility and immobility are at once spatial and temporal—they are about movement through places and also changes over time.

Mobility/immobility are lived realities as well as imagined states of being. They describe our everyday movements. And they shape how we think about where we have been and where we can still go.

When I present my work on poverty in contemporary Singapore, I sometimes encounter audience members who respond to what I say about material hardships by launching into stories about the hardships *they* grew up or are familiar with. At one workshop, I talked about a woman whose family was homeless for a few months. Her children had to shower in public bathrooms at 4am every day, in preparation to go to school. As I spoke, a person in his 70s quipped that *he* takes cold showers every day too. He cheerfully pointed out that it is nice because the weather in Singapore is hot. At another event, I spoke of bed bugs keeping kids up at night, leading them to miss school when they overslept in the morning. Someone then countered that he experienced bed bugs as a child too.

The remarks were made partly in jest, but their speakers aimed to soften the impact of my claims. What they were essentially implying is that taking cold showers is not so difficult; and bed bugs are not such a hardship. But they are. What these two people imply to be quirky habits or everyday phenomena of a romantic past are, for the people I have been meeting these recent years, uncomfortable conditions of an everyday present. It is their everyday reality to see that everyone else appears to have 'moved up' and established some semblance of comfort while they alone are 'left behind.'

Narratives of the Nation, Stories of the Self

When the two men spoke of their 'hardships,' it is rendered legible by a specific narrative. Each year, more material is produced to bolster this narrative: more exhibits, more posters, more movies, more declarations and slogans on websites, more news articles. Layers of a story build on each other, strengthening its overall structure and brightening its 'common sense' veneer. For a Singaporean, even a critical-minded one, it is a story that gets under the skin. It is a story that seeps into one's emotions, and becomes so deeply a part of a story of the self that it is hard to externalize and articulate.

This is the story we tell ourselves about ourselves: Singapore became in a matter of a few decades a shining Global City. We were poor and now we are rich. We had no natural resources and now we can eat whatever we want, buy whatever we want, right in our own city. We were uneducated and now our children score among the highest in the world on standardized tests. We are safe, we are clean, we are amazing. We are amazing. We are amazing.

To remain amazing, we must keep moving. Movement, motion, mobility—these are not cosmetic; they are about survival. If we stand still, we are doomed.

How does this narrative matter? When the two people listening to my talk brought up their 'hardships,' it is this narrative—so taken-for-granted it does not need uttering—that renders their experiences dignified rather than shameful. One can proudly talk about choosing to take cold showers because one knows that one is accepted to have climbed and arrived. One can recall bed bugs fondly rather than with shame because one is assured that one has moved up and is beyond those dark days of being poor. With the national narrative of miraculous progress serving as backdrop to their personal stories, these persons can lay claims to a kind of dignified triumph.

Which then leaves us wondering: what about the dignity of those who have not been and are not mobile? What of those who have, within the structure of this

narrative, stood still?

Inequality and Poverty

Inequality and poverty are urgent and global issues. They are topics that have received deep and sustained attention by academics, journalists, activists, policy makers, international governance institutions.[2] There is increasing recognition that the two issues are empirically linked, and that state actions (and inactions), in tandem with corporate practices, are crucial for intensifying or ameliorating problems.

The state of global inequality is bleak. Tremendous inequality remains between nations. The legacies of imperialism and colonialism, with attendant monopolization of resources by the global North to the detriment of the well-being of people in the global South, remain very much contemporary realities.[3] Inequality within societies too is severe. Where some own abundant cash and capital, many find themselves in more precarious situations; yet others seem altogether out of the game. In cities, where most people now live, we see manifestations of this—in the contrasts between skyscrapers and slums; in the contrasts between shopping malls and ghettoized migrant worker dormitories; in the contrasts between the bodies of people laboring as maids and construction workers and those who work out… at gyms.

The acknowledgment of and grappling with income and wealth inequalities seems slow to reach Singapore's shores. It is not easy to fold these realities into the tidy narrative of progress and prosperity.

In Singapore, inequality and poverty rates are difficult to ascertain as numerical data is patchy. Nonetheless, researchers who work with quantitative data point out that the trajectory of the Gini coefficient in recent decades suggests that inequality was slightly ameliorated in the 1960s and 1970s, and then increased again from the 1980s to the present.[4]

In 2016, income inequality as measured by the Gini coefficient stood at 0.458 before transfers and 0.402 after transfers.[5] Per capita household income (from paid work) for the top 10% of households was S$12,773, which is 2.1 times that of the 81st-90th decile households (S$5,958); 5.4 times that of the 41st-50th decile households (S$2,339); and 23 times that of the lowest 10% households (S$543). Among wealthy countries, Singapore is ranked among the most unequal countries (second to Hong Kong).[6]

The number of people who could be considered poor in Singapore is hard to ascertain because of the absence of an official poverty line. However, if it is defined, as some international organizations and scholars have defined it, as encompassing households whose incomes are less than half the median household income of the population, then roughly a fifth of the resident population[7] could be defined as poor.[8]

The people I have been talking to in the past three years are at the bottom of the income spectrum. These are households that qualify for rental housing from the Housing & Development Board (HDB). By definition—because this is the criterion set by the HDB—this means that they earn S$1,500 or less per household. While their situations may be particularly difficult, what they struggle with can help us understand some general challenges and insecurities faced by people in the contemporary global city. The point of looking closely at their lives is to shed light not just on the very low-income, but to analyze their experiences as a way of understanding our systems more broadly.

Meritocracy and Individual Narratives of Worth

The promise of equality is often described as a promise of mobility. That is, national leaders emphasize that they are focused on delivering *opportunities* for upward movement, for improvement: we cannot say the outcome will be equal, but we can promise that everyone will get to fairly play the game. The Singaporean state

regime has hedged its promise for equality heavily on this qualification. The hedge we can think of as 'meritocracy.'

Through the discourse and institutionalization of meritocracy, the narrative of large-scale upward mobility is scaled down to the individual level.

What are the contours of 'meritocracy'? Upward mobility is something *individuals* can achieve; this is a modern sensibility in its implication that one's fortunes are detached from that of one's family. Second, mobility can be achieved via hard work within the formal education system; this is in contrast to the model of success through business and enterprise that was the dominant mode before mass education. Third, the formal education system is strongly focused on academic know-how and examinations that test these. Fourth, while hard work is a necessary ingredient, an element of success is presumed to be about natural abilities; while everyone has a shot at success, there is natural inequality among people and the system cannot correct those natural inequalities of intelligence and talent. Part of what a meritocratic system does then is to sort, select, weed out, and differentially reward students, with examinations being the main tools deployed.

An aspect of the script of meritocracy that is rarely commented on but widely accepted is therefore this: the system aspires to fair competition, but the outcomes of competition are inevitably unequal positions in terms of academic credentials, professions, income, and wealth. In other words, although no political leader anywhere would emphasize this in the terms I'm about to, dreams about 'meritocracy' have never been about and do not pretend to lead to equal outcomes. Inequality, in fact, is a logical outcome of meritocracy. What the education system does when it selects, sorts, and hierarchizes, and when it gives its stamp of approval to those 'at the top,' is that it renders those who succeed through the system as legitimately *deserving*.[9] Left implicit is that those at the bottom have failed to be deserving.

Through the discourse and institutionalization of meritocracy, the narrative of large-scale upward mobility is thereby made concrete at the individual level. The connection between national success and individual merit is a powerful public *and*

private narrative that shapes those who've arrived, those in motion, and those standing still. To return to the two people who quipped about cold showers and bed bugs, we could say that the national narrative of mobility is powerfully grafted onto their individual narratives of worth.

Meritocracy: Not working as it should, or exactly as it can?

On the afternoons and evenings when I conduct my field work, as I visit families to chat, I sometimes get the feeling that time slows down. I walk into flats to see ways of being that I recognize from my childhood school holidays in the 1980s, when I would spend time at my grandparents' house in semi-rural Malaysia: a man boils water, on the stove, so that his child can have warm water to scoop out from a bucket at bath time. Tilam (mattresses) are kept away, stacked to one side during the day and laid out on floors at night, because the space for sleep is also the space for living.

There is so much that is positive in what I've observed, reminiscent of a time when relationships between people felt deeper and more central to the rhythms of everyday life: we sit on floors chatting about the past and present, taking our time to build trust and understanding, without a huge rush toward narrow goals and quantifiable ends. People in fact have a lot to do, but they somehow still have the patience and generosity to put their tasks on hold in order to entertain my questions. I find myself viewing my normal rhythms as a university professor and working parent in fresh light—recognizing a profound neglect of humanity in the mad rush that dominates my regular social interactions.

Children as young as six are capable of caring for siblings and neighbors who are younger, as they all run around the corridor playing games; their independence and capacity for care impress me tremendously.

It takes a while to move beyond seeing these scenes as either those of a romantic past or an impoverished present. They are neither and both. What they represent is something that requires an alternative set of vocabularies, a separate set of lenses to view clearly.

These lives can be seen clearly only when I zoom out—when I situate where these flats are in the wider terrain of the city, when I view the kids relative to their peers in Singapore schools. Most importantly, I can see them clearly only when I suspend my internal narrative of Singapore and my own family biography as Third World to First, lower class to higher. I can see them clearly when I force myself to see both the pitfalls and the strengths of all circumstances—theirs and mine. And I can see them clearly only when I invert the naturalized hierarchy that structures our interactions—that I, a professor, is automatically superior to them who are cleaners, cashiers, drivers, laborers—and when I honestly ask: what are the pitfalls in their circumstances, and what are their strengths? What are the pitfalls of *my* circumstances? What are its lacks? What do the contrasts in our circumstances and ways of being tell us about the *systems* in which we find ourselves navigating decisions and building lives?

When we pose these questions, we are saying the problems at stake here are not just about 'them,' but also about 'us.' We disrupt the tendency to use the higher-income, higher-educated as the norm against which all persons are measured. We cast aspersions on standard, taken-for-granted aspirations—for credentials, for status, for wealth, for rankings—that are so regularly prescribed as universal and beyond question.

The point here is this: numerous qualities and values, which we presume to be 'good,' are neither neutral nor universal.

It is crucial to think and articulate this point repeatedly. The discussion of Third World to First, lower class to higher, presumes that a certain type of change is good, and that the changes we have experienced are necessary. The script of pathways through the life course in contemporary Singapore— school, employment, accumulation of savings, marriage, housing, kids, caregiving—

presumes a narrow set of middle-class practices and values as 'normal.' Normalcy here implies that the script is common sense, beyond question, and also normatively right. In discussions of poverty, even among well-meaning people, there is an underlying presumption that the lower-income's ways are inferior, their life pathways 'deviant,' their 'choices' bad, their 'cultures' problematic, and that the appropriate intervention is to get 'them' to behave more like 'us.'

There is insufficient attention to the fact that reward and punishment systems are not neutral. Not all qualities, skills, and capacities are equally valued in our society. Inadequate thought is given to the ways in which some of us set the standards against which others are measured.

Being able to sit still, take instruction from adults, spell English words accurately (even when they make no phonetic sense)—these are crucial for 'success' from day one in Primary 1; they are qualities that the wealthier among us spend money to cultivate in our children. In the big scheme of things, there is very little we can say to defend their *inherent* value. On the other hand, the generosity of neighbors, the capacity of children to do chores and care for siblings, the mutual dependence within extended families who show support for one another—these values and practices I see in abundance among low-income communities are not values that are actively promoted. This 'community' in the true senses of the word somehow do not meet KPIs.[10] In our system of rewards, their values do not translate into assets that lead to the material and symbolic upward flights of families and individuals. In our national narrative, these are not values that are legible, especially not when they are embodied by the lower-income.

When we insist that some behaviors should be rewarded, that is often because we have vested interests rather than because those qualities have inherent human worth.

In a city whose story to itself and to the outside world is one of rapid upward mobility, the people I have been meeting over the past few years are framed as 'left behind.' More importantly, since mobility is cast as an individual endeavor, they are also marked as losers in the game, people 'unable to keep up.' They are often stuck

in these positions by a confluence of educational credentials that do not open doors, jobs that are paid poorly, and care gaps that are not adequately addressed.

And so it is that we have not one city but multiple cities.

For people like myself, the city is full of promise— entertainment, safety, solid infrastructure, security, and mobility. For the low-income, it is a city of limited movement—their lives are characterized by physical hardship and a strong sense that they will go nowhere. The qualities they and their children have—of resilience, independence, and generosity—have little legitimacy and standing in this shiny global city.

The most common critique about meritocracy in Singapore is that it is not working as it should, that our problem is not with the principles embedded in the system but with implementation. Hence, a million and one tweaks to 'level up.' In sociological literature, meritocracy is widely recognized as a system for sorting, selecting, and then differentially rewarding people; it is a system for legitimizing the process and outcomes of sorting, based on narrow notions of what is worth rewarding and what is not. And it works well when there is, what Pierre Bourdieu referred to as "misrecognition."[11]

Misrecognition happens when we think that a system is based on a certain set of principles when it really works on the basis of another, when we think it rewards each individual's hard work when in reality it rewards economic and cultural capital passed on from parents to children. Where there is misrecognition of its real principles and mechanisms, meritocracy is a system that legitimizes those who end up its victors, casting them as individuals who have succeeded on their own hard work and intelligence rather than on any inherited unfair advantages. It is also a system that tells us a specific story about failures, casting those too as individual lacks rather than systemic disadvantages.

From a sociological point of view, meritocracy in Singapore is working exactly as it can. And it works very well in convincing us that we all—no matter where we are on the social hierarchy— deserve to be exactly where we are. Those who cannot get their children to have qualities *legible as merit* pay its price.

As inequality across society intensifies, we see that this is a price paid not just by the very low-income but also by people higher on the income spectrum, who recognize and fear that there is a lot to lose in even a little downward mobility. The tuition industry, the enrichment business, depression and anxiety among youth, the high degree of stress experienced by parents and the time wasted supervising homework—these too are costs to those higher on the income spectrum.

Individuals do not live on islands (even when we literally do!). We are connected through rich, complex, and intricate ties to others in society. What we do and do not do are shaped by our sense of how others are—shared understandings of right and wrong, good and bad, valuable and worthless. The pathways and practices we end up taking are rendered meaningful by shared scripts and narratives that permeate our society.

It is from our shared scripts and narratives that I come to have a strong sense of myself as a professor, and some of the respondents I meet come to have an inferior sense of themselves as cleaners. The everyday experiences we have of how people look at us, talk to us, treat us, invite or not invite us to partake in social life —these are the materials we draw on to craft our selves. When my educational credentials open doors and opportunities, when I am addressed as 'Prof' in every correspondence I receive, and given 'merit' increments annually, this adds to my sense of self-esteem as well as to my material wealth. When a low-income person goes to the Social Service Office and is asked numerous personal questions about their family lives or how $40 appeared on their bank account statement, or why they don't *just* get a better-paying job, this adds to their sense of themselves as inferior, unworthy, and excluded.

An Ethnography of Inequality

Inequality is often studied as an objective fact, a question of numbers. It is of course

that. But the numbers are derivative— they are drawn from patterns of social realities but do not fully describe the realities themselves. Inequality, as a social phenomenon, is experiential. It is a lived reality, felt in *everyone's* everyday lives. These lived experiences tell us important things about how inequality is enacted and everyday reproduced.

As a sociologist, I am interested in structure. What that means is that I am interested in how institutions, rules, regulations, shape what individuals can and cannot do. But the structural is not deterministic; it does not, on its own, drive history. Structural circumstances provide the scaffolding, but it is persons going through their everyday business who enact the daily practices. It is in these daily practices that we can understand the effects of structures.

My research began as one of poverty, of the low-income, of *them*. Over time, I have come to realize that the story I have uncovered is one of inequality, of relative wealth and poverty, of *us*.

It would be easier to write a book about poverty, to continue thinking about the problems at hand as ones that can be resolved by more attention to *them*. But it would be less honest. It would be poorer and less complete knowledge.

Why does this knowledge matter? Because how we see a problem, the questions we ask about it, shape our solutions. If we misrecognize our problems, we cannot be surprised when we cannot come up with solutions that solve.

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The study of poverty is not rocket science. What there is to know about it isn't so difficult to understand.

The study of poverty is not rocket science. What keeps us from understanding and appreciating it is not its empirical or theoretical complexity.

I say this not to mean that there is no research work to be done—there is a lot that we still need to learn through systematic and rigorous empirical work. I say this partly because I often hear people claim, "the problem is complex," and I wait in

vain for the rest of the sentence. So, what I'm saying is, yes it's complex, but really, not so complex that it's beyond our understanding.

Why am I inserting myself so much in what I write? This is not typical practice in academic writing. It is actually tremendously uncomfortable. I insert myself because as I get deeper and deeper into this research, I see that this is key to shifting our lenses for viewing inequality and poverty more fully.

The biggest barrier to understanding and appreciating inequality and poverty is in some ways myself, or rather, my social position and where I place in the Singaporean narrative. A big barrier to accepting the realities, the contours, the experiences, the undeniable *realness* of poverty and inequality in Singapore is ideological. And it is an ideological barrier that we share as a collective. It is an ideological barrier deeply embedded in our national narrative.

The biggest barrier to understanding poverty and inequality, for people with varying degrees of power, status, influence, is their, *our* vested material and symbolic interests in its perpetuation. We are so deeply implicated in our national and individual narratives of growth, development, and meritocracy, that we have trouble confronting and seeing stories that trouble these narratives.

Narratives are not bad things. We need to tell ourselves stories about ourselves, in order to understand our past, make meaning of the present, and aspire to the future. But when narratives are monolithic and singular, they become fortresses of vested interests, biases and blindspots.

To see better, we need to expand our narratives. We must uncover more data but also go beyond merely tracking statistical trends or documenting examples of hardship. An important goal to set for ourselves lies in changing the narrative—our national narrative *and* our internal biographical narratives. If we can do that—face up to how we are all implicated and entangled, confront how the narrative we hold onto upholds our own privileges at the same time that it maintains the disadvantages of some of our fellow residents in this country—then we can really begin talking about solutions.

When we shift the narrative, what would we do differently?

We would not ghettoize the problem of poverty—we would not think of it as a problem of the 'other,' that there are those who render 'help' and those who receive 'help.' We would talk about wealth every time we speak of poverty. We would insist that elitism and marginality are two sides of the same coin. We would stop being coy in speaking about exploitation, about the exercise of power in everyday lives. We would start to deal with the uncomfortable truth that when those of us with more do things that are the best for 'our' children, that we are also further solidifying the narrow definitions of merit and creating less space for children who have other qualities that are not legible in our system. We would not shy away from calling this a moral problem, an ethical issue. Importantly, we would look at our systems more broadly. Education and so-called meritocracy, welfare and so-called dependence—we would examine all of these, and we would think about how these need to shift in profound ways rather than repeatedly tweaked at their edges.

Poverty is not rocket science. Step 1 is to disrupt our narratives.

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2 For a very small subset of recent work on inequality and/or poverty, see OECD (2014); Piketty (2014); Inglehart (2016); Credit Suisse Research Institute (2014); Bourguignon (2016); Ostry, Berg and Tsangarides (2014); Development Finance International and Oxfam (2017); Stiglitz (2012); Amin (2013); Ferguson (2006); Garon (2002); Haney (2002); Kohl-Arenas (2015); Mullainathan and Shafir (2013); Standing (2011); Wacquant (2009); Prasad (2012); Ackerman, Alstott and Van Parijs (2006); Ehrenreich (2010); Sainath (1996); Edin and Kefalas (2011); Davis, Hirsch, Padley and Marshall (2015); Song (2009).

3 Ferguson (2006); Roy, Negrón-Gonzales, Opoku-Agyemang and Talwalker (2016); Sassen (2001).

4 Ng (2015).

5 Singapore Department of Statistics (2016).

6 Central Intelligence Agency (2017).

7 Note that official statistics exclude the large transient migrant worker population living in Singapore. In 2016, they number almost 1.7 million, or about 30% of the total population. If their incomes were taken into account, given that most are low-wage workers, then income inequality and poverty rates would probably be even higher.

8 Donaldson, Loh, Mudaliar, Kadir, Wu and Yeoh (2013); Smith, Mudaliar, Kadir and Yeoh (2015).

9 Bourdieu (1989); Karabel and Halsey (1977); Khan (2011).

10 Key Performance Indicators.

11 Bourdieu (1989); Bourdieu and Wacquant (1992).

Everyday Lives



Tilam airing. Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2013

Dreams: a room of one's own

PEOPLE IN PUBLIC RENTAL FLATS dream of moving out. They tell me about trying to accumulate money in their CPF[1] accounts and going to the HDB[2] to put themselves in a queue.

They speak about waiting and longing. Their dreams are modest: to have their kids grow up in neighborhoods that are safe; to give their kids bedrooms of their own. Their dreams are also morbid: to own a flat is to have a sense of security because if "anything should happen" to them (i.e. if they should die prematurely), their families won't be left homeless.

Their dreams of moving out tells us something about life in public rental flats. Although people point to liking aspects of their neighborhoods—nearness to markets or MRT stations, helpful neighbors—it is clear that a rental flat is not a place they want to stay in forever.

Stasis, which I talked about in the previous essay, is as undesirable to them as it is palpable to me. In contrast to people in Singapore who own their own homes and who intend to live in them for the rest of their natural lives, people in rental flats want to move out. It is therefore worth trying to understand what makes HDB rental flats and neighborhoods undesirable places.

Rental flats: the neighborhood

HDB rental flats are generally situated within regular neighborhoods rather than segregated as separate neighborhoods. The older ones tend to be in a cluster of three to five adjacent blocks, while the newer ones are single blocks among 'regular,' owneroccupied flats. In the older clusters, in particular, there is a feeling of being in a rental neighborhood. While it is not obvious to someone just passing by, it is known to residents who live in the general area which blocks are rental blocks. Tensions sometimes exist between owner-occupied blocks and rental blocks, particularly when it comes to the use of shared spaces like playgrounds and open courts.

If one is not paying attention, it is not immediately obvious when a block of flats is made up mostly or entirely of rental units. But once you start paying attention, there are a few clues observable from street level.

First, doors. The way to tell a block of rental flats is to look at the space between front doors. Rental flats are either so-called 1-room or 2-room HDB flats. This means they have either no separate bedroom or one bedroom respectively. 1-room flats have a living area, a kitchen, a bathroom; they have no separate bedroom; they are roughly 35 square meters. 2-room flats have a living area, a kitchen, a bathroom, and one bedroom; they are about 45 square meters. For comparison, HDB 4-room flats—the modal type of housing in Singapore[3]—are double the size at 90 square meters.[4] Each rental flat is thus relatively narrow and the doors in close proximity. Looking at the facade of a HDB rental block, one is struck by the high density of units.



A HDB rental block. Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2015.

High density is at the root of some key tensions among residents. When I ask people if they like their neighborhood, many of them start off by saying things are "ok." But when we chat more, I hear about the difficulties of living in close proximity to others. They lament that common areas are dirty; if they live near shared rubbish chutes, there are cockroaches and ants in abundance. In some blocks, bed bugs are a menace and they are hard to be rid of by any individual family because they spread from flat to flat. I see more neighborly mutual care here than in my own neighborhood but people also tell me they are careful not to "mix around" too much with neighbors for fear of gossip—close proximity makes for easy mutual surveillance, whether conscious or not, and people do not want to bring attention and/or embarrassment to themselves and their families. Single mothers, in particular, are especially careful to check their contact because they

"don't want gossip." These issues are not unique to rental flats, but the high density makes them far more intense than in less dense areas.

A second feature of rental flats that is striking is smells. Many rental blocks I have visited, particularly in older neighborhoods, have distinct and not entirely pleasant smells. It is difficult to say what the smells are of, but again high density is at play here. The smells are accompanied by the sight of trash in common areas—including abandoned mattresses and furnishings—and sometimes cat urine in stairwells. The limited space within flats means people need to air clothes, mattresses, and upholstery in corridors, and so damp textiles contribute to smells. One gets used to the smells and yet it never leaves one's consciousness entirely. When I first started my fieldwork, it was one of the most salient experiences of being in rental neighborhoods: my brain switched to fieldwork mode as the scents hit my nostrils; if I had spent some weeks away, the smells brought me back to the memories and feelings associated with that space and my work there. Taking the stairs, especially if there was cat pee, I found myself holding my breath as I walked past.

I do *not* think the trash/smell situation is there because rental-flat dwellers are inherently less capable of taking care of their environments. Around Singapore, there are high-density areas where a great deal of trash is generated. The reason many other areas remain clean is because there are many workers doing the work of cleaning up. The point that strikes me here about smells is this: going home to these smells is going into a space that is distinct, a little apart from other spaces in Singapore. Whether or not it is thought of consciously, when a rental flat resident goes home, she or he enters into a zone marked not only by the visual but also by something quite primal and physical.

I did not feel unsafe when I was doing my fieldwork. Admittedly, I was initially wary. In retrospect, that must have been because I too carried in my consciousness negative prejudices about low-income neighborhoods. As happens with unfair biases, they are forced to retreat when confronted with empirical realities and complexities. Once I met people who had been in prison or had gotten

in trouble with the law, they became full-fledged persons rather than caricatures. Quite apart from what I carried with me as preconceived notions about low-income persons, then, it was a third feature of rental neighborhoods that perpetuated a sense of insecurity and danger, distrust and surveillance: the presence of police, both literally and metaphorically. Compared to non-rental neighborhoods, one sees police cars and policemen in rental neighborhoods more frequently. Residents also tell me that there are always police as well as narcotics officers around. Signboards and posters in rental neighborhoods are also constant reminders of the dangers lurking and the proximity of one's everyday life to serious problems.



A poster alerting people to the dangers of illegal money-lenders in the neighborhood.



A signboard placed at the ground floor of a rental block where people have been harrassed by illegal money-lenders when they failed to repay their debts.
Photos by Teo You Yenn, 2013.

There are probably empirically-sound reasons that the police and these signboards and posters exist to a greater degree in rental neighborhoods than in other neighborhoods. Perhaps it is the case that there are more incidences that require police attention here than in other neighborhoods (although it also may be the case that it is easier to get caught for even minor transgressions here than in other neighborhoods precisely because of police presence). Nonetheless, one has to wonder if it is necessary to create such a palpable sense of danger and insecurity when the majority of this population are law-abiding citizens. More poignantly, we should also ask, if the signs that we see in our everyday lives contribute to our sense of who we are, and are indeed aimed at getting us to think about our behaviors and habits, what are the implications for people when the only message they are getting about who they are revolve around crimes and problems? For kids who grow up in

these neighborhoods, in particular, what are the effects of being surrounded by messages that remind them not to do this or that?

This struck me especially hard when, walking through a 'regular' neighborhood with visitors from the UK, one smilingly commented that there were so many uplifting messages all over the place. I laughed and said that yes, there are a lot of calls to be 'virtuous' in Singapore, and she exclaimed, "Yes! Virtuous!"

I had by then been taking photos of rental neighborhoods and had noticed the strong sense of negativity in the signage in rental areas. Her observation immediately brought to mind this contrast between rental neighborhoods and owner-occupied neighborhoods:





(left) A lift at a rental block. Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2015.
(Right) A lift at an owner-occupied block. Photo courtesy of Ng Kok Hoe, 2016.

On one side: don't (borrow from loan sharks). On the other: do (climb the stairs to good health!). On one hand: an ominous picture. On the other: an image of well-being. Residents in owner-occupied blocks do sometimes see loan shark posters on their lift doors as well, so these posters are not targeted *only* at rental flat residents. However, in my three years of fieldwork, I do not recall seeing anything other than "1800-X-AH-LONG"[5] as I waited for the lift to visit residents at rental blocks. In these neighborhoods, there was next to none of the cheerful virtuousness my friend from the UK observed.[6]

Insert a kid coming home from school every day and taking these lifts. Imagine yourself as this child. To grow up in a low-income rental flat is to be immersed

daily in an environment dominated by negatives.

Inside flats



Kitchen and laundry area in a 1-room flat.
Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2014.

There is, as one should expect, variation in how the interior of flats are maintained.

Some are sparse; some are cluttered; most are clean though some are dirty. Some residents take great pride in their homes: they keep them neat and beautifully decorated. Some are artistic and paint murals or use stencils to create patterns on their walls to brighten their small space.

Amidst this variation, all residents have to make do with very limited spaces for their families.[7] The lack of bedrooms mean that living rooms generally double up as sleeping areas. Many families maintain just a few pieces of furniture in the living areas because floor space is needed for sleep. Some people use tilam (mattresses) that can be folded and put away in the day and laid out at night; others use mats or sleep on the floor directly without any soft covering. In some cases, people have sofas that become beds at night. Very rarely do families have full-sized dining tables that seat the entire family at the same time. Where people have dining tables, these are big enough for just two or three at a time; quite frequently, they use folding tables. Where space is limited, being able to move things out of the way is important.

The furnishings people have reflect the excesses of Singapore society—some people with limited income have quite nice furniture because well-to-do Singaporeans throw out nice things that are still in reasonably good condition. In these cramped flats, then, I sometimes saw beautiful wood-carved chairs, fancy bed frames, and sofas that were clearly well-made before they were weather-worn. As social workers often point out, residents also frequently have flat-screen televisions.

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It is worth speaking explicitly about televisions. In Singapore and elsewhere, people regularly remark that low-income persons are perhaps not as poor as they claim to be or that they are making bad choices… because they have large-screen televisions. I heard this from social workers I interviewed and among people who volunteer for organizations that work with low-income families. It is a remark made in passing, often in light, joking ways rather than with serious thought or malice, along the

lines of "they have bigger TVs than me!" I too noticed that nearly every household I visited had a television, and that sometimes these televisions are quite large. There is a popular belief that low-income families buy appliances from furnishing/appliance chain stores and that they do so because there are installment plans. When people mention this, they are usually implying that people are not being prudent and living beyond their means. Some families do buy things on installment plans and as a result incur debt they find difficult to repay; it is, however, unfair to claim that they are being imprudent and more accurate to say that they cannot meet certain key needs with their incomes.

A common way in which families gather the things they need in their homes—televisions, fridges, sofas, beds, washing machines, study desks—is through donations and second-hand shops. People with money in Singapore buy new appliances and furnishings, upgrading to higher resolution televisions for example, before their existing sets break down. Numerous appliances and furnishings in the homes of people I visit are incongruent with their income levels. While some buy these things on installment plans, many made a point of pointing out: "this one is from [organization X]… that one [organization Y] gave me." Younger and more web-savvy people find things on online resale websites. People who have brought old clothes, furniture, or other items to places like the Salvation Army will know that things are piled up to the brim at places where donations are collected. Television sets, including large-screen televisions, then, tell us less about 'bad choices' by low-income households and more about our society of high consumption and wastage.

In 2017 Singapore, the television is not a luxury. It is a basic appliance that every household has; some households have more than one. When I visited low-income families, televisions were almost always on. It often remained on during my visits and our conversations, albeit turned to a lower volume. People generally do not have cable subscriptions, so they watch public channels, usually in Malay, Tamil, or Mandarin. In some households, people stream programs from the internet. The point is this: televisions play important roles in the everyday lives of

low-income persons, probably more so than those with higher income. Singapore is an expensive city. Going out involves money—children asking to buy things, paying for food, transportation, or entry fees to attractions. Parents worry about bad influences in the neighborhood. It is boring to be at home without toys and games, and with limited capacity to partake in other hobbies. Television is therefore especially important entertainment. After the fridge and washing machine (also often donated), a television set is probably the single most important piece of appliance in a low-income household.

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The smallness of flats and the desire to save electricity lead some residents to keep lights off and leave their main doors open when they are home. To maintain some privacy, they sometimes put up curtains or wood shutters. In my early field notes, I regularly noted these coverings of doorways.

One of the main reasons people dream of moving out is the desire for more space for their growing children. Individual, private space is difficult in flats so small. Where there is more than one child in the family, parents do not have rooms of their own, and children do not either. Many residents, particularly those with teenage daughters, come up with novel methods for creating some semblance of privacy. They hang curtains around the lower deck of double-decker beds. They use shelves or cupboards as walls. In a later essay, I describe how space and authority over kids are linked; for now, note that the lack of space can lead to some teenagers staying away from home, and relationships becoming tensed and fraught.

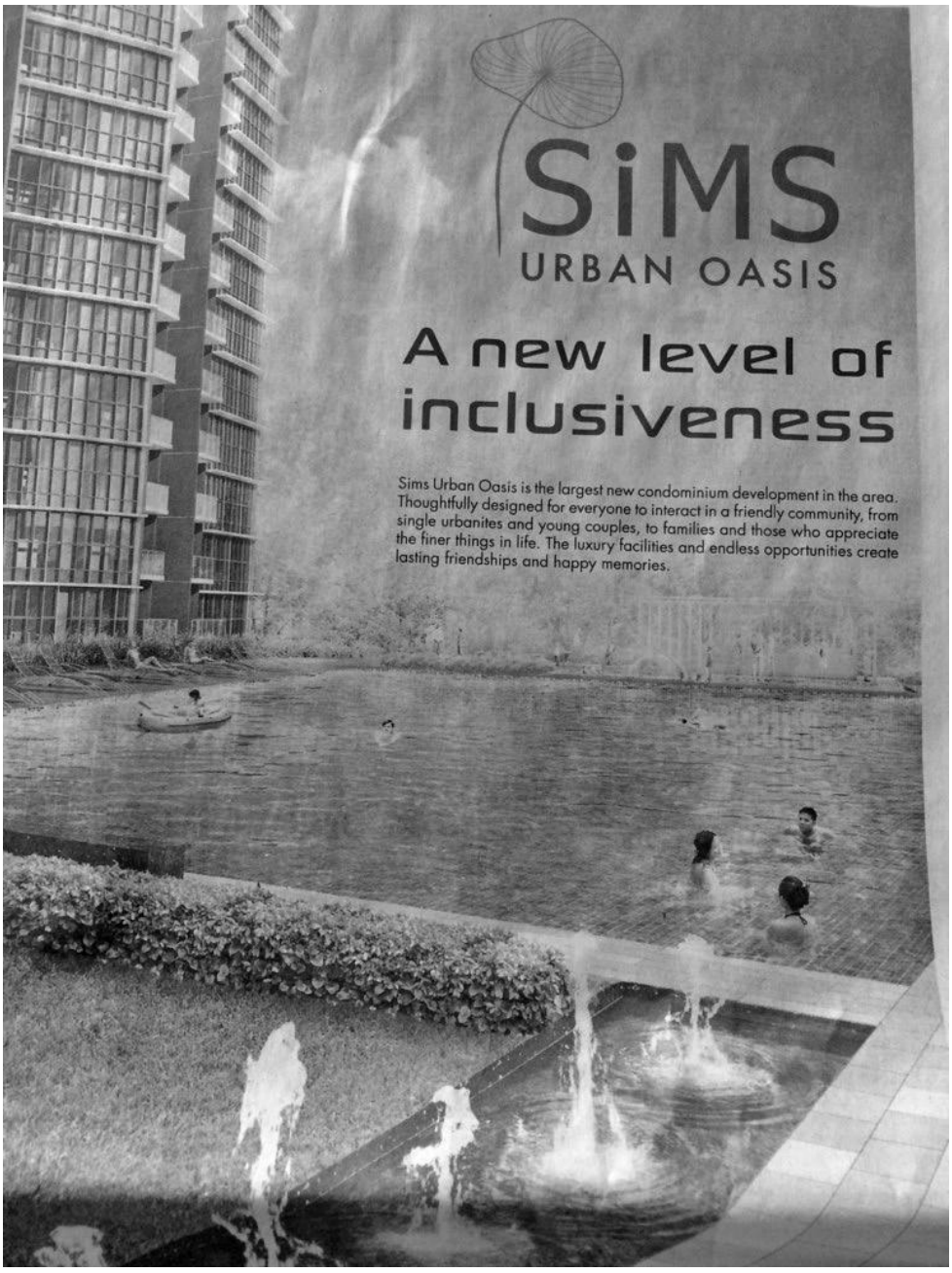
Individual space for keeping one's things is also limited. I saw mothers shouting at children, or telling me about shouting at their children, about packing up their things. Neatness becomes an important quality family members need to have, since so much space is used by everyone for multiple purposes. It also becomes a source of conflict and contestation within families. The limited space thus, counterintuitively, generates housework and stress.

The limitations of space within flats mean that there is some spillover of things to shared areas. Clothes, for example, are often dried on racks along the corridor. Shoe cabinets are common although, in some cases, people complain about shoes being stolen. Bicycles and kids' scooters are also parked along corridors, with similar attendant risks of theft. To understand why in rental neighborhoods, there tend to be more things left outside in common areas, one has to be mindful of space limitations within them.

When I was doing my fieldwork, visiting families in their homes, I was often surprised by what I experienced. The poor air circulation in some corridors of the older blocks created a claustrophobic, stifling atmosphere. When I was inside flats and if doors slammed shut as the wind blew, I would get the feeling of being trapped inside small and dark flats. In 2013, the haze hit Singapore with a vengeance—air quality was poor and it became our everyday reality to walk around with the smell of smoke in our nostrils and eyes stinging. I recall the sharp contrasts between the comfort of my air-conditioned office and the homes I visited.[8]

I was also surprised to meet people who have poor nutrition, who talk about how they sometimes ran out of money for food, of people who make choices about eating fewer meals so that their children could eat more. In my early fieldnotes, I expressed shock constantly. If transposed onto the lives of people in my own social milieu, many of the things I saw would be experienced as urgent crises. In the first months after I began the work, I could not stop talking about bed bugs. For my respondents, this and many other things were simply part of their everyday lives.

In context: what are needs and how are they social?



An advertisement for a (private) condominium, in a local newspaper.
Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2015.

People are highly adaptable creatures. While many dream of moving out, they

generally make do with what they have. They take steps to make their flats feel like home. For those who have experienced homelessness, having a place where they can sleep whenever they like, cook their own food, and feel safe is a step up.

When I tell people about my research, some people tell me: at least they are not homeless. This is true and by no means trivial. Nonetheless, to live in this environment is to be outside the norms of contemporary Singapore. Low-income persons who live in HDB rental flats have important unmet needs. To appreciate this, we have to situate these flats in the larger social context of contemporary Singapore.

The rental flats where my respondents live, and HDB rental flats in general, are surrounded by owner-occupied flats. These are bigger in size and hence less dense. In the common areas of corridors and void decks, particularly in older residential neighborhoods, there is a palpable difference between owner-occupied blocks and rental blocks. The former are cleaner, brighter, more spacious. A person living in a rental flat can see and recognizes daily that their homes are outside these norms.

Living in contemporary Singapore, we are surrounded by consumerism. Our environment is saturated with shopping malls, advertising, and people carrying branded objects—from backpacks to sneakers, handbags to mobile phones. A commute on the MRT[9] often begins and ends in a station connected to a shopping complex. A single mother once told me she is afraid to walk through a mall near her home—and which is connected to the nearest MRT station—because her six-year-old daughter will ask her to "buy this, buy that." To be embedded in a consumerist culture without money is to be constantly reminded of her inability to meet her child's desires.

Many people I meet work in the service sector. They clean homes, work as petrol kiosk attendants, are cleaners in hotels, malls, and condominiums, deliver food, move homes, work at cash registers. Daily, they are in contact with people with more money than them. While the low-income are often invisible to the higher-income in these spaces, the reverse is obviously not possible for the workers

whose jobs are to serve. Kids in low-income families sometimes follow their parents to work when their parents are stranded without alternative caregivers; I met a girl who follows her mom to her workplace, and her mom told me she described the swimming pool at a condominium to her father when they visited him in prison. To adults and kids alike, the sense of having less and being lesser is salient.

Norms exercise powerful influences. We like to think of ourselves as independent thinkers, as people who can decide what we want and just do it. The reality, as I have found both in earlier work and in current research, is that our notions about possibilities, desires, sense of self, are deeply shaped by the society in which we live. In Singapore, there is an extremely strong sense that there is a singular, 'normal' route in life: go to school, get educational credentials, secure a good job, accumulate CPF savings, meet a potential life partner, get in a queue to buy a HDB flat, pay for a housing loan with CPF accumulated from salary each month, register marriage, hold a wedding, move into a HDB flat, have two to three children, take care of elderly parents. These norms have come about as Singaporeans negotiate specific policy rules and regulations. They have been generated in the numerous interactions between various state agencies and actual persons. The interactions have been repeated so many times over so many years that people have come to understand and accept the process and the path as 'normal.' As middle-class Singaporeans informed me, this is the "normal Singaporean way" to be.[10]

Insofar as this version of life—of school, employment, family formation, household type—is framed as normal, low-income persons are cast as deviant. They are constantly reminded of this when they apply for HDB flats, when they apply for public aid, when they interact with social workers.

The HDB has no intention of evicting anyone. It is not easy to secure a rental flat but once a person does, he or she is in fact unlikely to be evicted. Astoundingly, I did not know this until fairly recently. In the three years when I was meeting people living in rental flats, the feeling I got *from them* about their housing situations is insecurity and instability. People talked about how their homes are not really their own; they worried about arrears on their rents; they spoke of wanting to

buy their own flats so that if something happens to them, their children will not become homeless. They also told me about seeing neighbors having their gates locked up and their things removed from their flats. A few showed me letters they received after not paying rent for many months; when I read them, they sounded like eviction letters. I met staff from the HDB who were genuinely surprised when I told them what I heard about people's feelings of insecurity. To them, from where they stand, they have no intention of creating homelessness. Why, given that the HDB does not intend to evict people, do rental flat dwellers speak so persistently of insecurity?

The answer goes back to context. First, experiences and the witnessing of homelessness. Second, experiences of rules, processes, renewals. Third, normative beliefs about ownership.

Why do we feel what we feel, and believe what we believe? Concrete experiences of the world, what we see around us, shape our feelings and beliefs.

For the people I met, homelessness is not a far-removed, abstract concept.[11] Many have experienced it in some form in their own lives: some have lived in a tent at a park or in a parked car; others have had to live with relatives; some have had to move from place to place as they outstayed their welcome in different relatives' homes; many have housed family members who move from place to place as circumstances—of family, of employment, of health—shift. One woman described to me how relieved she was to finally secure her own rental flat. For years, she slept in the living room of a shelter flat her parents were in. Because that flat was shared with another family, she had to find a time to sleep when others would not be around and she would not be embarrassed about how she, a woman, looked while she slept. When one's life experiences has been of moving from place to place, when housing has not been the one constant, they carry with them feelings of insecurity as long as they are in a rental flat. Given their life experiences, it is irrational to presume security.

Although the HDB has no intention of making anyone homeless, its processes are not experienced that way. On a regular basis,[12] tenants have to go through

renewal. Documents, particularly pertaining to income from employment, have to be submitted. If income increases, so does rent. Several people I met complained about this: they work hard, try to get better pay, but this disappears immediately into increased rent. The frequent renewal process makes people feel that their housing circumstances are contingent rather than guaranteed. When they have arrears, which many do, the letters they receive intensifies their anxiety and sense of insecurity.

The ubiquity of housing ownership in Singapore means that there is a widespread belief that real security can only come about from home ownership. This is probably not entirely true, but people believe it. The housing system and market indeed relies on people sharing this belief. Although many of the people I meet may never be able to afford their own flats, they too are part of this society and share these societal norms and beliefs.

In a city with one of the highest per capita incomes in the world, there are people living in the conditions I have described. Their flats are too small for separate bedrooms for parents and kids; they worry about becoming homeless; they run out of cash at some point every month; they live in spaces so dense that trash and bed bugs are perennial problems; their main mode of entertainment is the TV; they are reminded daily that their neighborhoods are dangerous; they don't turn the lights on because they want to save money; they boil water their kids need for warm showers; their flats are filled with the castaways of the wealthy.

We must fit into this same picture the Singapore of shiny malls, luxury cars, iPhones, and Louis Vuitton bags; the Singapore as 'highly livable city,' with top-ranked Pisa scores, best universities in Asia, highest rates of home ownership. The conditions in rental flats are deprivation, insecurity, and undignified because these too are the everyday realities of life in Singapore.



Name this city. Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2016.

Describing low-income neighborhoods in American and European cities, Loïc Wacquant argues that 'territorial stigmatization' has immense negative effects on how people feel and behave.[13] When a space is stigmatized—and marked as such as by its disrepair, by the pervasiveness of messages signaling the failures of its residents, and by the scarcity of key institutional resources— its residents develop coping mechanisms of mutual distancing and lateral denigration, retreat into the private sphere, and flee from the neighborhood whenever possible. The exceptionality of a neighborhood from the larger norms of a city harms local community ties and residents' feelings about their social worth.

Rental flats for low-income persons in Singapore are not ghettoized spaces in the extreme ways that low-income housing often is in other cities. There are also no slums. In terms of access to clean water, electricity, amenities, and transportation, the people I meet are not denied access to these things in any absolute or physical

way. Nonetheless, the spaces they are in are uncomfortable. Importantly, these spaces place them outside of norms.

How we sleep, where we wake, how water from the shower feels against our skin, how hungry or full our stomachs feel, the things we argue over daily, what we see when we leave our homes, what we smell when we get back. It may be true that looking from afar, Singapore does not have the housing problems that other cities do. But people don't live as if they are looking from afar or above.

We live everyday, bodily realities. Inequality is experienced in the interior of hours and minutes of a day.

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1 Central Provident Fund.

2 Housing & Development Board.

3 Singapore Department of Statistics (2016).

4 Housing & Development Board (2016).

5 "Ah Long" is a Hokkien term referring to loan sharks.

6 In 2016, when I shared these observations with some HDB staff, I got the sense that they had not given much thought to this contrast in signs. Once I pointed it out, they too could see its significance.

7 In a recent survey of HDB rental flats, Ng Kok Hoe found that adults and their children together make up the most common household type and that a quarter of all rental households have four or more household members. See Ng (2017).

8 As sociologists have shown, natural disasters and environmental degradation are not equal-opportunity phenomena. See, for example, Somers (2008); Klinenberg (2015).

9 Mass Rapid Transit.

10 Teo (2011).

11 In a recent street survey, a group of social workers and volunteers counted, in just a single night and at 25 sites, 180 persons sleeping outside. See Neo and Ng (2017); Paulo and Goh (2017); Kok (2017). Homelessness may not be as prevalent in Singapore as in some other cities, but it is a problem for some. Many residents of public rental flats have firsthand knowledge and/or experience of this.

12 Under the Public Rental Scheme, tenancies are renewed every two years. In households where all residents are 60 years and older, tenancies are renewed every three years. Under HDB's Interim Rental Housing Scheme, tenancies were renewed on a six-monthly basis from 2009-2011, and on an annual basis beginning in 2011.

13 Wacquant (2010); Wacquant (2016).

Work-Life Balance
Should Not Be Class Privilege

I BEGIN THIS ESSAY with the story of Nana. When we first met in 2014, she was working as a salesperson at a women's accessories shop. Nana wears impeccable, understated makeup, and has a warm, friendly, and open demeanor. All these are characteristics that make her effective at her sales job. She was 37 years old when we first met and had three children ages 12, 10 and 7. Because she had a very busy life, we spoke over several times at her work place, standing at the cash register when business was slow.

Our conversation started off with her telling me she wishes she could pay for private tuition for her kids. They were not doing well in school—the older two were failing in Mathematics. Like many parents in Singapore today, she finds the homework much more difficult than when she was a student. She is unable to help her kids directly. After finding out how much tuition would cost, she knows she cannot afford it for all of them. Like other working parents, she and her kids talk on the phone during the afternoons when they get home from school and she is at work; she calls to find out if they have taken their lunch and reminds them to do their homework.

After I witnessed one such phone call, she told me how worried she is that they are unable to keep up in school. Her mother is helping to watch her children while she and her husband are at work; this is a major source of comfort to her. Many other people I spoke with are unable to count on a stable source of care such as this. Still, even with her mother's help, she often feels like not everyone is cared for as well as she likes. Her youngest was just entering primary school and having problems adjusting to the new environment. Because of her work, Nana could not accompany her in school even though the school allowed this during certain times of the day. She felt guilty, especially since her daughter noticed some of her classmates' mothers there.

Maintaining paid work is very important for the well-being of her family, so she cannot jeopardize her job. Aside from her three children, she is also supporting her 70-year-old mother. Her husband's work has not been stable for a number of years. He was in a good blue-collar profession in the past, but a serious injury sustained at the workplace prevented him from continuing. It was after he lost that job that the family spiraled downward. Her eyes teared up a number of times when she described to me the dark days following his loss of regular employment and income. They lost their flat and moved from one relative to another relative's home. Each time, tensions eventually arose.

For a time, they stayed in an interim rental flat. Conditions there were terrible —there was no proper flooring, no gate,[1] and they had to share the 2-bedroom flat with another family. The bathroom floor was "so disgusting" her children refused to enter without slippers on. They were eventually evicted when they were unable to pay the rent. They ended up staying in a rented van. They would park at a beach park every night. There, her husband would sleep in the front seat while she, together with her three children and mother, slept in the back. Police officers sometimes came by to ask them what they were doing in the van, and they had to lie that they were there to go fishing.

These were terrifying and stressful times. She worried that her children would be taken away from her. In the mornings, she would take them to the public bathroom. They would shower in cold water at 4am, before going to school. Nana worked in a trendy women's clothing chain store at the time, and still had to show up at work looking neat and coifed. Some of her co-workers knew that she was facing difficult times and showed her kindness—giving her food to bring to her kids. But she was also made to feel bad when others gossiped about her and made comments about how "Nana always has problems." She talked about how she and her mother would often "fast" during this time. Her children did not complain, but they became skinnier.

There was no bitterness in the way Nana recounted her experiences. Instead, she often highlighted the kindness of people who helped her family—a security

guard who let them rent his flat after learning they lived in a van; co-workers who gave her food for her kids; her mother's friend who let her bring clothes to iron at her flat every few days.

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Nana's story is not unusual. In three years, I heard numerous life stories with variations in details but similarities in themes. Juxtaposed against what we know and imagine about Singapore, the stories are jarring. Homelessness, hunger, cold showers at 4am in public bathrooms—these are not what we think of when we think of Singapore.

To be surprised, however, is not the point. The more I heard these stories, the more I saw that the people I was speaking to were not so different from me. Across our class divide, I shared with my respondents a social context in which parenting has become a somewhat lonesome activity—limited to the confines of the nuclear family household. For them as for me, parenting is done under intense time pressure, and the pursuit of wage work is the main competitor for time and energy.[2] We share, finally, an urgent sense that our main responsibility as parents is to ensure our children's success in school. This stems from our recognition that academic success is linked to job prospects and that well-being in Singapore is dependent on getting a job with good income.

It is precisely on each of these common needs that we also find our circumstances diverging: when I spoke with low-income parents, I noticed the multiple ways in which our different material circumstances led to variant strategies for mitigating each of these challenges.

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It is not difficult to talk to strangers once you mention children. Asking a simple question—how are your kids?—clears away barriers and opens up conversations. One major finding in my research is worth stating explicitly from the get-go:

children are at the center of people's lives, identities, efforts, and decisions. As parents manage tight finances and challenging conditions, children are their top priority.

When I transition from a researcher to a member of my social circles, I find this to be similar: parents spend huge amounts of time thinking, talking, and worrying about their children. As I move from trespasser in respondents' homes and neighborhoods to inhabitant in my own, in the two classed worlds, images of parents' hopes and children's habits merge and diverge. The figures of caregivers and wage-earners—mothers, grandmothers, neighbors, domestic workers, fathers, older siblings or cousins, childcare teachers, social workers—intersect and yet form distinct patterns. Across class divides, we face similar human needs for care and dignity. Yet, we regularly fulfill these needs differently. The rest of this essay addresses the questions of how and why.

This is what parenting looks like

For people with children 6 years old and younger, everyday life is hectic. Younger children need constant adult presence or supervision. They need care on all fronts—from cleaning to feeding to dressing to helping them move about. Keeping children alive and healthy is a round-the-clock task.

Unsurprisingly, when I speak to parents with young children, the need for someone to be around who can do this intensive caring and supervision is the precondition to everything. In order to do wage work, to go to the market or run other errands, to bring older children to places they need to be at, to attend community activities, mothers (and occasionally fathers) talk about how they must either have someone to take care of their children while they do the task, or be able to bring their children along with them. This precondition becomes even clearer to me when, walking around the neighborhoods where I was conducting my research, I run into people I had become familiar with: adults are flanked by children as they

go to pick up a few things at nearby shops or to the post office; older children (sometimes themselves as young as 8) are holding the hands of their younger siblings while their parents are at work or out running errands. Some mothers who work as cleaners in private households on ad-hoc bases bring their children along with them if they are working during after-school hours or when children are too sick to go to childcare centers or kindergartens.

For parents (most commonly, mothers) with very young children, everyday life is therefore relentlessly busy. Yet, it is not immediately obvious what labor these parents do on an everyday basis.

Middle-class housewives will be familiar with this feeling: when called to account for their days, they are often left with little to report. Days spent on household chores and with young children is time spent doing "this and that." Parents who are in full-time employment—both women and men—often wonder aloud what women who aren't employed are doing all day. After all, we too are caring for our children, doing some housework, running errands, and managing schedules. With our pride as parents, and especially as mothers, at stake, we are loath to admit that there are many hours in the day when we are not at home and hence numerous everyday activities that someone else—usually other women—are doing, ostensibly on our behalf. If women *and men* who pay for housework and care labor— whether in the form of live-in domestic workers, part-time cleaners, hourly babysitters, or even laundry and food delivery services—honestly and fully account for the labor that goes into the upkeep of households and the care of children, we will get a more accurate sense of the vast amount of time and energies that go into the reproduction of everyday existence and well-being.[3]

Persons with limited income do not outsource any of this household and care labor. Neighbors and extended family members form important support systems. Often low-income themselves, however, they have their own stresses and challenges to bear, and so the support they provide is often unstable.

Being low-income also means spending more time and energy on certain tasks: more frequent trips to the market since stocking up requires cash they do not have;

regular trips to the post office to top up cash cards to pre-pay for utilities, since past arrears mean they are no longer allowed to pay at the end of each month; trips to pay bills that people with more money avoid by using internet banking or pre-scheduled bank deductions; meetings with social workers or teachers.

When I speak with parents with young children, I frequently notice their stress. Money is tight. Many talk about wanting to find more income through wage work. But they are held back because it is difficult to secure a 'good' job, where 'good' means a job with hours that would allow them to also take care of cooking, cleaning, and children; where 'good' implies sufficient stability *and* flexibility so that they do not have to scramble to figure out who will care for their children; where 'good' means that any potential wages actually make them better off rather than keep them at about the same place given the opportunity costs involved.

Finding reliable care for children who need a great deal of it is difficult when paid caregivers are not an option. The main form of childcare parents from low-income households can secure are in government-linked childcare centers. It is here that state subsidies make fees low enough to afford. On the whole, this option is a great deal more accessible now compared to a decade ago. Yet, several challenges remain. First, to qualify for full subsidies, mothers have to be employed. This is a circular problem: without help with childcare, women are not able to find time to secure stable employment; without stable employment, they are not able to secure enrollment in childcare centers.[4] Second, there are issues with location. While the total number of childcare spaces in Singapore exceed demand, these are not always located where parents need them to be. For low-income parents, enrollment in childcare centers within walking distance of their homes is crucial. For one thing, they need to save on costs of transportation. But a less obvious reason, at least to middle-class eyes, is that proximity allows for other people—neighbors, older kids—to help pick younger children up while parents are still at work.

Importantly, even with childcare, employment is still hard to maintain because care gaps—either daily or cyclical—persist. Daily gaps appear insofar as center hours may not coincide with work hours. Dropping children off is not usually a

problem, but picking them up by the time centers close (typically 7pm) is challenging. For people doing night shifts, childcare centers certainly do not fully address needs of care. Weekends, too, pose challenges. I met parents who have to leave young children at home on their own when they go to work; this creates enormous anxieties and they are unable to fully focus at work. A woman told me about having to finally quit her job for a reason that people with various care options will find hard to imagine: her 10-year-old son could walk home alone but could not manage to open the very sticky door lock; even as a care gap is unsatisfactorily resolved (a 10-year-old being home alone), another one emerges (the child cannot enter the flat).

In addition, there are also cyclical and relatively regular emergencies. Young children, particularly when they first begin at childcare centers, fall sick easily. Center policies regarding illness are understandably strict. Hence, there are frequently days when children need to be kept at home. My own child, in the first year at a childcare center, had to stay away from childcare two to three days every three weeks or so. Low-wage workers tend to have very limited leverage vis-à-vis their employers when it comes to rearranging work schedules or taking time off. They are also in jobs where working from home is almost never an option. Having to miss work to take care of emergencies often causes stress and is a reason people decide they have no choice but to quit their jobs. This happens when bosses give them a hard time, but even when bosses are understanding, people feel guilty for not being good employees or for making things difficult for their co-workers who have to do more when they are unable to show up at the last minute. Even with childcare centers, then, maintaining employment is tricky.

If children are in kindergartens rather than childcare centers, long school holidays—one week each in March and September; four weeks in June; and six weeks in November and December— bring about new challenges for maintaining wage work. Unlike children in higher-income households, who can be enrolled in holiday camps and/or have paid caregivers to fill care gaps, school holidays in low-income households are major disruptions.

As children grow older and become more competent in everyday tasks, certain pressures subside. In general, by the time they are 7 years old or so, they do not need to be closely monitored at all times: they become better at managing risks to their well-being such as falling and hurting themselves; they are able to use the bathroom on their own, shower and feed themselves, and to some extent, take care of their own belongings. Children in low-income households, in fact, are far more competent at each of these compared to their counterparts in higher-income households. New challenges, however, emerge at this age. In contrast to younger children who can be enrolled in all-day childcare centers, primary school is only half-day. There are no provisions for meals or showers during the day. In this sense, parents with children who transition from childcare centers to primary school find themselves faced with new care gaps, as well as new financial costs.

Over the past few years, more after-school Student Care Centers have been set up. At present, however, many parents speak of not being able to secure spaces in the facilities at their children's schools. The extra logistics and costs involved in centers outside of school (e.g. school bus) are high. Importantly, Student Care is typically organized too much like school. They have rigid schedules, limited space for children to freely play, and are focused on getting children to do their school work. While parents often think this is good—because they want their children to cultivate homework routines and habits—children themselves are sometimes resistant. As caregivers of children will know, when children are resistant, they bring emotional distress to the daily lives of adults. They can cry daily over the same issue; they are capable of throwing tantrums or pleading; they regress on tasks that they were able to do before. Children have their own preferences and wills, and it is not easy (nor desirable) to ignore these. In abstract discussions of policy and childcare support, this issue does not get raised. What I have found in listening to parents talk about their kids is that the issue of children's happiness is very often a high priority and a key reason why women give up wage work. Parents—regardless of class backgrounds—want to find caregivers and care arrangements that make their children comfortable and happy, and whom/which they can trust. Indeed, minor,

one-time incidents can create unhappiness for a child and cause people to doubt the value of a caregiver or caregiving facility. Although the alternative of not having wage work means greater discomfort for low-income families, it is often, taking into account the big picture of children's well-being, the better option.

Finally, an important care gap that emerges for younger children relates to schoolwork and academic results. In Singapore today, we often hear of highly-educated women quitting their jobs or taking extended time off wage work in order to supervise children during the PSLE[5] year. We know very well the pressures children face, and parents feel, when it comes to examinations. Among my respondents, I heard mothers talk about quitting their jobs because children were failing weekly spelling tests and/or teachers were calling them up regularly to speak to them about their kids' problems with school work. Many of the parents I meet are not themselves highly educated. They have trouble helping children with school work. Nonetheless, they feel they must do something. When they are not around, things are worse because children do not do their homework at all. Although they cannot help with the actual work, they can supervise and nag.

When low-income persons seek public assistance, they are regularly told: "put your children in childcare/student care and get a job." In the abstract, it is hard to quibble with this advice. But once we take into account the detailed picture—poor quality wage work (low pay, lack of control over schedules, high stress); regular and persistent care gaps; children's happiness and well-being; the intensity of school work and the huge importance accorded to school examinations—we see more clearly why many women in low-income circumstances decide against employment. Their children, like children from higher-income households, need reliable, trustworthy caregivers. They, like parents with more means, have aspirations for children and want them to be the best they can be.

Wage work and care responsibilities—you can't talk

about one without talking about the other

In the past few years, I have spent many afternoons in people's homes. When I visit, the door is almost always left open. The television is often on. As we chat, people wander in and out of the flats. Neighbors who walk by wave and nod. Children go out to the corridor to look for their friends, and kids cycle or scoot up and down corridors, avoiding shoes and plants as they zoom by. Neighbors sometimes stop by with food; people mention their kids being picked up by friends, relatives, or neighbors. One gets the sense, in these neighborhoods, that rich social ties exist, in ways that seem to be thicker than in wealthier ones. I witnessed in these spaces warmth and generosity that made a deep impression on me: people lending money to others even when they are short themselves; neighbors sharing food when they themselves sometimes go hungry; mothers picking up from school not just their own but also their neighbors' children.

Yet, despite this generosity, care gaps remain. Why? The reason is fairly straightforward: people's social ties are often with others of similar class background. Despite the interdependence and generosity, everyone faces challenges. They have their own children to care for, bills to pay, jobs to manage. In middle-class Singapore, we hear of 'typical' ways to take care of children, one being 'maid plus mother/mother-in-law.'[6] For people with limited means, these are options that play out differently. Grandmothers, aunts, cousins, sisters, sisters-in-law are often caregivers. But they often have responsibilities of their own, so even when they do help with caregiving, there is a degree of instability and irregularity over time. The gaps that people with more means can plug by having paid caregivers—grandmothers often work in tandem with domestic workers in high-income households, for example—are left unfilled here.

At the center of the problem of care gaps is the quality of wage work, and more specifically, the poor quality of low-wage work in Singapore.

As a feminist scholar, I am inclined to point to the benefits of employment for

women. Having wages improves women's position in households. Jobs and careers bring respect, autonomy, and decision-making powers to women. Indeed, many women I spoke with told me that when they have some money of their own, they can make choices about buying things for their kids or themselves, and this brings them immense satisfaction. Yet, over the past years, I have also seen how the benefits of employment are not always experienced by women in low-income households— at least not in significant enough degrees to outweigh the costs they face when their children are not adequately cared for.

One main problem here is this: the way issues of employment and care responsibilities are typically framed is class-biased. As a society, we have thus far failed to look closely at the quality of employment for low-wage workers and how the ways in which we talk about 'work-life balance' is class-blind in a way their realities are not. This is not merely discursive. These failures to consider and systematically address through public policy what families in different class positions need have resulted in failures to acknowledge and resolve the huge care gaps for low-income families.

A comparative lens is instructive here. Contrasting the conditions of my employment with those of my respondents, we see stark differences. First, where I can expect to work from Mondays to Fridays most weeks, and during regular office hours, many low-wage workers work shifts that change every so often and are not guaranteed a fixed number of hours of work. For example, they may work a certain number of night shifts and then be given a day shift; or they may have a certain number of days of work one week and then a different number another week. They often do not know of their schedules until a week before they are expected to abide by them. This unpredictability and irregularity makes it difficult to plan for caregiving needs. A great deal of energy, then, is spent *thinking* about how to resolve their children's needs for care. What they face on a regular basis is what happens for me during school holidays: a good part of my mental energies is expended on planning what I will do with my child. I have many advantages: flexibility in my work schedule (I can work at night or weekends at home); a partner and co-parent

whose job is also flexible; a trusted and reliable babysitter (whom we can afford to employ); parents who can be called on to help at any time; money to pay for holiday camps. And yet, it still takes up a great deal of time and energy. Much of this labor involves coordinating with various parties, as well as negotiation with the people involved. Doing shift work, and having to deal with changes in shifts creates extra labor in organizing caregiving. It is labor that people do not have to worry about if their work is regular.

Schedules that change are like so many leaks from a roof— you plug one and another emerges. We should not underestimate the time and energy it takes to plug leaks, as well as the stress it exerts on people.

Related to this is the notion of 'mastery' over time.[7] Not only are their employment hours irregular, they are also unpredictable and subjected to employer demands. As scholars have pointed out, flexible labor is flexible primarily for employers rather than for employees.[8] This is not a phenomenon limited to low-wage workers but it *is* particularly endemic among them. Irregularity and unpredictability, as Dan Clawson and Naomi Gerstel argue, tend to go together. Workers in low-wage jobs are often expected to be flexible in taking on unplanned shifts. They have little to no leverage and virtually no bargaining power. Without paid care labor to rely on, my respondents have to scramble to ask neighbors to help, get older children to stand in for them, or leave children alone at home without adult supervision. These conditions are largely invisible to people whose jobs are regular and predictable.

We have to start talking about the conditions of low-wage employment. They are key to understanding how much more difficult work-life 'balance' is when one's access to wage work is limited to irregular and unpredictable work.

It is important too, to recognize the significance of both formal and substantive rights. Low-wage employment does poorly on both.

Many low-wage workers are contract workers rather than permanent staff. This means they have limited or no leave benefits and that they are paid only for the specific hours they are at the workplace. Even among permanent workers, benefits

such as paid time off or healthcare tend to be commensurate with pay-scale level, such that low-wage workers have low levels of benefits.

In addition to these formal differences, there are also important differences when it comes to the *substantive* execution of rights. At my job, I get respect. I never doubt that I have the right to take time off to deal with life's needs. I expect my colleagues to understand. I do not worry about having my pay deducted, being reprimanded or otherwise punished for missing a few days of work here and there. My confidence that no one will fault me is important for shaping how I behave and how well I am able to deal with my needs. As a study in the Netherlands demonstrates, understanding bosses and co-workers set the tone for what are reasonable and expected practices at the workplace.[9]

Low-wage workers do not generally face the same set of conditions when they need to attend to family needs. Even if formal rights exist, substantive ones often do not. The reality of low-wage work is that workers feel insecure and powerless. They are afraid to ask for time off to take care of their families' needs. They worry about supervisors being irritated with them. They know from experience that they must strategize to avoid getting scolded by bosses or losing jobs that they need. In my conversations with low-income persons, fear and anxiety about asking for time off looms large. Their past encounters with supervisors, with bosses, have informed them that they *should* fear, they *should* be anxious. One woman, for example, told me about filming her child being sick and hospitalized because she felt she needed this video evidence to ask for a few weeks off. The absurdity of this is apparent when I think about the many times my child has been sick and I took time off without the slightest pause. That I might have to first prove I wasn't lying is beyond contemplation.

There are two key prejudices about people who are low-income: first, that they have different 'values' and 'mindsets'—particularly with regard to work ethic and parenting. There is a belief that low-income persons have a tendency to make 'bad choices' that perpetuate their poor conditions, particularly when it comes to

parenting.[10] Second, that they have a tendency to avoid employment and become reliant on state support. Here, the belief is perpetuated through public policies that place 'dependence' front and center as that which is to be avoided.[11] Both of these prejudices are empirically inaccurate and profoundly damaging.

Children and their care stand at the center of the lives of the people I met. All other practices and decisions—wage work, leisure, expenditure—are linked to what parents think would be best for their kids. All parents, regardless of class, are imperfect. And of course, within any class, there are variations in parent-child relationships. But, over the years, I have been struck by the degree to which low-income parents have to sacrifice their own comfort and well-being to an extent far more intense than parents with more means. In talking about their everyday lives, people reveal how little they sleep and how much they work (whether wage work, care work, or housework); they speak without resentment about forgoing their own needs—such as new clothing for festivals or even meals—so that their children's needs can be met first; in their furrowed brows and helpless shrugs, and in the occasional stories of people giving up and spiraling into despair, I saw the costs these sacrifices exacted on their mental and physical well-being.

Low-income parents do not necessarily make more 'bad choices' than parents with higher income, but more of their practices turn out to have negative outcomes. It is more accurate to say that they have bad options for managing the need for money and the need of their kids for care. Their poor employment conditions are central to this. The lack of continuous and unconditional public support for care is another. These two things should make us rethink our prejudices.

Work-life balance should not be a class privilege

In 2012, Anne-Marie Slaughter launched intense debates when her article, 'Why Women Still Can't Have It All,' appeared in *The Atlantic*.[12] Slaughter hit a nerve by pointing out that the many conditions women face, at work and at home, make it

impossible for women to fully "have it all"—where "all" entails marriage, children, and high-powered careers. She proposed changing these circumstances through increasing the number of women in government and through the gender-sensitive policy-making that would follow. She argued that policies in the workplace have to shift to really accommodate demands of both work and home.

Though written for a North American audience, Slaughter's article was widely read and discussed in Singapore. In fact, in May 2014, an auditorium packed with academics, civil servants, and corporate leaders warmly received her at the Singapore Management University. I know because I too was there, eager to hear her. Slaughter's arguments and proposed solutions found enthusiastic support. That work-life balance requires corporations to allow for flexible work schedules and career trajectories was especially salient.

After the article was published and went viral, Tressie McMillan Cottom[13] eloquently countered that Slaughter's article is problematic not because it is wrong, but because it represents a limited sliver of women's experiences. Specifically, by focusing mostly on corporations and careers, it obscures the lived realities of women who are neither ethnoracially dominant nor class-privileged. Cottom also argues that in Slaughter's prescriptions for resolution, she too quickly presumes that (white, upper-class) women in power would be the solution to these particular problems, that there would be trickle-down effects from women with relative power to those with less.

At a more general level, Nancy Fraser[14] critiques the trend of privileging individual choice, autonomy, and career advancement, arguing that this approach abandons the goals of earlier feminist movements for greater social justice, solidarity, and participatory democracy. By focusing primarily on what *individual* women can do to improve their own situations, this mode of thinking about women's advancement fails to critique, and ultimately serves to legitimize, the undemocratic and exploitative tendencies of neoliberal capitalism.

Cottom and Fraser each remind us that when problems are framed in particular ways, conversations generally stay within the framework.

Slaughter's warm reception in Singapore, by a class-privileged audience, is not surprising. Much of what she had to say resonates with existing discourses about work-life balance: corporations can do more and men must step up. These are not unimportant points, but this framing implicitly presumes that people have careers (versus jobs) and that families live in married-twoparent-dual-career households. To her credit, Anne-Marie Slaughter, in response to critiques of her article, subsequently wrote a book that directly acknowledges inequalities *among* women.[15] Nonetheless, the tendency to universalize from the experiences of the (upper-) middle class persist.

Middle-class biases are not inherently problematic. These, too, are real people's lives and problems. It is true that in middle-to-high income heteronormative families, women bear far heavier burdens of care work and household responsibilities than their husbands. It is true that workplace policies and men's behaviors have yet to change in significant enough ways to correct the imbalance. And I should note here that if we look even more closely, middle-income families have quite different struggles compared to high-income families. It is worth paying attention to the varied challenges faced by *all kinds of* families when it comes to work-life balance.

I am pointing out, nonetheless, that middle-class biases and this universalizing tendency are endemic to public discussions about work-life balance and that this is problematic. Historically, the pursuit of migrant domestic workers as the resolution to demands for housekeeping and care labor has meant that domestic work has become more devalued and invisible. Since the 1980s, the main solution to care needs in Singapore has been migrant domestic workers who work in individual households. The early rationale of this public policy was that it would allow Singaporean women, particularly higher-educated, professional women, to participate in employment while domestic workers cared for their children. Over the past decades, the number of domestic workers has increased from 40,000 in 1988 to 239,800 in 2016. As the population ages, public policy also supports this mode of care for older persons.

The strong assumption implicit in public discourse that people have 'maids' limits how people—particularly those in positions of influence—think about the issue of 'balance.' The amount and complexity of labor that goes into creating work-life balance in situations of poor wage-work conditions and without any paid care work is rarely discussed.

We cannot forget that there has been an ugly history of class bifurcation and eugenics thinking regarding Singaporean women's value as mothers. In both national discourse and public policy, highly-educated women have for decades been cast as more valuable mothers than their lower-educated counterparts.[16] This now largely unspoken and yet widely accepted and institutionalized class prejudice—that poor women have too many children and wealthy women too few—prevents us from dealing with blind spots. To overcome this historical baggage, there has to be explicit reckoning.

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I ran into Nana again in early 2016. I learnt that she had been pregnant with her fourth child when we spoke in 2014. She had now delivered her baby and was back at work. She was still stressed about her children's school results, still could not afford tuition for them, still exhausted from working and caring for her children. But she was also extremely thankful that they now had a more stable roof over their heads and no more debts. After years of moving from place to place, she and her husband finally managed to buy a flat. Numerous challenges remained, but she was relieved that her kids could go to school regularly. She asked me how my research was going. I told her about an op-ed I had recently published. She asked to read it, and I sent it to her later that day. The piece was about some of the challenges low-income parents face, about how they care greatly for their children, and about how they *have* poor options rather than *make* poor choices. After reading it, Nana sent me a text to say that she hopes it will "inspire people" who face problems to "hang on and continue to be the best of themselves."

Nana *was* the best of herself. She and her family overcame their major housing crisis. Many other parents I met are also doing their best—they work hard to make sure there's food on the table, find ways to meet their kids' needs, cobble together care solutions. They are generous in circumstances where it is not easy to be generous, where being generous entails real sacrifice.

Being the best of themselves rarely result in sustained improvements in their lives. Nana's message to me revealed a spirit I have seen repeatedly: to "hang on," to "continue," to persist, to try to find strength in oneself. I find Nana amazing—strong, persevering, resourceful, loving, selfless. Like many other mothers I've met, Nana seems to me a superwoman. But being 'super' comes at a great cost and usually does not save the day.

Nana's is a story many would like me to tell—someone who experienced tremendous hardship, persevered, and then apparently overcame. But this is not where her story ends. The difficulties she has with balancing wage work and care responsibilities will persist; they may even intensify as her children become teenagers and her mother grows older. She will continue to feel like she is doing everything she can for her kids and that that is still not enough. She is still caught between needing a job and wanting to be present for her kids. Her family, unusual in being able to improve their situation enough to buy their own flat, remains in precarious position: an illness, an accident, a misunderstanding with a boss, a failed exam, a bout of teenage rebellion—many different scenarios could push them back into crisis mode because there still is no buffer zone to cushion these ordinary life-risks. Nana managed to get out of crisis not *because* her employment conditions and social policies changed to allow her to better meet her various responsibilities. She overcame *in spite* of unconducive conditions. Nana's story is worth lauding. But it is not a triumph for the system.

A right to care

I published an article in 2016—"Not everyone has 'maids'"—in which I present arguments similar to the ones I have presented here. Given the title, I must point out that the solution to the work-life balance quandary is *not* for everyone to employ domestic workers. Paid domestic and care services are probably here to stay; indeed, we must also push for improvements in the way our society recognizes, respects, and rewards this labor. But the purpose of pointing out that people care under different class conditions is to urge that we should improve conditions for all *so that everyone can care better*, not so that anyone can give up care responsibilities to paid caregivers.

When I was a girl first encountering ideas about women's empowerment, I focused my sights on not holding myself back career-wise and ensuring that I would not be constrained by domestic demands. So much about being a woman who's had the good fortune to be offered some choices, and yet not good enough fortune to live in a world with gender equality, is about giving up some of what we want and making peace with not "having it all." Many women give up dreams and ideals as they patch together careers, marriage, children.[17] My career-centered path should not be read as a rejection of the domestic and care aspects of life. Over the years, as I deepened my engagement with feminist thought, as I met more women older than me or whose lives are different from mine because of class disparities, and as I've grown older and experienced more that life has to offer, I have become increasingly appreciative of the fact that our lives are not—*should not*—be limited to singular, one-dimensional goals nor to a small range of life activities. We should—women and men, across class lines—learn to be good at our jobs *and* learn to change diapers, cook, talk to kids, do laundry, help our neighbors and friends, buy groceries, pay bills, play; we should have, in all our days, time to learn to love and be loved. We give up the mundane at our own peril.

Low-income parents are *not* saying that they want people to take over what they do for their families. Instead, they are saying that their families are their priority and whatever else they are expected to do—employment included—must

allow them to first take care of their families' needs. Nana was not trying to get someone else to go to her kid's school on her behalf—*she* would like to have been able to go.

We make meaning through our everyday lives—in small activities and through relationships. These are moments of potential beauty. They are the acts that make us human. The inclination by class-privileged women and men to reject the domestic realm because we see and know that it is the sphere of less power—it is an inclination that gives up too much and we must claw it back. In the process, we must also work to expand the space for *everyone* to meet their needs—make real choices, partake in the mundane, live lives, be human. To do this, we need reasonable employment conditions across the class spectrum and social policies that are not class-biased but genuinely supportive of all families.

No one should have to be super in order to be human.

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1 Most entrances to HDB flats have both gates and doors. Gates give residents an additional sense of security. People may leave their doors open for ventilation and light without worrying about strangers entering their flats or young children wandering out.

2 This problem is not limited to Singapore. See, for example, Clawson and Gerstel (2014); Le Bihan, Knijn and Martin (2014).

3 There is a rich tradition in feminist scholarship that points out the centrality and yet invisibility of housework, care labor, and more generally, social reproduction. See, for example, Razavi (2007); Orloff (1996); Laslett and Brenner (1989); Kofman (2012); Glazer (1984); Hochschild and Machung (1989).

4 Although there are exceptions to the rule—insofar as social workers can write letters on behalf of non-employed mothers for them to still receive subsidies— such 'case by case' scenarios mean that many who may appeal are unaware of the possibility. Most of the mothers I spoke to mentioned the employment requirement for childcare center subsidies. I learnt about the exemption letter option from social workers and not from mothers themselves. If people generally do not know about this route, it cannot reasonably be regarded as an option.

5 Primary School Leaving Examination.

6 I explore these norms in some detail in an earlier project. See Teo (2011).

7 Clawson and Gerstel (2014).

8 Standing (2011).

9 Knijn and Da Roit (2014).

10 See, for example, Toh (2016). I responded to the article with an op-ed. See Teo (2016a).

11 Teo (2013).

12 Slaughter (2012).

13 Cottom (2012).

14 Fraser (2013).

15 Slaughter (2015).

16 Teo (2016b); Teo (2014).

17 Scholars have devoted some attention to how gender inequalities in the 'private'/domestic realm play out in differences in how men and women navigate certain professional worlds, including academia. See, for example,

Baker (2012).

I Want My Children Better Than Me

IN 2003 AND 2004, while I was a graduate student doing research for my dissertation, I met people starting on their adult lives. From them, I learnt about 'the Singapore way' of growing up. Many of my respondents were just a few years older than I was. They had finished schooling, worked for a year or two, accumulated some CPF.[1] They had partners on similar trajectories. They applied for HDB[2] flats, collected their keys, 'ROM-ed,'[3] and held 'customary' weddings. After all this, they were ready to 'start a family.'[4]

I asked them: what did people need to think about when they think about having children? They listed yet another set of preconditions: "financial readiness" for basic material needs—diapers and milk powder, they laughingly told me, are "very expensive." Turning serious, they told me about things that *they* did not have when they were kids which now feel like necessities—tuition, enrichment classes, hobbies like piano and ballet.[5] I got the sense from talking to respondents that having kids had to be carefully planned for and that couples had to make sure they had enough money.

I was 28 years old when I listened to these descriptions of what it is to be 'normal' in Singapore. Some respondents teased me to hurry up and not wait too long to settle down. I laughed or smiled politely. I actually felt removed. Being in graduate school meant that I could put off some of these things they were casting as natural and normal. I could not at that point in time fully empathize with how seriously they took the issue of ensuring that things are in place before having children.

Fast forward a decade to 2013. I am sitting on the living room floor of Mdm M. She describes to me the times she delivered her three kids, sketching in humorous terms the birth story of each. Her children, ages 12, 10, and 8, are at the center of her life. She and her daughter, in particular, often chat about their shared

aspirations for the child. The girl is doing well in school, better than both her older and younger brothers. She asks her mother what kind of school comes after secondary school and ITE.[6] Neither know the answer, but whatever it is, that is where she wants to go. Speaking from within their tiny flat, her mother recalls their conversations about the girl buying a house and a car when she grows up; her mother can live with her and take care of her children.

Mdm M had a very difficult childhood. Her father died when she was 6 years old. Her mother, at a loss, got her to beg on the street. She was eventually taken out of her mother's custody and put into a Girls' Home. She lived there until she was 18 years old. By 21, she was married. Her husband was unfaithful. While pregnant with their second child, she ran away from him. She met her current husband and later married him. With him, she had another child. Mdm M hopes her kids will do well in school. Her husband also has high hopes for their children. He, like her, has had a hard life. "I want them better than me," he tells me, by way of explaining why he is a strict father.

Mdm M and her husband's lives have not included the steps and sequences described to me by the respondents I spoke with a decade earlier. Their hopes for their kids are high, but they do not imagine their futures like so many stepping stones in a river.

By this second moment, I was married and had a child. I identified with my earlier respondents not in how well I planned everything, but certainly in the general sequence and how big a deal it felt to have even one kid. I was struck by the comparatively easygoing attitude of people I was meeting in low-income communities. It is *not* the case that having and raising kids is easy for them—they face numerous hardships. But they spoke of life differently from people I had interviewed a decade earlier, and from people in my own social milieu: marriage and kids are not events to be planned out in precision. These are not part of sequential five-step life plans: school, work, HDB, marriage, children. Talking to low-income parents compelled me to reexamine the strong need for planning and control so characteristic of people in my social milieu. In their stories of becoming parents, I

noticed a lack of angst. I heard a sense of wonder and openness toward seeing children as gifts or—for the more religious—as blessings. Low-income persons do not have all kinds of (financial) preconditions in mind that they think they must have *in order* to have children.[7]

Their ease entered into their everyday habits as parents. As the American sociologist, Annette Lareau, put it: for higher-class parents, children are 'projects.'[8] They have tightly scheduled lives and coordinated activities; high-income parents spend significant time and energy thinking about how to fulfill their kids' 'potentials.' For the working class and poor, Lareau argues, parenting is more about 'the accomplishment of natural growth.' Top priorities in these families are safety and health. Moreover, children should be children—by which parents mean that kids should have the time and space to do their own thing, to play. This is partly because lower-income parents experience hardships in their adult lives and want to shield their children from having to deal with tight schedules and overwork in their childhoods. In any case, financial constraints prevent them from approaching parenting as projects.

Lareau's findings are relevant for understanding my Singapore respondents past and present. There are stark contrasts across class lines when it comes to what becoming a parent means and how to approach it. Parents of all class backgrounds talk about how important education is and how much they want their kids to do well in school, but *how* this plays out in everyday lives looks different.

I began to appreciate that the first story—presented to me as what all Singaporeans *should* do—is not a universal story, and does not have to be the only way to live.

Two more years go by. By this time, I had sat on numerous floors in HDB rental flats. One afternoon, I met Suyati. Originally from Indonesia, she has been living in Singapore as a Long-Term Social Visit Pass (LTVP) holder since she married her Singaporean husband. For a number of years, he has been incarcerated. She barely makes ends meet by cleaning a few homes a week. When her daughter, Ani, is not at school—when she is sick or school is closed—Suyati brings her along

to the condominiums where she works. When they visit her husband in prison, Ani is full of chatter. She tells her father about the condominium swimming pools she sees. As a LTVP pass holder, Suyati is actually not supposed to do wage work.[9] Doing the ad-hoc work she does, she makes barely enough to get by.

Suyati's daughter, like mine, was then six years old. We talked about the fact that they would both enter primary school the following year. Suyati was very anxious about missing the enrollment deadline. Her English is weak and she did not know how to enroll online. She didn't know how easy or difficult it would be for Ani to get into a school near their flat. Months later, when it was time for me to enroll my daughter, I called her to make sure she too had enrolled hers. I tried to alleviate her anxieties, but the reality I knew from friends was that the process is indeed not always straightforward and that even parents who are comfortable with English and have access to information are often anxious that they will not get the schools of their choosing.

On my side of the city, things went smoothly. I was soon added to a WhatsApp parent chat group at my daughter's primary school. With that, I inadvertently gained entry into a world of intensive parenting. At the first orientation for parents, a week after school started, a father raised his hand to ask how the "overall standard of the kids" was. As a teacher myself, I felt sorry for the teacher who had to answer an unanswerable question. In response to the vibe of intense parental concern, she spoke with the expectation that parents would be helping children with their school responsibilities on a daily basis. Indeed, throughout Primary One, the chat group buzzed with activity—with parents, mostly mothers, asking each other what their children should bring to school the following day; what day spelling tests would be that week; if anyone could send the spelling list because their child couldn't find theirs. The first spelling test took place the second week of Primary One, and the words "butterfly" and "caterpillar" were on that list. At a second parent-teacher meeting soon after, parents were reminded to help kids with specific topics because "this is where some of them are weak."

Not long after our kids started Primary One in their respective schools, I

visited Suyati again. A few months into Primary One and Ani, a lively, curious, and bright child, was falling behind. She could not read and write and had been identified as a weak student who should attend extra coaching each morning before school. I brought Ani some books for beginning readers that my child had used. My daughter no longer read them; she had started on the Harry Potter novels.

In this third moment, I saw the complex intertwining and relationality of lives across class lines. We are making our way through life in the same country, standing at the same part of life's course. Yet, our experiences are starkly different. We come face to face with similar institutions, but we exercise different levels and forms of agency in our interactions with them. I began to wonder how my ability to plan my life is linked to Mdm M's and Suyati's inability to plan theirs. How might my 7-year-old reading Harry Potter be connected to Suyati's 7-year-old being labeled 'weak'?

This third research experience compelled me to see that I have to go beyond just saying that there are *different* ways to live life and be parents. If one pathway is recognized and rewarded and another is not, then 'embracing difference' alone is meaningless. We must unpack and scrutinize how class differences translate into *inequalities*.

World-class education system

When we look at the Singapore education system, we see certain things that are widely and internationally regarded to be laudable. A great deal of attention and resources are channeled into public education. Teachers receive rigorous and continual training, and teaching is a well-compensated and well-respected job. We see high regard for academic rigor—pegged to global standards of abilities, and in specific foundational subject areas (Mathematics and Science).[10] There is bilingual education which takes into account, to a degree, the needs of different ethnic groups, including minorities; the main medium of instruction is English, but

students also take a second language, typically associated with their ethnic groups. We see attention to children with different learning styles and abilities, and we see the existence of programs and human resources that target these differences. There are financial aid programs in place for children from lower-income households so as to provide opportunities for material resources and extra-curricular activities.

Yet, on the other hand, there are notable differentiating mechanisms and inequalities in outcomes.

Tracing key developments in the historical trajectory of Singapore's education system, Zongyi Deng and S. Gopinathan point out that the early signs of the effects of ethnicity and socioeconomic status on children's school performance were largely ignored. Differences in outcomes were essentially registered as (natural) ability differentials. A national system of tracking (i.e. 'streaming'), accompanied by high-stakes examinations at primary school, was put in place in 1980.[11] This highly stratified system persists in Singapore today, as do inequalities along ethnic and class lines. In a recent study, Ong Xiang Ling and Cheung Hoi Shan found that—as measured by parents' educational attainment, housing type, and monthly per capita household income—students in 'elite' schools are disproportionately from higher socioeconomic status households compared to students from 'neighborhood' schools.[12] On the other side of the spectrum, among students placed in lower educational tracks ('Normal Technical'), there are disproportionate numbers of students from ethnic minority and lower-income households.[13] The different educational tracks are meant to cater to different learning needs, but they also result in different exposure to learning. This includes, importantly, as Li-Ching Ho finds, citizenship education.[14] Students in different tracks have unequal conceptions of civic engagement and democratic rights—while higher-track students are developed to become civic agents, lower-track students are prepared to become obedient citizens.[15]

These studies give weight to perceptions already widely held: that some schools are 'better' and some are 'worse,' and even more poignantly than that, that some students are superior and others inferior.[16]

Are schools and our purported system of meritocracy doing what it claims it is doing? To what extent is the education system a space where there is equality of opportunity? Is education the route to upward mobility for the low-income? To what extent do schools embody the values of equality and justice? To what extent do they undermine values of equality and justice?

Worries about inequalities in the education system often center on the 'low-performing' and focus on 'leveling up.' Kids from low-income families are often the target group. The presence of numerous programs, personnel, and public expenditure intended to level up these kids, combined with the persistence of low performance among them, leads to the perception that kids from low-income families are less motivated or lack the right home environment for studying. More generally, many Singaporeans take for granted that the system is merit-based and there are ample opportunities for everyone regardless of their family backgrounds.

These perspectives are not wrong per se, but they are insufficiently precise. In their imprecision, they inadvertently slip into faulting low-income parents for the poor academic performance of their kids. The logic goes that if our systems are fair, then surely, they fail because parents are not doing what they should be doing.

To understand why kids from low-income households do poorly in school, we *would* do well to understand what their lives at home are like. But we must also step back and situate their lives within the broader social context. This includes trying to understand what material conditions are like for parents, what school experiences are like for kids, and finally and least often done, what higher-income families are doing for *their* kids. It is when we do all this that we can have a more complete and accurate understanding of how kids from low-income families, within this system, are compelled to play a game they cannot win because someone else is setting the rules.

Parenting in the age of high-stakes educational

competition

In conversations with low-income parents, education comes up repeatedly as a major source of anxiety. Low-income parents—and especially mothers—tell me that an important reason why they need to quit their jobs or cut back on wage work is because their kids are struggling in school. People talk about children failing weekly spelling tests and/or teachers calling them up regularly to speak to them about their kids' problems with school work.

In some ways, low-income parents' experiences are not so different from higher-income parents'. The incessant buzzing of my phone with messages from parents of my child's classmates indicates a high degree of parental involvement in children's schooling. In ongoing interviews I am conducting with parents of various class backgrounds, I am often struck by the amount of time and energy parents—across class lines—put into keeping an eye on their children's progress in school. Newspaper forum letters and online sites are regularly peppered with discussions about schools, homework, and exams, demonstrating the deep angst we share as a nation. We hear of professional women quitting their jobs or taking extended time off wage work in order to supervise children. We know very well the pressures children face, and parents feel, when it comes to examinations. Parents in contemporary Singapore universally complain about how difficult primary school has become.

My low-income respondents cannot really help their kids with homework. Many of them barely finished primary school. My friends, mostly university graduates, tell me that by Primary 3 or 4, they struggle to help their kids with homework. A few of my middle-income respondents (from an ongoing research project) told me about attending courses in order to learn how to coach their children, particularly in Mathematics. The reality, then, is that parents experience deep limitations as they try to navigate their children's schooling; most of them, after all, are not teachers. Nagging, screaming, sometimes beatings, resistance, tears

—these seem par for the course in parent-child interactions as parents try to help with homework. One (university-educated) mother told me candidly that the high-pressure school system, and her anxiety about her child keeping up, makes the time she spends with her daughter rather unpleasant. She can see, and yet feels helpless to stop, the behavioral patterns that are damaging their relationship.

The difficulty of the curriculum, the understanding that exams have high-stake consequences for their kids' futures, and the difficulty of teaching one's own children, have fueled the growth of the tuition industry. Parents with ample means use these to help their children from the get-go (in some cases as young as preschool) and on a regular basis (i.e. throughout the school years). Parents with moderate means forgo other household needs and hire tutors in crucial exam years and/or on subjects especially tough for their kids.[17] Tuition has become a billion-dollar industry, with parents spending significant proportions of household income on it.[18]

Quite apart from tuition for academic subjects, an industry also exists for 'enrichment' programs. Some of these are meant to further hone skills that contribute to academic performance in schools. Others are essentially insurance policies—ways for kids to develop other types of 'talents' that can also open doors to 'good schools' or higher tracks in case their academic results fall short. That these exist also tell us an additional thing: some parents are diligently learning about how the system works and are active campaigners on behalf of their children. It is difficult to fault parents for wanting the best for their children, but it is important to notice that this type of campaigning is not class-neutral: it comes more easily to people who have themselves succeeded in the system and understand its logic, who feel a sense of entitlement in their interactions with teachers, who have time to devote to this labor, and who have budgets that allow for various aspects of this—including for buying books, hiring tutors, cutting back on fulltime employment.

The sociologist Pierre Bourdieu spoke of parents from higher class backgrounds subtly transmitting advantages to their children—through socializing them in ways of speaking, relating to authority figures, and understanding things

like art and music.[19] He called these "cultural capital"—they are qualities that schools reward and yet do not teach.[20] They are 'capital' because they eventually translate into formal credentials and, importantly, into *legitimate* status. This legitimacy is possible because the relative advantages and disadvantages of kids and the hidden requirements of schools are not apparent. In other words, for the most part, people see the rules of the game as fair. The people who eventually make it to the top of a social hierarchy, via the ladder of formal education, are seen—both by themselves and those below them—as meritorious and deserving. For Bourdieu, the qualities that become capital are difficult to put one's finger on and difficult to replicate; *cultural* capital is distinguished from *economic* capital precisely because it is not just money that translates to social power. In contemporary cities—from Shanghai to New York, Seoul to Singapore—we see parental practices that require Bourdieu's theory as well as its modification: in the commercial centers that run parallel to formal schools, economic capital is, unsubtly and unabashedly, transformed into cultural capital every day.

When we look at low-income kids' experiences with schooling, these larger social realities must be kept in view.

Although there is variation in how kids from low-income families do in school, there are recurring patterns. Many of the kids fall behind almost immediately as they enter the first year of mandatory schooling. They are less advanced than kids from wealthier families, who can read and write by the day they enter Primary 1. Very quickly, many barely pass or completely fail English and Mathematics. They usually still do reasonably well in Mother Tongue, which many use at home, signaling that the kids generally do have the capacity to learn when there is sufficient exposure to a subject. In Primary 1 and 2, many of the kids from the low-income families are identified as having problems and pulled out of class for extra coaching through the Learning Support Programme (LSP) and Learning Support Programme for Maths (LSM). While this can help, it is not easy for the kids to catch up, since the more advanced kids continue to move forward at a fast pace. By Primary 3, many kids from low-income families are tracked and banded into lower-

performing classes. Although schools vary in how obvious the banding is at Primary 3 and 4, kids themselves are well aware of where they stand vis-à-vis others. By Primary 5 and 6, many of the kids do so poorly that they have to switch to what is known as 'Foundation' level for some or all of their subjects. While most parents I spoke with reported their kids still going to school regularly, it is apparent that many develop a sense of themselves as inferior to others and start to feel quite demoralized. In some cases, kids begin to resist going to school. If conditions are unstable at home—changing living arrangements, irregular job schedules, unstable income, marital conflict, need for children to take on responsibilities such as caring for younger siblings, et cetera—parents also find it difficult to manage their children's school schedules. If they do indeed stop going to school regularly, their social connections at school will suffer. When they return, the absence of friends, teasing or bullying from schoolmates, can make staying the course difficult.

Both children and their parents face many difficulties due to complex home situations that have little to do with schools, but the schooling experience itself is crucial for understanding their relative lack of educational success. This becomes especially clear when speaking with parents who are, despite all their challenges, getting their kids to go to school every day.

Soon after starting primary school, kids are placed in tracks that send strong signals to them about how teachers and schools think of them, shaping how they think of themselves and their abilities. These kids whose potential is no less than kids from higher-income households are left further and further behind with each passing year. Once on the low tracks, partly because they are taught significantly less than higher-track kids, it is virtually impossible for the kids to move to higher tracks. For most of my respondents, having their kids passing the Primary School Leaving Examination (PSLE) is regarded as an achievement. Most of the kids go on to the lowest track in secondary school and some drop out altogether. A few make it beyond secondary school to ITEs (Institute of Technical Education). In three years of fieldwork, I came across only a small handful of families where a child had made it into a polytechnic; one single instance stands out in my mind, of a girl who

qualified for university.

In theory, all educational paths can lead to reasonable lives and decent well-being. In reality, their limited educational credentials will put them in similar low-wage jobs as their parents. It is disingenuous to claim that all tracks are good and all paths valued; if this were the case, and if Singaporeans actually believe this, tuition centers would be out of business.

How does the demand for precocity, including early tracking, lead to these patterns?

People who work with kids will know that students are sensitive about how they compare to their peers. A teacher I spoke with told me that students who are in lower bands say things like "I stupid lah" or "I lazy what." They do not try because they do not believe they can possibly succeed. Teachers working with kids in low tracks have to spend time and energy on behavioral issues linked to low self-esteem and lack of motivation. They are more disruptive in classrooms and more likely to skip school or neglect homework. This phenomenon is not something limited to Singapore nor unknown to pedagogical researchers. Jeannie Oakes, in a classic study on tracking, shows that one of the detrimental effects of tracking students according to narrow criteria of academic abilities is that students in low tracks often think of themselves as poor learners and thus do not try as hard as students in high tracks who think of themselves as capable.[21] In other words, 'low motivation,' a reason cited by educators who work with kids from low-income families, is something reproduced within the school context. Specifically, the labeling of kids is something of a self-fulfilling prophecy that shapes learning behaviors.[22]

There are some positive things to an education system that has multiple tracks. Kids are not completely thrown out—there are still tracks open to them, which prevent them from dropping out of school altogether. At the same time, however, there also appears an irrational outcome: most of these kids appear to be of regular intelligence and do not have learning disabilities, but they are labeled 'slow' from a young age. In speaking to an Allied Educator whose job it is to work with kids with learning disabilities, I learnt that it takes some time for her to figure out which kids

have disabilities. Why? Because most of the kids who come to her attention are 'behind' simply because they have not had as much exposure to school materials and not because they are unable to learn in neuro-typical ways. In other words, given time and exposure, they are no less capable of learning than most other children. They lack exposure for a variety of reasons: they have less preschool education; their parents do not speak English (or the type of English required in schools); there is limited reading at home; and they do not have extra coaching by tuition teachers. In other words, the main reason they 'fall behind' can be traced to their relative class disadvantages. Turn our view around and we see that, given the ubiquity of enrichment centers and tutors, some kids—because of class advantages —are advantaged in a system where early exposure and precocity are rewarded. The kids who are able to run forward the moment the gates are open are neither more 'meritorious' nor more deserving.

Why do I call this an irrational outcome? If we think of schools as places of learning, if 'equality of opportunity' is upheld as our education system's mantra, and if the purpose of mass education is to train as many capable individuals as we can who will grow up to be contributing members of our society, then kids who have insufficient exposure outside of school should have sufficient exposure within it and sufficient *time* to even out the advantages/disadvantages resulting from class differences. They should not be punished for having insufficient exposure outside of it. By virtue of rewarding precocity—expecting kids to be able to read and write when they begin Primary 1, for example— the school system values its role in sorting ahead of its role in teaching.

The effects of early sorting and labeling are profound for parents as well as kids. Parents with more means also tend to be parents who have the confidence to say: my kid is not stupid, he/ she just needs more help. How our kids are branded by schools, the information parents get from schools about how they compare vis-à-vis other children—these shape our conceptions of our children and what they are capable of. If I believe my child is fundamentally, even with bad grades, capable, then my solution is to find help, especially if I have money to pay for this help. If,

in contrast, over time, I am told repeatedly by teachers that my child is very weak or unmotivated, my sense of my kid is that she/he is like me, not so good in school, not likely to do well. If I have no money for tutors anyway, then my aspirations for my child too will be adjusted accordingly. When some parents lament to me that their child does not seem to be "stupid" but somehow, they—"don't know why"—cannot do well in school, I hear a sense of frustration and confusion.

Parents' opinions and actions feed into a child's sense of themselves and their potential. Many of the parents I meet have high hopes that their children will do better than them, that they won't end up with such hard lives, but they parent in a context where their children are already branded as weaker, as lesser, as not as smart, as not as capable. It is incredibly difficult to transcend that and to see their kids as still having talents and value. I see many low-income parents trying to do this, but like many of us who try our best to form independent opinions, we are not immune to the voices of others. We depend strongly on teachers' assessments and understandings of our children. We evaluate our children according to what seems 'normal' in our society. For many low-income parents, a sense of resignation sets in. An acceptance of a child's poor results and lacks come to define the dynamic within the family. Returning to my earlier story of Mdm M—in the family's lore, there is a clever child and her not-as-clever siblings. In many family lores in low-income homes, children are good at soccer, or dancing, or cooking, or helping with housework and care, but hopeless at Mathematics and English. Once solidified into common sense, both parents and children have a hard time coming out from under these labels.

The home environment of low-income kids is indeed not always conducive to studying. Spaces are small, family relationships are sometimes tensed, material hardships are persistent. But this could be said to be the case for many Singaporean adults who now find themselves middle-class in contemporary Singapore. Many of my peers grew up in exactly these 'not conducive' environments. This perhaps explains higher-income Singaporeans' reluctance to interrogate systemic inequality and an attendant rush to judge the low-income: if I could overcome hardship, why

can't they? Earlier, I mentioned that to understand the persistence of low educational achievement and what appears to be the reproduction of class inequalities among the low-income today, we must look beyond individual families' practices. We have to examine the broader social context and important developments in the education system's criteria, dynamics, and principles. And though counter-intuitive, we have to look at wider social practices of parents across class lines. In the 1980s, when I was in primary school, I did not have tuition, and none of my friends did. My parents spent approximately zero hours a week helping me with my homework—roughly the same amount of time my classmates' parents spent on theirs.

What is our current system rewarding, and what is it punishing? It is in stepping back, going well beyond focusing on individual low-income families, that we can see what is going on.

"I want my children better than me"

I began this essay by relating three moments in my research career. Each brought a new layer of insight, and each required rethinking of the previous moment. In the first, I learnt about what it is to be a 'normal' Singaporean. In the second moment, I learnt that there may be more than one way to be and that the performance of the normal is not class-neutral. In the third, I saw that class matters not just in shaping performance but in its consequences: most parents want their children to be better than them, but not all can attain this. More importantly, in their quest for this ideal —through making decisions about how to spend their money and time, in the types of interactions they have with their children and their children's teachers—they shape the system everyone has to deal with.

The lack of class privilege is about having to play by someone else's rules; the presence of class privilege is about being able to set standards. With this, I am back at the first moment of research in 2003 when middle-class respondents claimed,

with a sense of inevitability, that their choices are those of *all normal* Singaporeans.

American journalist Nikole Hannah-Jones writes about the racial segregation and inequalities of schools in contemporary USA. There are many things about the American case that are unique to that society, but there are also many inequalities there that are mirrored elsewhere. In a 2017 interview,[23] Hannah-Jones spoke about something that was deeply moving. She had placed her daughter in a public school that is perceived as a terrible school even though she has the means to place her in a different, 'better' school. A lot of people thought she was making an odd choice. But for her, it is a moral issue—what is at stake goes beyond her child's well-being.[24] If she put her child in a private school, she would be doing what many middle and upper-middle class parents are doing—undermining the integrity of the public school system with their flight. She puts it this way: "It is important to understand that the inequality we see, school segregation, is both structural, it is systemic, but it's also upheld by individual choices. … As long as individual parents continue to make choices that only benefit their own children...we're not going to see a change."

A lot of my research and writing in the past decade have been about institutions and policies. I have talked primarily about how we need to rethink the principles underlying our policies if we want to see more equal outcomes. I still believe that if we want to see significant change, we need to have collective action, we need to work to alter big structural things—rules, regulations, criteria, principles underlying policies. But doing this more recent research, I am also continually reminded that life is lived at the micro level, at the level of everyday decisions, everyday interactions, everyday exercise of power and agency and responses to constraints and restraints.

Nikole Hannah-Jones is a tough act to follow. She is right to say that inequalities are also reproduced by the individual choices of those who have the power to make choices. This implies an extremely uncomfortable conclusion for those of us in positions to make choices: the choices we make, even when we think

are just about us, are in fact also about others.

We who have the power to make choices disproportionately shape outcomes and limit options for people who don't have the power to make choices.

It follows that if we don't share the power to make choices, we will never see a change to those things we say are bad or unacceptable to our society. When those of us who have the means maximize our own children's and our own families' advantages, we are contributing to strengthening norms about achievement, success/failure, that undermine our fellow citizens' well-being. Everyone may say "I want my children better than me," but not everyone can see this to fruition nor have the same impact on standards and norms when they do.

As parents, we must therefore think very carefully about what we are doing when we demand that teachers assign more homework, when we ask questions about what standard our kids' peers are at, when we micro-manage our kids' lives, when we pay for tutors, when we fight to get our kids into certain schools.

Equally if not more important, we must ask what we are allowing to perpetuate when we do not resist a system many of us can now see is deeply problematic. If those higher in the social hierarchy, ahead in the pack, refuse to pause and change their ways, the call to extend assistance to the low-income or to 'level up' will continue to ring hollow.

This still isn't *just* about individual parental practices

Embedded in what I have said lies inherent conflict in class interests *as well as* the potential for class solidarity. Regardless of class, everyone is subject to state policies on education. It is becoming increasingly clear that a high-stakes, examination-oriented education system exerts costs on parents and kids across the class spectrum.

We should care because we are losing potentially valuable human resources. We will all grow old in societies populated by other people's children; our well-being depends on their capabilities.[25] We contribute to public education precisely

because there are collective returns on this expenditure. To enhance our shared well-being, we have an interest in ensuring that all kids growing up in our society can fulfill their human potential.

The circumstances and experiences of low-income families reveal the deep inequalities embedded in our education system— the focus on narrow definitions of abilities, the demand for precocity, the reliance on parental involvement and commercial services, together undermine the democratic promise and potential of mass education. As a society, we speak loudly and proudly about meritocracy and equality of opportunity. As a matter of ethics and morality, we should all care about the undermining of these promises, and we should fight to resist this erosion of our shared ethos.

The requirement of narrow ways of being, of precocity, are not easy to attain for any child. The financial costs, the time expended, the harms done to familial relationships, the stresses exerted on our children[26]—these are significant. In the long run, all of us must ask: to what end? Is it worth it?

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1 Central Provident Fund.

2 Housing & Development Board.

3 Registry of Marriage.

4 I detail these responses in Teo (2011).

5 They had to, moreover, think about care arrangements. While money was rarely explicitly mentioned here, grandmothers, domestic workers, and mothers who gave up employment were listed. Each of these options entails financial costs.

6 Institute of Technical Education.

7 If they waited to have the same kind of preconditions that middle-class respondents imply are necessities, they would of course never have children. Edin and Kefalas argue that low-income women often place motherhood as a high priority because this brings them a sense of accomplishment and self-worth, in a context where few other things do. See Edin and Kefalas (2011).

8 Lareau (2011).

9 This is unless she finds an employer who applies for a Letter of Consent from the Ministry of Manpower, and if this Letter of Consent is granted. As a discretionary (i.e. 'case by case') policy, one should expect that there will be people who may be eligible who are unaware of their options. It is also not entirely clear the full range of factors that affect MOM's decisions. For example, on their website, one stipulation is that "You are not allowed to work in objectionable occupations such as a dance hostess." (Ministry of Manpower 2018; emphasis mine).

10 As Contact Singapore puts it: "Singapore was also ranked 1st in both Math and Science across 140 countries in World Economic Forum's Global Competitiveness Report 2015-2016." https://www.contactsingapore.sg/en/professionals/why-singapore/living/education

11 Deng and Gopinathan (2016).

12 Ong and Cheung (2016).

13 Wang, Teng and Tan (2014).

14 Ho (2012).

15 Ho, Sim and Alviar-Martin (2011).

16 In their survey, Ong and Cheung found that "regardless of their school type, all students perceived individuals in elite schools to be of higher social status and academic competence than those in non-elite

schools. … Students from elite secondary schools perceived themselves to have a higher social status than individuals from non-elite secondary schools" (page 1, emphasis mine).

17 In 2012/13, comparing monthly household expenditure on tuition and other educational courses (home-based tuition, center-based tuition, other courses), the difference is stark: households in the 1st to 10th percentiles spent a total of S$25.10; households in the 41st to 50th percentiles spent four times that (S$99.60), and those in the 90th–100th percentiles spent seven times as much (S$181.40). See Singapore Department of Statistics (2013).

18 Wise (2016).

19 Annette Lareau and Shamus Khan, following in Bourdieu's tradition, separately locate and trace how these qualities come into being in everyday family lives and elite schools respectively. See Lareau (2011); Khan (2011).

20 Bourdieu (1989).

21 Oakes (2005 [1985]).

22 Importantly, Oakes also shows that students in low tracks have fewer opportunities for learning. They are exposed to less and lesser material and spend fewer hours on learning.

23 Hannah-Jones (2017).

24 See also Brighouse and Swift (2009).

25 Economists such as Nancy Folbre have thus argued for seeing children as public goods. See Folbre (1994).

26 A recent study by the Programme for International Student Assessment (Pisa) found that Singapore students have comparatively high levels of anxiety about school performance. See Davie (2017).

Growing Up
Without Class Protections

WHEN I SPEAK to parents with older kids, these are the worries I hear of: kids who spend long hours away from home, hanging out with friends; kids who are unsure of their future vocations and who are struggling in school or dropping out; kids at risk of unplanned pregnancies; kids who have material wants and needs that are not easily fulfilled; kids getting into trouble with the police for things like underage smoking, drugs, and theft.

In popular parlance, we refer to 'at-risk youth' or 'juvenile delinquents' as if they automatically arise from 'bad neighborhoods' or 'dysfunctional families.' The unspoken presumption is that youth 'go astray' because parents are neglectful. The more generous rendition of this view points to how busy parents are with trying to make a living.

In the neighborhoods where I did my research, it was often parents themselves who were expressing worries about their kids. I saw parents stressed out at their relationships with their teenage children, anxious about the fact that their kids were not listening to them, not coming home, not heeding their advice to take their parents' lives as cautionary tales. Clearly, the full story goes beyond one of parental neglect. After hearing parents express their worries and anxieties about kids, of observing youths who hang out in low-income neighborhoods, and from talking to social workers who work with young people, it strikes me that we don't adequately acknowledge the complex care needs (and care gaps) of youth. For our constant talk about family as the central unit of Singapore society, we pay very little attention to the everyday contours of family life.

We often speak of 'children' or 'kids' as if it is one big category. Public policy tends to frame care needs only in terms of care that very young children require—constant supervision, physical assistance to go about daily lives. Viewing care this way obscures the complex needs of children, and the challenges that parents, low-

income ones in particular, face. It leads us to overlook the fact that older kids also need parental care. When we begin to think about what youths need, we start to realize that parents in low-income households have a far more difficult time maintaining parental authority and that kids in low-income households do not have some of the protections that kids in higher-income households have.

Sphere of influence and authority: the relevance of class conditions

When it comes to raising older kids, all parents struggle with maintaining some sphere of influence and authority. These are difficult because older kids are not like younger ones: they are able to go about their own everyday lives more independently than young children, and they are more aware of the world beyond their families. These two things are exactly the reasons low-income parents struggle more than their higher-income counterparts.

In what follows, I describe the relevance of things we do not often talk about, and which turn out are important for parenting youth: space, activities, and pocket money; time, leisure, and memories; the social standing of parents. Through these, I hope to bring attention to the fact that youth have complex care needs and these needs require conditions that low-income parents often cannot meet.

Space, paid activities, and pocket money

The reality of living in a low-income household is that there is little space for privacy. Even parents do not usually have a bedroom to themselves, so children certainly do not have much private space. When I visited homes, I saw people creatively use bedsheets and furniture to create partitions for some semblance of privacy for teenage children, especially girls. Still, the limitations of small flats mean

that teenagers often find it more pleasant to spend time out of the home with friends than to be at home. In cases where relationships are fraught, as they often are between parents and teenage children regardless of class circumstances, this tendency to stay away naturally intensifies. When parents speak about wishing they could have bigger flats, one of the reasons they mention is that their kids can then have their own private space and perhaps even bring friends home to do homework, study, socialize, without being disturbed by younger siblings and other family members.

Unlike kids whose parents have money for enrichment and/ or leisure activities, kids from low-income families have more hours in the day when they are unoccupied and away from adults. Compared to kids who are more financially dependent on their parents and therefore perhaps compelled to be more pliant, teenagers from low-income households more often earn their own pocket money through part-time work. In certain ways, they are more mature, independent, and autonomous than their middle-class counterparts. They also tend to have peers who are similarly independent and therefore available to hang out with. As a result of this confluence of factors, parents are more likely to have limited influence over their kids. Hence, people express worries not just about very young children but also about teenage ones. Parenting older children is as difficult as, and indeed sometimes more difficult than parenting young children. Kids sometimes stop going to school, stay out late, or stay away from home altogether. To put this plainly, middle-class parents hold sway over their teenage children partly through circumstance. Their financial dependence on parents, their use of personal spaces in their homes, their scheduled activities are all conditions that grant parents continued access to influence over their everyday lives. Absent of these conditions, authority is tough to maintain for low-income parents.

Time, leisure, memories

Kids have shifting needs over their life course. The difficulties in addressing older kids' needs are not often discussed as a care gap problem. Yet, as we see needs shift from everyday physical care to relationship building and trust formation, the availability of time, energies, and parental authority become more crucial than ever. When we place shifting needs over the life course at the center of our attention, we see that family life is not just about meeting biological needs. Parenting is not merely about keeping children alive. While children above a certain age no longer need constant supervision, family relationships make a big difference to parents' and children's well-being.

When we pay attention to the ever-evolving and complex needs of kids, and not just their physical care, we see new challenges in parenting while being low-income.

In the early days of my research, a community worker told me that they sometimes organize overnight staycations for families. These are simple affairs: they go to a chalet and bring food to barbeque. The community worker had prepared a photo album for a family after one such staycation—printed out photos from the weekend and put them into an album. She wanted to deliver the album to the family. At first, I misunderstood her purpose. I thought the point was the material, physical object—a photo album with printed photos as a luxury the families could not afford. But as she explained why they did this, and as I later heard families speak of these weekends with great fondness, I realized that this was about memory-building. The families do not often have opportunities to be together to relax and enjoy themselves as a family. The nights away and the photos—they are about building some happy memories of family life.

As I write this, I think about my own office and home, and about numerous other people's offices and homes. We surround ourselves with pictures of people we care about, mostly in leisurely settings: there's me and my sibling in front of our bikes, there's me and my family and best friend on holiday in Istanbul, there's me and my old classmates at a Chinese New Year's gathering, there's me and my proud parents at my graduation. Memories sustain us—they tell us who we are and to

whom we're connected. We surround ourselves with photographs so that we can look at these happy moments and remember we belong to somebody, some people belong to us, and we are not alone.

The photographs in the album are thus not merely physical objects. They evoke the pleasure of an unusual weekend of leisure. For families who live everyday lives under intense time and money pressure, they represent memories of things other than housework, emotions other than stress, and shared moments between family members beyond instructions or quarrels.

If family is, as we are so often reminded, a basic unit of society, we must remember that it is not merely a functional, economic unit. Parent-child relationships are not just transactions: I feed you, you stay alive, one day you feed me so I stay alive. Relationship-building and trust-building are important life activities happening in the inside of families. And these life activities require time of a particular sort—time for leisure, time for play, time for rest. Self-help parenting books abound with this wisdom: communicate, spend time together on fun things, build trust, and these relationships will endure throughout one's life.

Weekend getaways are relatively rare for the families I meet. I do not mean that people do not know how to have fun. Some families still manage to carve out leisure in spite of money and time limitations; they are resourceful in finding free places and activities to do. But for most families, leisure is difficult to manage—there are so many demands on time, so much wage work occurs during times when other families are resting, so many activities in Singapore require money. This becomes especially challenging as kids become older. Unlike young children who can be easily entertained by just a visit to a playground or park, older kids are harder to please and what interests them tend to cost more. The building of family life and happy memories, it turns out, is deeply class-inflected.

The world beyond: parental authority is social

Parental authority is difficult to maintain for a poignant reason. I've regularly heard parents say that they hope their children will not be like them. Indeed, this is the lesson they often tell their children: "study hard, don't be like me." Their dreams and aspirations are frequently along the lines of "I want my kids to not be like me," or as in the previous essay, "I want my children better than me."

As a teacher and a parent, the most powerful tool of influence I have with younger people comes often and deeply not from what I say, but from who I am. I can advise students to take certain steps or abide by certain principles because I have taken them. Importantly, they accept my advice as legitimate because they can see where those steps have taken me. I can tell my child about my experiences in school and she can know that missteps and failures are not fatal because she sees that I am a 'success' in the eyes of Singapore society. When you are parenting as a person whose path is not seen as admirable by conventional standards, as someone who is not perceived as a success in your social world, your authority is inevitably suspect. This is not to say that children do not respect their parents. They do. In fact, in many homes I was in, I saw many gestures of such respect. Among Malay families, for example, the act of salaam—where children bow to kiss the hand of their elders as a form of greeting and farewell—is a striking and beautiful physical manifestation of such respect. Nonetheless, to say that parents lack authority in these circumstances is to point out that it is difficult to tell younger people—listen to me, but don't do what I did and don't become like me.

Parenting is an activity performed within society. Nobody is a mother or a father in a social vacuum. The challenges of parenting are linked not just to our own children's needs—they are also tied to how to parent in 'normal' ways in a given society and at a given historical moment. We figure out all kinds of things about what a 'good mother' or a 'good father' is from people around us—what neighbors, co-workers, friends, sometimes strangers in lifts say to us; the advice we get from teachers, doctors, and other authority figures; the messages we are sent as we interact with various policy practices. When we consider each of these, we see that one of the profound difficulties of parenting while low-income is that one has

to parent in a social context where one is, and knows that one is, negatively judged as a parent.

One thing my respondents, and especially mothers, tell me when we talk about their kids is that they are not like "other parents" in their neighborhoods. Zee, for example, says that she is very strict with her four children. They have to do their homework every day before they play; they are expected to help with cleaning up the flat and the older kids have to take care of their younger siblings; importantly, they are not allowed to loiter downstairs. Like many parents I met, she talks about wanting to move out of their rental flat because of the neighborhood. She tells me she sees a lot of kids staying out late in the neighborhood. Some, as young as 13 or 14, are already smoking. She feels "heart pain" seeing that. She is very strict, different from other parents. I regularly hear this reference to the undesirability of the neighborhood as well as to this notion of parenting differently. Why does it come up so frequently? The parents' worries are certainly real—there are undeniably more risks in their neighborhoods. But there is also something going on that has to do with the social interaction between them and me. The parents who speak of their uniqueness in the neighborhood are seeking recognition, affirmation, and dignity as they perform parenting to me, the researcher. They are showing their understanding, in our social exchange during these afternoon chats, of where *I* come from, and how people like me tend to judge people like them. In these moments, the conversation moves forward to the extent that I nod, when my face expresses understanding, and insofar as I make sounds signaling empathy. I am aware of the need to show that I am listening, acknowledging, not judging— that I am behaving in ways people like me often don't. They are visibly encouraged when community workers praise them for being good mothers; in those moments, they smile, modestly saying "have to lah."

How do I know this is about dignity and the need for affirmation? Often, in my conversations with low-income persons, their tense interactions with authority figures come up. Sometimes they refer to teachers who make them feel stressed because every conversation is about their kids' problems in school and what they

should do to help them. More often, it is about their interactions with people from whom they are seeking financial assistance. This may not be obvious to the people taking this line of questioning, but every question along the lines of "why don't you put your kid in student care? Why don't you go find a better-paying job? Why don't you go for more training?" adds to the sense low-income parents have that people in positions of authority do not believe they are good parents or smart enough to make the right decisions. If people are always trying to give you advice about your parenting, often without knowing much about how you parent, you would probably also feel like no one thinks you are a worthy parent. These interactions make them feel belittled. Months, sometimes years after they have happened, people can recollect details of those interactions. Exchanges that probably lasted no more than a few minutes have clearly been played over and over in their minds. The moments when they remind me they are exceptions in their neighborhoods, and when myself or community workers acknowledge them as good parents, must be understood in this context.

Wealth and social status matter a lot in this city. Everyone in Singapore knows this. You can see it in the body language of people interacting as customers and wait-staff at restaurants; you see it in the bodies of people brushing past each other in public spaces; you hear it in the voices of people speaking to people 'higher' and 'lower' than themselves. We are an extremely status-conscious society—where there are people who serve and people who are served, and people are expected to manage their bodies, to adjust their tones, accordingly. Parenting while low-income is about parenting with the knowledge that one has low status in this society. And so low-income parents find themselves having to do this immensely difficult thing: they have to tell their kids to listen to them and yet also send them the message "don't be like me." It is difficult to exercise authority under these conditions. To have one's parenting practices be unintelligible, unacknowledged, deemed less worthy, is a profound form of attack on the self, especially when being a parent is a central part of one's identity.

Parenting is hard. And it is hard at multiple stages of life. It is hard in good

circumstances, but harder yet when one has limited money, time, and social standing.

Growing up without class protections

Over the years, I've had mixed feelings about my research findings. Should I interpret what I see as strength, signs of 'resilience,' or should I think of them as lacks, as 'problems'? Increasingly, I see that neither alone are complete and that both are true. The two interpretative frames have to be held simultaneously, difficult as that is given their seeming contradictions. We need to recognize this: the fact that individuals make the best of their circumstances does not mean that their circumstances are acceptable.

> This is from a fieldnote I wrote after a visit in 2014:
>
> We enter the flat. It is a one-room flat. A woman is cooking some sambal belacan dish. The smell stays with me long after we leave the flat. The flat is sparsely furnished. Mattresses are leaned against a wall. An ashtray is on the floor, and there are several cigarette butts in it. The family has three cats; a grey one, very hairy, roams around during our visit. The two kids are very friendly—they had big open smiles and expressions, were affectionate and warm to each other, and very hospitable to us. They invited us to sit down on the floor and proceeded to sit down themselves. The boy wandered off into the kitchen and brought back two glasses of chrysanthemum drinks. I am struck by how well-mannered they are in this regard; I can't think of too many children in my social milieu who would know to go and bring drinks for guests on their own.

When I read my field notes, I see that I was impressed by the kids I met: kids who greeted me when I went to their homes; kids who brought drinks and offered them

to guests with two hands; kids who spoke respectfully and humbly; kids who sat quietly on the side without vying for the attention of their parents as we talked. From their parents, I learnt of kids who step up to help adults— with housework, with care of younger siblings, with earning money, with caring for a sick parent. From teachers, I know that these kids, though academically weak, are often the most helpful ones when teachers require assistance with this and that. They are imperfect and, as mentioned, I hear of the troubles they get into. But as a group, these kids strike me as mature, independent, respectful, sometimes astonishingly selfless. It is important to highlight their strengths because in our public discourse, they are much maligned; their lacks—failing exams, truancy, smoking, misdemeanors—are all that get airing.

Observing that they have strengths, that they are good kids is not, however, the same as saying they are alright. Indeed, one must also notice that these are young people whose opportunities are limited, and whose paths are full of peril.

*

I met Mui when she was already ill. She was in her 40s. She had undergone treatment for cancer but her prognosis was not good. Mui was a single mother to Aaron, then 14 years old. There were pictures of her son as a kindergartener on a wall of her flat. She pointed to them as she spoke fondly of how cute and smart he was. Though I visited her flat three times, I never met the boy. By the time she was ill, he was a typical teenager who preferred to hang out with his friends. She lamented that he was sullen with her, and that he'd picked up smoking. As she became weaker, the boy's future—where he would live and with whom—became an urgent source of anxiety. Mui had a mother and siblings, but none of them, at the time of her being sick, were keen to be guardians for the boy. They did not have a close relationship with him, and they also had other responsibilities and dependents of their own. By the third time I was in her flat, Mui was so weak she could barely speak. Her sister, a chatty and cheerful woman, spoke as she went about helping

Mui with housework and cooking. She talked about how hardworking Mui was when she was well. She recounted the difficult relationship she and her siblings had with their mother when they were young. She talked about her thinking that Mui's son should go live with their other sister, his aunt, and about how she herself could not take him on because she is often not at home. She expressed how important it is that he be closely supervised because if he were to run away, he would be lost to the family forever. It took me some months, and further instances of hearing about youth who do not return home and cannot be located by their families, before I fully appreciated that she had real cause for concern. A child in this context could actually become 'lost' to their family. Unpredictable, catastrophic events can happen in anyone's life; families with more money, too, face illness, divorce, death. All families, to some degree, face tension and conflict in relationships. But it is after hearing about youth who can be lost that I began to see that young people in low-income families bear higher levels of risk. They are especially vulnerable in times of familial crises; the costs they bear when relationships are fraught are higher; their paths are more easily disrupted.

For this book, I did not interview kids. To more fully understand their perspectives, further research needs to be done. I did, nonetheless, observe many of them hanging around the neighborhood. Because I was often in flats, I also sometimes met them if they were at home. I heard about them through their family members and social workers. Indirectly, I also gained insight about what it is to be young in low-income households through adults telling stories about their own years as youth. From these various accounts, it is clear that being young in low-income circumstances is extremely challenging.

To be young is to be restless and somewhat misunderstood. It is to have certain understandings about the world and the energy and desire to partake in it and then to face frustrations at one's lack of power to do so fully. I remember these feelings from my own youth. I detect it when I hear my students or younger friends talk about their lives. To be young and middle-class is to be able to delay autonomy, to hold off responsibility toward others, to be given the benefit of the doubt when

one makes mistakes, to have time to learn, to live under parental protection until one is ready to fly. Youth from low-income families do not have the luxury of time to ride this stage out. For kids in this neighborhood, independence and responsibilities kick in early—household obligations, wage work, parenthood, support of younger siblings or parents, relational crises and conflicts. In the midst of this, many youth still somehow manage to survive and thrive—this perhaps explains their street-wise vibes. Many others, understandably, have a tough time.

Why do I describe these burdens and vulnerabilities? In the previous section, I lay out the ways in which parenting youth is difficult under low-income conditions. To see how this plays out for their kids is to see that the lives of parents and children are deeply intertwined. It is also to see that the reproduction of class—whether class disadvantage or advantage—is the default route. In our current social context, mobility, not stasis, is the puzzle and exception.

"Family as first line of support"

Parenting is a socially embedded activity. By this, I mean two things. First, it is linked to other elements of everyday life— wage work, familial interactions, schooling. Second, it is shaped by and rooted in the broader expectations, demands, and habits of society. No one, in other words, is 'just' a parent, and no one parents in isolation. While we are parents, we are also simultaneously employees, co-workers, spouses, siblings, daughters/sons, neighbors, friends. We figure out how to be parents partly from how teachers relate to us, what extended family members ask of us, what friends and acquaintances advise us, what 'professionals'—doctors, counsellors, social workers— tell us. Many of us like to imagine we are independent —how many times have I heard people declare "I just do what I want to do and I don't care what other people say"?—but the reality is that what makes for a 'good' or 'bad' parent is shaped by circumstances and informed by criteria beyond any given individual's control.

Parenting under poor conditions involves high pressures from lack of money and lack of control over time. These lead to care gaps not only for very young children but also for older ones. They make building family lives—including happy memories of play and leisure, and everyday life-activities of communication and relationship-building—tremendously difficult.

So much of well-being in Singapore is premised on the presence and support of the family unit. Our access to various public goods is heavily mediated through the individual family— from housing, to healthcare, to retirement support.1 In education, too, parents' involvement and investments have become more central than ever. The heavy reliance on the family unit across the class continuum, together with the inequalities we see between families, has profound long-term consequences not just for different levels of luxuries but for the meeting of basic needs.

Policies cannot and probably should not anticipate all irrationalities and breakdowns in individual families. Nonetheless, given the heavy presumption in the delivery of public goods that 'family is the first line of support,' more must be done to ensure that a reasonable *family life*—which is more than just the formation of a family *unit*—is not a class privilege.

In recent years, there has been talk of leveling the playing field by investing resources into supporting children from low-income households. Public resources have been put into education, including early childhood education. This is a good thing. But children's and parents' well-being are not disconnected, and indeed school lives are not independent of family lives. Leveling the playing field must therefore also include narrowing the distance between low-income families' family life and that of higher-income families.

In the everyday interior of home, our experiences of family are not just of persons as economic digits, of family members as narrow economic actors—breadwinner, dependent, future wage-earner, past wage-earner. We live with living, breathing persons— with whom we quarrel, for whom we care, with whom we share laughter and tears. To perform interdependence within the family, for the

family to act as an economic unit—as our public policy wills us to do—we still need these ties that bind. The right to family cannot be limited to family as a mere economic unit. Given the centrality of the family for well-being in this society, we should have the right not just to form families, but to give and receive care, and to build meaningful and dignified lives together.

These three years of research have, inadvertently, been years of personal learning and reflection. My respondents' have been sources of wisdom. Through them, I saw the value of patience, of generosity, of hard work, of expressions of affection and appreciation. My afternoons in the neighborhoods were enjoyable ones—I felt a slowing down of time when people welcomed me into their homes and spoke with me when I just showed up at their doorstep. I felt a jolting but welcome contrast to my usual professional interactions when people talked openly just as a matter of sharing and not because I could offer them anything in return. I became a little nostalgic seeing kids hanging out and playing on their own in ways that are reminiscent of my own childhood. Over and over, I have been impressed by people's resilience and ability to bounce back after setbacks; by their beliefs in hard work and positive thinking in the face of continual adversity; by the centrality of interpersonal interactions, relations, and trust that make up the texture of everyday lives; by many parents' willingness to sacrifice in profound ways for their kids. I often put myself in their shoes after a field visit and wonder if I have it in myself to be as strong, kind, generous. Many of my respondents inspire me to be a better parent—more forgiving, more loving, more open to seeing my child as a separate person from me. Being around them has forced me to rethink much of what I take for granted as 'normal' ways of being.

People sometimes say that (more well-off) Singaporeans should visit low-income places—either in Singapore or in neighboring countries—so that we can better appreciate how good our lives are. In a recent focus group discussion for another research project I'm involved in, participants commented that traveling, particularly to countries in our region, helps people see how poor other places are

and that "Singapore is still the best." The logic seems rooted in an assumption that I find troubling: someone else's suffering makes my life look better. My experience these past few years suggests instead that if we want to learn about and from others, we must be willing to go beyond being merely passersby. And we have to go beyond the presumption that our perspectives, experiences, worldviews are the only ones there are or the only ones that matter.

Why is it important to make this point? As I have argued, none of us parent in a vacuum. The low social esteem and worth low-income parents face are significant in shaping parent-child relations. Acknowledgements of parents' efforts, love, and sacrifice, are as far and few between as they are important. It matters that we make legible and legitimate these qualities of parenting that I witnessed. Caricatures of low-income parents, unfair prejudices, and a refusal to recognize social context and limitations—these cannot be the basis of our collective practices. If we are serious about wanting to expand opportunities for kids from low-income families, then all of us—including teachers, social workers, policy makers, researchers—need to overcome our narrow lenses and indeed our prejudices.

'Good' and 'bad' parents exist across the class spectrum. For the most part, none of us are completely good or completely bad. A more accurate way of describing parenting may be to say that we often try and often fail, and we hope that we will raise good people despite our trials and errors. We do our best in specific social contexts with particular conditions and circumstances. Some of this is the outcome of luck, but much of this context is created through the choices we make as a society —in the policies and laws we push for or do not push for, in the institutional practices we design and implement, and in the ways we conduct ourselves in relation to others.

1 More on this in the essay, "Differentiated Deservedness."

Differentiated Deservedness

FOR THE SINGAPOREAN, the state's presence in everyday life is as persistent as air. No book on inequality and poverty is complete without an explicit discussion of the state's place in the picture. In this essay, I lay out the key principles that underlie the state's approach to welfare and the consequences this has on the way we are—our Singaporean-ness.

This essay draws from work I have published in more academic settings.[1] Although I have rewritten it with the intention of it being more accessible to a general audience, it retains some of the more rigid structure and specialized language of academic work. I hope this does not put people off—this essay sits at the center of the book because it is the heart of our challenges.

It may also be a difficult read insofar as it is a reminder of the difficulties involved in undoing injustices. For those of us who care about reducing inequalities, the challenges we face—they are systemic, they are cultural, they are intertwined.

I am a sociologist. My training and professional role are for me to ask questions, to look, to unpack, to analyze, to critique. I am well aware that this is insufficient to bring about change. But I think it is an important part of the process, a necessary precondition to further imagining of alternatives. Solutions to problems depend first on asking the right questions, on accurately diagnosing and framing what is at stake. If we prescribe solutions before we understand our problems, the solutions will necessarily be limited.

Before reading this piece, I invite you to keep two simple questions in mind: can we resolve the problems of poverty and inequality which I have described in earlier essays? What stands in the way of resolution?

Delivering public goods: the centrality of wage work and marriage

When it comes to housing, healthcare, retirement, and care needs, the state intervenes deeply in regulating the channels of provision and routes to access. From the perspective of a citizen, however, these intensive interventions do not translate into guaranteed access. Meeting needs depends on a combination of regular employment and stable marriages where men and women play gendered roles. How well the needs are met and how securely they can be met in the long-term depends further on income sufficient for savings and/or investments as well as maintaining interdependent economic relationships within families.

From public housing to healthcare, childcare to retirement, people have to do regular and continuous wage work and then essentially purchase each of these with their income. There are no universal provisions. Singaporeans are compelled to save for these needs through an employment-linked compulsory savings account—the Central Provident Fund (CPF), and this alone is generally insufficient. Persons who find themselves without wage work at some point in their lives—women who are caregivers; disabled persons; elderly persons—are to depend on family members who are employed before turning, as a last resort, to public support.

Subsidies for services are dependent on rigid familial forms. Being and staying married are preconditions to accessing public goods, most notably housing. A gendered division of labor— where husbands are breadwinners and wives are responsible for care functions—is supported and reproduced by policies concerning parental support (e.g. maternity/paternity leave; childcare center subsidies; foreign domestic worker regulations; tax reliefs for married working mothers). Men and women who are not in marriages find it more difficult to access public housing. People who leave marriages via divorce are required to sell their flats. Children who are born of unmarried women receive less support; until changes announced in April 2016, unmarried women could not even access government-paid maternity leave. Unmarried women and their children still cannot form 'family nucleus' to apply for public housing. Support for healthcare costs are subject to means tests which take into account the income and savings of the patient as well as other members of her/his family. Elderly persons who have no income receive support

only after they are able to prove that they do not have adult children who can support them.

The financing of a wide range of needs via employment income means that all citizens face substantial insecurity if they lose their jobs or are unable to work, either temporarily or permanently. The consequences are especially severe for those who do not have sufficient income to be set aside while they are employed and, as implied above, are not connected to other income-earners via marriage. Payment for public housing and healthcare are deeply dependent on regular income, so the costs to basic well-being for people and households without substantial savings are direct and swift. Eligibility for support is deeply dependent on one's ties to other family members, so marital and familial conflicts can quickly slide into insecurity over the meeting of basic needs of shelter. For women who have been caregivers and not wage earners, in particular, the loss of connection to a male breadwinner can mean immediate hardship for themselves and their children.

These key principles—employment income as the primary mode for meeting needs, and a specific marital form as criteria for accessing public support—are justified in the language of 'self-reliance' and 'protecting traditional Asian family values.' The logic is that if the state does too much, this will erode the work ethic and/or family's interdependence. Intended or unintended, we should note this outcome: access to public goods is both individualized and differentiated—you get what you are allowed to access and able to buy.

Institutionalization

The individualized and differentiated access to public goods in Singapore is not a residual or inevitable outcome of free market forces. Neither is it just national discourse, mere rhetoric. Instead, it is deeply institutionalized and reproduced through state institutions. There are specific, regularized, and wide-ranging constraints that shape the path, quality and quantity of people's access to various

public goods.

For starters, many national-level systems exist. There is a national education system that all citizens are required to participate in. Healthcare services are provided through both 'private' and 'public' hospitals, but the state coordinates and regulates both.[2] Most housing in Singapore is built and sold through a state agency —the Housing & Development Board (HDB). Finally, a state institution compels and coordinates the individual savings of all employed citizens and permanent residents.

This final instrument is worth elaboration. With the exception of education—where subsidies are more universally applied and fees kept relatively low (if one doesn't account for the tuition industry)—financing for healthcare, housing, and retirement are individualized through the Central Provident Fund (CPF) system.

Each employed Singapore citizen or Permanent Resident is required to have a CPF account. A portion of monthly salaries goes into their individual accounts (with specific proportions going into each of three accounts—Ordinary, Special, and Medisave); part of this is framed as employee contributions and the other as employer contributions. The contribution rates vary primarily by age and income. The money accumulated in an individual's account can be used for the following: retirement, public housing, healthcare, and investment in a selected range of financial products. Unlike pension systems in Europe, the money accumulated belongs to the individual. Prior to 55 years old, an individual may withdraw from her/his CPF (Ordinary) account only to pay for housing or hospitalization. After age 55, individuals may withdraw money from their accounts, but generally only what is in excess of mandated minimum sums, put in place to prevent depletion of individual accounts at age 55. Since 2009, CPF members have also been enrolled in an annuity plan, CPF Life, that provides a monthly income from age 65 for as long as they live. There is some pooled risk and an insurance component, and all who are enrolled in the CPF Life will receive some income for the rest of their lives; however, the plan's financing structure stays within individual accounts and how much any given person receives monthly is dependent on the amount of money

remaining in her/his account at age 55. Through the CPF, then, people's ability to pay for public housing, healthcare, and retirement, is dependent on how long they have been able to sustain continual employment over their lifetime and their level of earnings during their wage-earning years.

To say that the Singapore system institutionalizes access and that this access is individualized is to point out a number of things.

First, this is a mandatory system—there is no opting out.[3] This is a cornerstone of the concept of institutionalization—that certain practices become regular, automatic, and far-reaching.

Second, there are specific and rigid rules and regulations around both contribution and usage: the state sets and adjusts specific amounts of contribution to individual CPF accounts as well as minimum sums that have to remain in an account even upon retirement; it also requires, for example, co-payments when people use their CPF to fund health services, and stipulates CPF moneys to be returned to the individual accounts of married/ divorced couples when housing is sold.

Third, the various institutions are highly connected and coordinated: buying a flat and seeking hospital treatment triggers bureaucratic interventions across state agencies.

Fourth, the CPF system is not set up to have societal-wide transfers—either intergenerational or cross-class.[4] An individual's capacity to fund her/his retirement, housing, and healthcare depends on the salary received while employed.

Fifth, because individual CPFs have not generally been adequate,[5] individuals need to have additional individually-coordinated savings, investments, personal insurance, or alternative sources of income (including adult children who will support them), in order to adequately meet all their needs.

Finally, the state recognizes, encourages, and services a differentiated market: public housing comes in different sizes and prices, and with variant allusions to social status; health services can be purchased at different 'class' wards and in different types of hospitals with longer or shorter wait times that match up with a

person's ability to pay; childcare centers and kindergartens vary widely in price and quality.

The system in which we meet our needs therefore compels Singaporeans to live within these principles: individual responsibility and 'self-reliance' via stable and continuous employment; general absence of social security; minimal redistribution; and familial interdependence where 'family' is also defined as an individual unit and interdependence entails specific gendered and intergenerational care practices. Importantly, the type and quality of service we can access depends on people's (varied) abilities to pay.

Residual, Targeted, and Conditional 'Help'

Public housing, healthcare, education, and retirement, are not usually framed as 'welfare' in the national debate. This signals, quite aptly, that none of these goods or services are universal citizenship rights. Instead, similar to other liberal regimes such as the US and UK, 'welfare' often refers narrowly to aid that is targeted at the low-income. In such regimes, welfare is a term that has negative connotations of over-dependence, parasitic behavior, and exceptionalism. "We are not a welfare state" is a statement regularly declared by citizens and they mean to imply this is a positive thing.

Unsurprisingly, public policy designed to address the 'exceptional'—the low-income in a wealthy city—is designed with free-riders in mind. They are residual rather than comprehensive, narrowly targeted (through asset and means tests), and highly conditional.

The Singapore state has characterized its approach toward 'the needy' as one that relies on three principles: "help the needy and their families achieve self-reliance; encourage families to be the first line of support for the needy; spur community organizations to participate in helping the needy under a 'Many Helping Hands' approach."[6]

In recent years, a large number of complicated schemes targeting low-income households have come into existence. They are aimed at increasing the income of low-wage workers (e.g., Workfare Income Supplement); at subsidizing preschool costs for low-income families (e.g., ComCare Child Care Subsidies); at tiding low-income households over in times of crisis (e.g., ComCare Urgent Financial Assistance); and at subsidizing medical costs for low-income persons (e.g., MediFund).

Three intertwined features of these programs are noteworthy: first, they are residual. That is, they are clearly earmarked as targeting a specific and small group of Singaporeans rather than part of broad, universal citizenship rights to social security. Indeed, they are explicitly framed as being for the exceptional: although most Singaporeans have done well, there are a minority who have not and hence need extra 'help' and these schemes are for them.[7] These are residual, corrective measures because not everything can be "left to the market."[8]

Second and relatedly, they are narrowly targeted. Here, I refer to the fact that specific sums are aimed at specific people/households within designated and narrow criteria. The Workfare Income Supplement (WIS), for example, is aimed at supplementing the income and CPF contributions of workers above 35 years old, who earn less than S$2,000 per month, and who have been employed for at least one month in a given three-month period. Within this group, the amount received depends on a confluence of factors including age, income, the value of the worker's residential property, and whether the worker is in wage work or self-employed. 40 per cent of the WIS is in cash while 60 per cent is in CPF. These details tell us that the programs are configured for and correspondingly fulfill narrow definitions of need.

The policies are designed to ensure that no one gets more than what the state has designated as their 'need.' What is at stake here is not only that the low-income may not be receiving sufficient support, but that this way of framing support creates indignity for 'recipients' through marking qualification as exceptional and for the most 'needy.' Similarly, applicants to temporary cash aid through ComCare are

subject to strict means tests (to ensure, primarily, that there are no adequate income sources in the family at the moment) and to reviews every three to six months.

I was surprised at how often my respondents, who are in the lowest earning segment of the population, spoke about *not* applying for 'help' because the process is so difficult and, even more astoundingly, because they think they should "leave it for others" in greater need. It appeared that they too take for granted that 'self-reliance' is paramount. In desperate circumstances, they still insisted they are "ok, still can manage."

This sense that state support is 'help' for the most 'needy,' rather than social security for all citizens, is deepened through a third feature, in which support is conditional on social identities and everyday individual practices. In particular, class-specific, gendered familial performances are key to shaping access.

Support for childcare, for example, is differentiated—type of support (maternity leave, Baby Bonus, tax reliefs, subsidies); amounts of subsidies; and delivery channels (foreign domestic workers, childcare centers, or kindergartens) differ—based on household income, mothers' income, marital status of parents, and employment status of mothers. For low-income women looking to access support for childcare, continuous employment is a precondition—signaling the norm of wage work and the conditionality of aid.

If we pay attention only to specialized programs, it appears like the low-income are the focus of a lot of 'welfare.' In the many lectures I have given about my research, I have heard this articulated among audience members with some regularity: there are so many programs for the very poor now, the government is doing so much. Yet, if we step back and look at the big picture, we see that, within our system, low-income Singaporeans have the most trouble meeting their needs for housing, childcare, healthcare, and long-term security. In contemporary Singapore, the primary things that matter in securing all of these is income from employment and being in a specific family form. We take this so much for granted that we rarely ask why and how public goods have come to be organized so much like regular commercial goods and services.[9]

Within the existing logic of market participation and purchase of needs, as long as endemically low wages and workers' exploitation are missing from the discussion, and as long as 'family' is unquestionably accepted as a singular thing, it will appear that people who cannot meet their needs are 'failures,' exceptions who 'fall through the cracks.' A phrase that comes up at almost every event I have attended where poverty is discussed—'identifying the truly needy'—tells us that even among people who ostensibly care about poverty, there is a common-sense acceptance that among the low-income population, there are those who simply have not tried hard enough to succeed. For what is 'truly needy' if there is no 'not truly needy' in one's imagination?

Differentiated Deservedness

In the design and delivery of public goods, we see articulations of what I call differentiated deservedness. People have different types of access and degree of public support depending on who they are *and* how they live.

Here I'd like to make a subtle analytical distinction between the concepts of discrimination and differentiation. Discrimination describes the process by which existing social groupings are granted uneven access to goods and services, where some people are granted more/less access because they belong to one category and not the other. The concept of discrimination is very useful because it allows us to see unequal treatment. But it generally leaves untouched the assumption that certain social categories are self-evident and have relatively coherent boundaries. So we may say, for example, that unmarried people are discriminated against in housing policies—they are a group that does not have access in the same way that married people have access to public housing. This formulation is not wrong, but it presumes that the categories of 'unmarried' and 'married' are self-evident—that people form coherent groups within each, and that marriage/ nonmarriage is a natural way to organize the distribution of housing.

Differentiation, on the other hand, pushes us to think of the process in more *productive* terms. It brings attention to the fact that what is also happening is an act of creating categories and rendering them meaningful. The concept reminds us that social categories do not sprout in nature and that once created, they are not simply bureaucratic labels but also become crucial parts of people's identities. The act of differentiating *generates* particular practices and *gives meaning* to categories. Through the complex confluence of public policies—including rules about 'unmarried' and 'married' people, for example—content and meanings are given to those categories, rendering them socially real and significant. Being married or not married come to connote specific things in Singapore society—they become a crucial lens for our understanding of ourselves and of each other.

To pay attention not just to discrimination but also to differentiation is to see that the categories—husbands/wives, straight/gay, old/young, employed/non-employed, married/ unmarried, parent/childless, able-bodied/disabled, graduate/non-graduate— *become* socially relevant categories in contemporary Singapore precisely because they are so significant in our public policies and for our fulfilling of key needs. Public policies not only emphasize different benefits for men versus women, or people with more versus less income. They cast meaning on personal practices. Heterosexuality, womanhood, employment, are necessary but in themselves insufficient conditions to access important things. Instead, heterosexuality must be performed within marriage during relative youth; womanhood has to be practiced through marriage, employment, and motherhood; and employment must be continuous, stable, and result in sufficient income which one is compelled to keep within one's nuclear family. In this way, policies mark citizens as having different roles, responsibilities, and rights depending on specific interweaving of social categories *and* everyday practices. Enacting heteronormativity —through marriage, through continuous employment, through having the right number of children that matches one's socioeconomic circumstances, through cultivating dependence across generations with one's parents or children—is key. Fall off the path at any point and pay a price in well-being and security.

To sum up, the welfare regime in Singapore can be characterized as such: first, people are compelled to fulfill their needs for housing, healthcare, childcare, and retirement primarily through regular participation in formal employment. There is no coordinated safety net for persons who are not in employment. Second, there is a high degree of state regulation and coordination when it comes to accessing public goods in Singapore. While social spending and redistribution are modest, institutionalization and disciplining are not. State agencies, laws, and policies together institutionalize what amounts to highly individualized and differentiated access to public goods. Specific heteronormative performances of the familial are important, and economic participation must be understood as also entailing familial interdependence of a specific form. Finally, where there is attention to the low-income who cannot fulfill needs through market participation, this 'help' is residual, targeted, and conditional. The wide range in the type and quality of services that come with different price tags naturalizes inequality. Living in a city where the type of housing, healthcare, education, and childcare we have is dependent on how much money we can spend, we come to accept that we deserve different levels of service depending on our wealth.

Despite recent state rhetoric in the direction of 'social inclusion,' then, the regime that is put into practice has a very thin sense of mutual obligations amongst members of society.[10] Instead, the ethic that is produced through everyday practice is one in which everyone has to take care of themselves as individuals and *individual* families.

The two realities of being Singaporean, or, can customers be loyal toward other customers

As I write this, National Day is around the corner. Military aircraft dragging the flag fly overhead. Lamp posts are plastered with banners featuring the faces of our

multicultural peoples. Songs about our nation, our pride, play over the radio. Singaporeans are reminded, in ways big and small, that we are one nation, one people, one Singapore. This nationalism—the articulation of our unity through symbols—is intensified at this time of the year but also persistent throughout the rest of it. The language of 'national good,' 'greater good of society'— this is language one can still use in Singapore's public discourse without being laughed off stage, without coming across as quaint and naïve. This is an aspect of our national culture; our shared discourse includes this claim that in Singapore, we are not as individualistic as in 'The West.' We put society above self.

An aspect of this discourse is true in the way that it is probably true of many other societies, including the much-maligned 'West.' Humans live in society and living in society— particularly in cities—requires certain levels of cooperation, altruism, a certain degree of giving up one's interests for a greater good.

But. This ideal of our country—made up of people who put society before self, a sociologist's dream—is everyday challenged by the other ethos we face living in Singapore: no one owes you anything and it's everyone for themselves (i.e. their families). This too has become our culture.

Ethics are created from collective practices. We should care about the principles that, every single day, underlie our shared practices—of employment, of enacting family, of flat application, of childcare, of saving for retirement, of paying for tutors, of socializing our children in 'filial piety'—because they are also the bricks that make up our public ethic.

Given particular mechanisms and principles of instituting access and lack thereof to public goods, what kinds of persons become marked as good citizens who deserve more, and what kinds as not-so-good and therefore deserving of less? In a system that emphasizes self-reliance and the family as the first line of support, what are thinkable and what are unthinkable ways of relating to one another in society?

Being an individual in an individual family unit—with specific behaviors, plans, desires, and ultimately money—is what brings about deservedness. We see

embedded in this logic a particular sort of agent with an individualized subjectivity: people are individuals, families are individual units. They should act for themselves, they must try to help themselves, they must be self-reliant, and their dependence on others must be minimized. In this schema, dependence is the ultimate individual failure and social ill. When people end up in different places—when we see some people living it up and others living on the edges—it is because they deserve it.

Thinking and living this every day, inequality appears inevitable.

The rah-rah of 'greater good' competes with our experiential reality.

Of mutual obligations, shared responsibilities and collective rights—where are the institutional mechanisms that allow us to live those? In lived realities, our definition of social membership is one where deservedness is an individual challenge, task, and responsibility. The traditional 'Asian family' itself turns out to be a cover—an individualized unit that also serves as legitimation for our lives detached from our fellow citizens.

If we each pay a price for the things we need in life, and if we are constantly reminded that we get exactly what we pay for, and that paying any more than for our own share would be unfair, can we really see and consider the other people who are also at the cashier?

Can customers think about other customers?

Our national discourse emphasizes sacrifice, community, greater good. Our institutions, our everyday lives—they regulate and compel individualism, competition, self-centeredness.

Reforms

Reforms are urgently needed, particularly in the East Asian regimes which are ageing rapidly and which have historically had low social welfare spending. That the current system is inadequate and requires reform is also accepted by policy makers and/or politicians in Singapore.

Two features of recent interventions stand out: first, there has been a strong focus on jobs. Second, there has been an expansion of schemes targeted at the low-income. The first set of interventions have primarily been oriented toward incentivizing employers to retain workers they may otherwise retrench. Aside from the Workfare Income Supplement, a slew of schemes have been introduced to subsidize companies' payrolls when they retain older and/or low-wage workers and when their workers attend training programs. The second set of schemes, aimed at low-income households, includes short-term cash aid and subsidies for childcare and schools. As mentioned, they have generally been designed as short-term measures with strict means-tests, are conditional on familial forms and practices, and are generally modest in sums.

The continuities in principles are notable.

First, there remains strong resistance to universalism. This is despite the fact that there have been some gestures at ensuring some baseline meeting of needs through the CPF Life and MediShield Life—the former to provide some income in old-age commensurate with income while working, and the latter medical insurance that aims to insure all citizens and permanent residents, primarily for coverage for high-cost treatments (certain chronic illnesses, surgery, and hospitalization).

The persistent resistance to universalism is expressed in three ways: in discussions about the importance of forging social inclusion, very little has been said or done about redistribution. On the contrary, the specter of raised income taxes continues to insert itself into state-led discussions of welfare. We continue to hear that Singapore's attractiveness to global businesses and 'talent' is dependent on keeping taxes low. Scholar of social welfare regimes, Daniel Béland, points out that 'social exclusion' invokes a horizontal spatial metaphor, in contrast to the vertical imagery that is produced when the focus is on income disparities.[11] We see this in the Singapore case—increased prominence given to the rhetoric of 'social inclusion' with minimal consideration of the power relations and exploitation that produce exclusions. The avoidance of direct discussions of inequality and the need for not merely 'inclusion' but redistribution prevents conversations about universalism.

A second way in which universalism continues to be sidestepped—even actively avoided—is through the strong commitment to finely-calibrated means tests in most of the schemes that have been introduced in recent years. We see this in various subsidies for children's education and care, in cash aid and income supplements for the low-income, and in various policies that shape access to healthcare services.

A third way in which universalism is avoided is through something less obvious: a ghettoization of the problem of poverty. In state discourse about poverty, notions about 'charity,' and about those with more 'helping' those with less, have become increasingly salient. In tandem with this, a slew of new specialized agencies, programs and schemes, and personnel have been constructed to deal with 'the needy.' This way of framing the problem of poverty isolates it—detaches the issues and challenges faced by a small minority of the population from those faced by everyone else. It dislodges the issue of poverty from the broader political economy in which it is produced. Importantly, it frames public interventions as 'charity,' as 'help'—in other words, beyond public *responsibility*—and recipients as *recipients* rather than as members of society with rights to certain basic levels of well-being and security.

Aside from continued aversion toward universalism, recent reforms also persist in affirming the centrality of the family. As Esping-Andersen points out,[12] the commitment to the familial can be positive in the sense of enabling and forging solidarities between people; viewed particularly from the perspective of women, however, their real effects have tended to be uneven burdens and forced dependence. In its measures to enhance employment opportunities for workers, the Singapore state has paid very little attention to disrupting gendered roles at home and gender inequalities at work. In its policies prescribing 'work-life harmony,' it has in fact reaffirmed the double-burden of employment and domestic responsibilities for women.[13] Relatedly, heteronormativity—encompassing specific performances of both gender and sexuality—remains strongly affirmed through state institutions and practice. In various policies around public housing, childcare,

work benefits, mothers continue to be distinguished from fathers, unmarried mothers from married ones, married couples from unmarried persons. There is hence little in reforms thus far that point to genuine disruption of the principle of differentiated deservedness.

By not disrupting the ethic of individualism and differentiated deservedness, both of which are institutionalized and rendered common sense, recent reforms continue to affirm the importance of individual practices and 'choices,' and the acceptance of differences and inequalities in outcomes. In sidestepping the issue of universalism, it has made no moves toward constructing citizenship built upon an ethic of mutual obligations where there are, as Margaret Somers puts it, "reciprocal but nonequivalent rights and obligations between equal citizens."

Now what?

It is apparent that neoliberal capitalism has generated wide material disparities within societies. Singapore's income inequality, as measured by the Gini coefficient, ranks among the highest compared to other wealthy nations.[14] In 2016, per capita household income from work for the top 10% of households was S$12,773, which is 2.1 times that of the 81st–90th decile households (S$5,958); 5.4 times that of the 41st–50th decile households (S$2,339); and 23 times that of the lowest 10% households (S$543).[15]

The many costs of being poor in a wealthy city and not fitting the 'ideal family' in the state's schema are clear to see: housing insecurity and very poor housing conditions; fear of seeking medical treatment because of lack of money; children who are already behind by the time they begin formal schooling at Primary One; inability to increase household income because care needs cannot be met; poor conditions in old age—including meeting basic needs for food—due to lack of accumulated savings. In other words, the need for well-being and security amongst the Singaporean population are particularly acute at the lower ends of the income

strata.

As populations age, family sizes shrink, capitalist crises intensify, and jobs across the board become less secure, we have to face the fact that people's needs for social security have expanded. In other words, although the focus of this book has been on the lowest-income, the conditions of insecurity and precarity they face are not quarantined in that segment of the population. Based on what we see in the world around us, we are no longer talking about a small minority nor a problem that will go away.[16]

There are at least two reasons why differentiated deservedness needs to be examined before needs can be properly met: first, and most obviously, to the extent that the principle of differentiated deservedness is embedded in social policies, the inequalities generated by capitalist logic are not alleviated but deepened by state policies. In other words, as long as access to public goods varies greatly in terms of affordability, and affordability in turn is heavily dependent on one's position in the capitalist economy, one's advantage or disadvantage from market participation maps onto their interactions with public goods. We have seen, moreover, that such differentiating also compels particular 'familial' performances of gender and sexuality; as more delay, reject, or leave marriage, reduce fertility—for a variety of reasons that are themselves related to security and well-being—social policies that continue to presume and insist on rigid familial forms are necessarily going to fall short of addressing real needs.

A second reason to scrutinize differentiated deservedness as we consider the way forward is this: as I have argued, state policies are not merely discriminating but producing certain categories, individualized orientations and sensibilities. This has implications for the politics of reform. What we have in this mode of governance is not just a state against a cohesive society, but a society split apart by varied and possibly competing interests; a society made up of members who are deeply individualized and embedded in a context where citizens accept that some people are more deserving and others less so. The process of reform, then, will not be an

easy path toward welfare expansion partly at least because of the 'society' that current welfare practices has produced.

To meet people's needs and bring about greater well-being for society, our bifurcated consciousness—greater-good-society-before-self on the one side; survival-of-the-fittest-care-for-my-family-first on the other—must be brought into coherence.

To overcome inequalities, unevenly distributed wealth, power, indignity, and hardships within our social body, we cannot remain customers.

Can customers think about other customers? No. We can't.

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1 Teo (2015); Teo (2017).

2 Lim (2013a).

3 People who have substantial alternative forms of retirement income may apply for exemptions from maintaining the mandated minimum sum at retirement, but contributions to the account prior to retirement are mandatory.

4 What inter-generational redistribution there is happens within individual familial units and on an ad hoc basis. Individuals who have met certain requirements for their own retirement needs (as specified by the CPF Board) may transfer funds into the CPF accounts of their parents, parents-in-law, grandparents, and grandparents-in-law.

5 Bhaskaran, Ho, Low, Tan, Vadaketh and Yeoh (2012); Hui (2012); Ng (2013).

6 Ministry of Social and Family Development (2017).

7 Shanmugaratnam (2014).

8 Shanmugaratnam (2011).

9 Jeremy Lim's book on the healthcare system contains some excellent reminders of just how recent the genesis from a more universal, publicly-funded form morphed into an individualized, privately-paid form. See Lim (2013a).

10 Somers (2008).

11 Béland (2007).

12 Esping-Andersen (1997).

13 Teo (2013).

14 Lim (2013b).

15 Singapore Department of Statistics (2016).

16 Standing (2011).

Needs, Wants, Dignity



Sketch by L, 2017.

TWO BOYS in a family, ages 10 and 9, were invited by a social worker to participate in a program where they could make a wish for anything under S$90. A few months later, they would know if their wishes have been picked by a donor organization.

I asked the social worker if all the wishes get fulfilled. He told me about some common problems. Donors insist on in-kind rather than cash gifts so sometimes gifts delivered are not exactly what the children asked for. Last year, a boy received a pink backpack that he didn't really like (he had asked for purple). The wait for the

wishes to be fulfilled is four long months; what they wanted when they made the request may no longer be as pressing by the time their requests are answered. About 80% of the requests get picked. That is, 20% do not, so some kids get left out in the end. This is tough since they were excited when asked what they wanted, and they see other kids receiving their gifts. Perhaps theirs were not seen as 'worthy' requests. Perhaps the stories written about them by social workers were not compelling enough. Perhaps their wishes were not seen as 'needs' but as 'wants.'

Wants are often needs.

That afternoon of my visit, the younger boy made his wish quickly. He was less tentative than his big brother about making his wish. "Soccer boots," he said immediately. "All my friends have." He plays soccer in school. His coach had asked him why he doesn't have soccer boots. All his friends have them. We took a few minutes to figure out his size. His mother brought out a measuring tape to measure his foot. She also looked at the size of his current school shoes. There was discussion about when the shoes will be gifted and how to take into consideration his feet growing in the next months. We were after all discussing Christmas in August. The social worker asked what his favorite colors were and wrote down his preferences. After the flurry of activity, the boy added that he would like long socks. He also used his hands to gesture the shape of a specific type of bag to put the shoes in. It is clear that he was so specific because many of his friends in his soccer CCA already had all these things he was describing.

The two boys took the opportunity very seriously, especially the older one. He smiled gently, excited by the prospect of making a wish. But he quickly turned pensive, thinking carefully, weighing various options. From where he was sitting, on the floor, he turned his face upward to look at his mother to make sure that his decision was the right one.

She too was taking the opportunity very seriously. She wanted her children to be able to fulfill their wishes, but also wanted to make sure the gifts were practical—things that they need urgently and will use regularly. She first suggested something

practical—swim trunks. The boy was unenthusiastic. He already has swim trunks, he mumbled softly. She suggested it because his younger brother doesn't have proper ones, but the younger boy had used up his own wish quickly by asking for soccer boots. When she saw her older son's reluctant expression and a tinge of disappointment, she backed down and let him decide for himself. He ended up wishing for badminton rackets because the ones they had were in bad condition.

The mother's desire for her children to have their wishes met is as strong as, if not stronger, than the children's own desires. I have met many parents like her. They talk about buying nice things for their children when they can—backpacks of specific brands, water bottles in particular styles, special shoes for soccer. It is not any bag, any bottle, any shoes—it is specific ones that their children want. Parents will know: Moana and Hello Kitty are different; Spiderman and Pikachu are not interchangeable. A backpack is not just a backpack.

Low-income parents talk about how sorry they feel when they cannot afford to buy things their children want. They talk about how they try to treat their kids when they have some extra cash, but how this cannot be a regular thing. They try to avoid walking through shopping centers so they don't have to keep feeling a complex mix of frustration, guilt, and pity for their children.

We all have things we desire—a book that just came out, a handsome wallet, a new pair of shoes, an updated phone. We all have things we need—a book that just came out, a handsome wallet, a new pair of shoes, an updated phone.

We need that book because all our friends have it and have been talking endlessly about it. We have a wallet but it's now old and a little embarrassing to bring out. We can't wear the same shoes every day; we feel our colleagues would notice. Having an updated phone makes us feel like we're moving with the times, not left behind.

What we frequently think of as wants, in specific contexts, are needs. They are, as the sociologist Allison Pugh's work shows, *dignity needs*.[1] They allow us to feel like we belong to the groups we care about, that we are rooted in, and that we need respect, acceptance and love from. As the title of Pugh's book suggests— we long

for things because we long to belong.

Shoes, clothes, backpacks, pencil cases, stickers, water bottles, toys—many of these things are not just articles that have objective use-value. They enable children to participate in and belong to social groups. They are bridges to new friendships and ties to bind old ones. In all social settings—school, soccer practice, tuition, community outings—the objects kids have, which most others have, allow them to blend in, to not call attention to themselves, to be part of the group.

Children from families with limited income, just as those from families with more income, feel the need to have what their friends have, to be able to participate just as their friends can. This includes the 'right' shoes, bags, toys, for a particular time and place. It often includes things that appear useless in the eyes of adults—fidget spinners, Pokémon cards, slime. I meet parents who want to fulfill these desires. To be able to please our children, to make them joyous, however fleeting, is an important part of being a good parent. Low-income parents cannot and do not expect to fulfill all their desires, but they recognize how important these things are to their children.

Sometimes dignity comes in the form of a pair of yellow and white soccer boots.

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Pugh, Allison J. 2009. *Longing and belonging: Parents, children, and consumer culture*. Berkeley, CA: University of California Press.

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Dignity Is Like Clean Air

OVER THE YEARS, I have been struck by the numerous times people told me details about small interactions. So-and-so did this and then that. So-and-so said this to me, I said this back, and they said this in return and so I said this. So-and-so was a Chinese/Malay/Indian, young/old, man/woman. I heard about interactions between neighbors, friends, family members. I heard about exchanges with bosses, co-workers, and teachers. I also heard about interactions with social workers and staff at social service organizations.

A widow told me she stays home and keeps her door shut because she is afraid of gossip if she talks to male neighbors; it's happened before. A father told me about being angry with his son's teacher because she said his son had done something but she had no evidence. A mother of two young kids told me she would not go to (a social service agency to) ask for help again because the last time she did, the staff there just told her to get a job. A man recounted a social worker of a particular ethnic group, short hair, not-so-old, and got annoyed just recalling her tone. Someone told me about quitting a higher-paying job and settling for a lower-paying one because the supervisor shouted at her and her co-workers.

A researcher doing qualitative research notes all of these stories. They don't seem especially noteworthy at first. But over time, I began to see a pattern. The interactions were often brief— no more than a few minutes. Sometimes they took place a long while back. Importantly, they were told to me to illustrate a larger lesson, a rationale to explain present decisions and behaviors. They were small encounters that meant a lot. I began to see that people talked about what appear to be minutiae because the incidences—though brief, though a long time ago—had hurt their feelings. These were encounters that made people feel small and they wanted to avoid feeling that way again.

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I often encounter surprise at my research topic of poverty in Singapore. The people I speak with about my work comment that poverty here is not visible, not in the way it is in cities where there are many homeless persons and panhandlers. This is true and I am indeed also often struck, when I visit other cities, by the sight of homeless people amidst skyscrapers, suits, and Starbucks cups. On the other hand, as I learnt more about the jobs that low-income persons in Singapore take on, I began to see that low-income persons are in reality highly present in most Singaporeans' everyday lives. In the rental flats, I met people who work as cashiers in chain stores that I shop at; as petrol kiosk attendants at places where I refuel my car; as deliverymen at the companies that deliver my goods; and, probably more frequently than any other job, as cleaners in office buildings, condominiums, shopping malls—all places that I am at on a regular basis. When I started paying more attention in my everyday life to low-wage workers, I realized that when we say we cannot see poverty in Singapore, it is partly because its manifestations are masked *and* partly because we do not look.

When I paid attention to people working in low-wage jobs, this is what I saw: often, people do not acknowledge their presence, even when they are directly interacting with them. Customers generally do not say hello to cashiers or make eye contact with them. Office-workers and residents frequently sidestep cleaners in their buildings as if they are invisible. Drivers cut into the lanes of motorcyclists and delivery vans. Supervisors and customers speak to them loudly and in demanding tones. People do not consistently say please and thank you. This is the reality of being a low-wage worker: one is ignored and invisible at best, yelled at and treated with disrespect at worst. This context is important to know before one can understand why people remember and recall what seem to be small events.

What is dignity? It is a sense of being valued, a feeling of being respected, a sensation of esteem, of self-worth. How and from where does one get it? In everyday life.

My dignity, for example, is propped up by the many times people address me

as “Prof” in any given day—either over email or in person. I feel respected and valued because my job title and salary signal that my efforts matter and I deserve to be rewarded for them. No one threatens to deduct my pay because I miss a day of work. Not once have I been shouted at while in the workplace. As I move through the day, from my home to my office to the classroom to a meeting room to a supermarket or a petrol station, I am visible: people make eye contact with me, they smile, they say hello, they thank me, they bid me farewell. As I stand at a cashier, the worker greets me hello and after I pay she thanks me; my response to her is up to me but it is part of her job to treat me like I matter.

Dignity is like clean air. You do not notice its absence unless it is in short supply. You do not realize how much you need it, how important it is to you, until you don’t have it. Professors, bankers, lawyers, doctors, policy makers, ministers, CEOs— there are differences amongst this list, but a key thing we have in common is that our dignity needs are amply and consistently met, so much so that it requires explicit effort to be conscious of dignity as a need that every human being has. When one lives life as a low-income person, every single day is made up of micro instances of rudeness and disrespect. Every day is a struggle with (in)dignity.

What is wrong with asking someone for ten documents to prove that they are ‘truly needy’? Why shouldn’t we automatically tell a person seeking aid to find employment and leave their kids at childcare? What is the problem with framing ‘help’ as being for a very small minority?

Why is it the people I spoke with can recall what seem to have been minor slights? Why do small encounters come to mean so much?

The two sets of questions are intertwined. It has to do with dignity. In a social context where their dignity needs are not met, interactions with state agencies often deepen this sense of indignity rather than alleviate it.

One of the questions I regularly hear, particularly when I speak to audiences that include people working in government agencies, is this: why don’t they seek help? There is a long list of social service agencies. There is a long list of people in

the helping professions. There is a long list of programs, initiatives and schemes. How can one say the low-income have no avenues for assistance?

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This is not an essay about courtesy and how people should treat low-income persons with more respect, though that is obviously necessary.

Social service sector staff are some of the nicest people I have met. This is important to first state explicitly and unequivocally. Over the past few years, I have spoken to numerous people who work within the social service sector, at a variety of organizations. Some are social workers, some counsellors, others administrative staff. I have been immensely impressed by their generosity, kindness, and sincerity. Many who work at social service agencies are people who chose these jobs because they believe in giving back and helping others in worse positions than themselves. We probably already have, within this sector, some of the people most suited to being in it. Although I heard numerous stories about negative interactions which have clearly made an impression on my respondents, my analysis would be incomplete if I just accepted at face value that the problem is rude or insensitive staff. Given what I know about social service workers, this would be tremendously one-sided and unfair. Instead, stepping back and looking at the big-picture is important.

When people with low income fixate on the specific individuals they interact with, this is because individual experiences always stand out in our minds. They see not organizations as a whole but people; they interact not with an abstract 'the system' but with a living, breathing person on the other side of the counter. But from where I am standing as a researcher, hearing many stories and different perspectives, seeing specific issues come up repeatedly, what is clear is this: there is something going on at a systemic level. This is not a story of bad people.

The question to ask is thus: what is it in our *systems* of social support that are dignity-harming? To answer this, we must look closely at institutional structures

and their ideological underpinnings.

Poverty as exception

The principles of 'self-reliance' and 'family as first line of support' make explicit the fact that there are no universal entitlements for Singaporeans. Securing public housing, healthcare, retirement is mainly about one's capacity to do wage work, accumulate sufficient money, as well as one's capacity to form families by way of marriage.[1] For those unable to work and/or maintain such definitions of families, there are 'Many Helping Hands.' This refers to partnerships between families and 'the community.'

Within this framework, 'the poor' are marked as a tiny minority, as exceptions. This marking of poverty as exception occurs both symbolically/discursively and materially.

Symbolically and discursively, Singaporeans are regularly referred to as largely middle-class and comfortable, and poverty described as highly exceptional.[2] While recognizing intensifying struggles to meet needs for housing, healthcare, et cetera, state officials insist that average Singaporeans can meet these needs *if they work*.

This framing of most Singaporeans as self-reliant (through having wage work) and middle-class is accompanied by concrete policies that turn this into fact. Although there is no official poverty line,[3] social policies aimed at the poor designate their target group as those households earning below S$1,900 per month or S$650 per capita. Significant assistance is aimed at this lowest-earning 10 per cent of resident (citizen/permanent resident) households in Singapore. There is particular focus on people who, due to old age and/or chronic illness, are unable to work *and* who have no family members to rely on.

The creation of criteria and means tests—which include income, employability, and familial conditions—mark out a very small number of households as 'needy.' This means that many among the lowest 30 per cent, for

example, are *not* framed as needing public support. Because various government subsidies are directed at the *very* low-income, and in a national social context where wealth and growth are constantly lauded, there is social stigma attached to applying for and receiving public support. Without establishing a poverty line, but through means tests that employ the use of a very low bar, the state marks a small and exceptional minority as poor and needy.

The creation of specialist institutions targeted at 'the poor' give further material shape to poverty and the low-income as marginal and exceptional. The 'Many Helping Hands' of 'community' is effectively made up of a number of state-initiated if not state-run organizations: the Ministry of Social and Family Development (MSF); the National Council of Social Service (NCSS); the People's Association (PA); five Central Development Councils (CDC); more than twenty Social Service Offices (SSO); almost fifty Family Service Centres (FSC); and numerous other Voluntary Welfare Organizations (VWO) and ethnically-based Self-Help Groups (SHG).

Each of these performs specific roles in regulation (setting policy both for recipients of public aid and service-providing agencies), funding (budgeting and distribution), and type of service (e.g. counseling, disbursing financial aid, running programs). In particular, the MSF, NCSS, and PA—as policy-makers, regulators, and funders—have great influence in shaping the everyday work and goals of the service-providers: CDCs, SSOs, FSCs, VWOs, and SHGs.

A resultant feature of this cacophony of acronymed institutions worth highlighting is a certain degree of division of labor. Each of the institutions has specific roles carved out for them, to which they are held accountable through funding rules and 'Key Performance Indicators' (KPIs). Despite some overlap and duplication of services, each is ultimately responsible for a limited range of schemes and programs. This in turn generates a problem-solving orientation in which the 'problem' is conceived narrowly—and sometimes cut up into separate chunks—and in view of the short-term.[4]

Rather than systematically examining and re-examining how poverty comes

about, or providing the conditions and platforms for such re-examination, these institutions become rather focused on trouble-shooting for their own catalog of concerns. This implies efforts at generating solutions without necessarily reframing how problems have been defined. Their mandate is to target those who fall into specific categories; their everyday responsibilities lie in resolving the individual problems of client cases. And insofar as their mandate is to use what funds they have to 'help,' they do not have the authority nor the resources to address the issue of poverty as a larger systemic issue and are limited to addressing the problems of a small group. Rather than acknowledging and tackling the problem, for example, of endemic low wages made possible by the exploitation of foreign workers or the decreasing potential for social mobility because of inequalities in the education system, the existence of these specialized institutions separates and insulates the problem of 'the poor' from the broader issues of inequality in access and delivery of essential public goods.

Significantly, the problems of the middle- and high-income are conceptualized and dealt with separately, through institutional and policy instruments quite apart from those aimed at the very low-income. The state's orientation toward pronatalism epitomizes this: while well-educated, higher-income women are encouraged—via tax reliefs, foreign domestic worker policies, and paid maternity leave—to have more babies, the low-income are offered financial incentives to keep family size small via a separate channel known as the HOPE scheme.[5]

Whether intended or not, the existence of specialized institutions and personnel to deal with a small group of people leads to the separation of poverty from the issue of *public* goods and citizenship rights.

Other institutions of the state which arguably have a stake in addressing poverty and its reproduction become inoculated from directly dealing with how *their* policies may compound and reproduce poverty. Increasingly, the institutions that specialize in social services monopolize the landscape for discussions of poverty. Although oriented to 'help'—or perhaps precisely because of this—the logic of their interventions deepens *poverty as exception*.

Poverty as tolerable

In fieldnote after fieldnote, my reflections after interviewing social workers begin with this observation: she/he was extraordinarily nice, kind, generous. After months of talking to social workers and reacting like this, I was struck by two things: first, the profound extent to which the Singapore system—with its anti-welfare stance—depends on the good hearts of social service providers trying their best to help. Second and importantly, *in spite of* social workers' extraordinary generosity and kindness, their clients experience endemic struggles and rather intense suffering. These observations sensitized me to the ways in which the organization of social welfare institutions and design of programs were such that aid is miserly, conditional, and highly limited and limiting for both clients and social workers.

Within the anti-welfare regime of Singapore, poverty is tolerated. This tolerance is *not* an emotive tendency on the part of social workers. It is an institutionalized, bureaucratic tolerance. Ultimately, it constrains the transformational potential of social workers.

How does this work?

Numerous policies and regulations shape the who, how, and what: who can receive help and who can provide it; how both service providers and recipients must go about the process; and what people can and cannot have access to. Because government spending is relatively low, there is heavy dependence on the kindness and generosity of both staff and unpaid volunteers within this sector. Despite their good intentions and hard work, social service providers have access to a limited range of resources, programs, and schemes to offer their clients. Indeed, the regulations and criteria they must abide by ensure that clients have limited, conditional, and finite aid. These are insufficient to resolve their problems in sustained ways.

The presumptions about low-income human beings embedded in the design of

programs and aid are as such: people will take advantage when given the opportunity to; there will be free riders; and excessive aid will disincentivize and discourage hard work and 'self-reliance.'

For example, one scheme that social workers working in Family Service Centres have access to is the Straits Times School Pocket Money Fund, commonly referred to as the SPMF. The funds are raised by the main newspaper in Singapore —*The Straits Times*—but administered by social workers through Family Service Centres, Special/Vocational Schools, and Children's Homes. The SPMF is provided to children who are attending school, and who come from households where the per capita monthly household income is below S$450. It provides 'pocket money' of S$60, S$95, or S$120 per month for primary, secondary, and post-secondary students respectively. Assuming 20 school days per month, that is S$3, $4.75, or S$6 daily. To get on the scheme, social workers must conduct a thorough review of applicants. This includes ascertaining that children attend school regularly. The review involves social workers conducting home visits to evaluate applicants' suitability. They also review the cases every three to six months. Most clients can only be on this scheme for two years, though 'chronic cases' may be eligible for up to four years. Social workers tell me they often advise clients to get on and off the SPMF intermittently, so as to stretch it over as long a period in a child's school life as possible.

The SPMF is an important form of aid for the very lowincome, and perhaps the most regular source of funds that FSC social workers can provide for their clients. Strikingly, it shares with other financial aid schemes these qualities: in absolute amounts, it provides very limited help; it entails quite a high level of scrutiny—opening up oneself and one's family to home visits from social workers and regular access to one's work record, family history, et cetera; this surveillance and scrutiny is repeated at regular and short intervals; to stay on the scheme requires discipline and specific behaviors.

How is this an instance of poverty as institutionally/bureaucratically tolerable? That this modest form of aid is important to social workers' clients tell us that these

households are in very poor financial shape. Yet, this aid, being one of the few that these households have relatively easy access to, is also conditional and finite. To qualify for a small sum of money, people have to subject themselves to sustained scrutiny and discipline. Instead of framing this degree of deprivation as deeply problematic in such a wealthy society, the focus is on the people who have such *needs* and on their *performing deservedness* for this tiny amount of aid. In this case, the institutions set up to 'help' have embedded within their institutional logic a high tolerance for the suffering and struggle of people *known to the system* to be struggling at this level. In other words, these are not the proverbial 'fallen through the cracks' people—these are people that the system *knows* are in such bad condition that they are willing to answer all kinds of personal questions about their families so that their kids can eat at recess. This is tolerance both for absolute hardship—the inability to pay for children's basic needs—and for the hardship involved in seeking help, the indignity of opening up one's life for scrutiny in exchange for so little money. This example illustrates a larger dynamic in Singapore's system of carefully calibrated conditional aid: one has to be desperate before one has access to anything at all, and even then, that suffering is repeatedly tolerated when aid is withheld, suspended, and finally taken away.

A second example illustrates further the extent to which these institutions institutionalize the tolerance of suffering: here, people who do not match the criteria are basically ignored and left outside the system. One group that is on the rise and in this category of absolute exclusion is 'foreign wives.' These are women who have married low-income citizen men and who are not citizens or permanent residents.[6] The immigration policies in Singapore are such that people with low educational credentials are unlikely to be successful in their applications for permanent residence or citizenship. Social workers are seeing a rise in the number of these foreign wives in the neighborhoods they work in. There is little to nothing they can do for them. To offer them any aid, social workers have to find ways to make connections to Singaporeans; either their spouses or in some cases their citizen children can be the applicants for aid. In cases where they are estranged from

spouses or without (citizen) children, however, there is very little social workers can do. Some of them find ways to bring them food rations or donations in kind, but that is often the best they can do. These are women they feel bad for, and do try to help, but who ultimately cannot enter into their systems.

The institutionalization of poverty as tolerable happens through the goals and regulations set for social workers and social service provider organizations. The topic of 'KPIs' (Key Performance Indicators) came up a lot in my conversations with social service agency workers. Organization managers find themselves heavily tethered to these and are given pressure from the funding government ministry and sometimes other types of funders. Individual staff, in turn, find that they have to produce and process a certain number of cases within specified time periods. Social workers are compelled to think about how many cases they have moved through and importantly, moved *out* of the system. By social workers' accounts, closing a case may mean that a family is no longer in deep crisis; perhaps there is now some paid work. However, the problems faced by low-income families are often complex, multiple, and interconnected—bad debts, difficult familial relations, lack of credentials to secure stable employment, difficult behavior among children and youth, drug abuse, domestic violence, et cetera.[7] Often cases are closed when some of the more obvious problems are temporarily resolved— for example, from no wages to low wages—without necessary resolution of sustained and chronic challenges. The number of cases that are *closed* are read as indicators of success, registered as the fulfilling of 'performance'/KPIs—directly deepening the institutions' tolerance for the continual struggles in the lives of the low-income.

To appreciate how social service institutions reproduce poverty as tolerable, we also have to revisit the division of labor within these institutions. Here, the dispensing of the bigger amounts of aid is done through the CDCs and, since 2013, the SSOs, while case work and counseling is generally provided by the FSCs and sometimes other VWOs. Although there are often case management meetings across agencies, one of the effects of this division of labor is that there is a certain

depersonalization that happens where financial aid is concerned. The case workers who work closely with families, who come to appreciate their complex and deep struggles, who want to be their champions, are generally not the ones who ultimately dispense financial aid from the ComCare Fund.[8] This detachment and division of labor, has the effect of rendering tolerable —at the personal, individual level of the staff dispensing aid—endemic and repeated struggle and suffering.

To understand why the various organizations who work directly with clients comply to regulations and have limited room to reframe problems and expand their coverage of who is 'needy,' we must make explicit one important thing about this sector: money is power. As the primary funder in the sector, the MSF sets out the responsibilities and staff composition of the service-providing organizations, and compels them to compete with one another for funding through their implementation of programs. As non-profit-generating entities, each VWO's very existence is dependent on compliance to MSF and its underlying policy assumptions and priorities. At the level of individual agencies' everyday work, then, suffering has to be tolerable because the alternative—that they would not exist to help anyone at all—is worse.

In sum, within social service institutions, the tolerance for endemic struggle and suffering is built into everyday practices and institutionalized. It has little to do with the social service providers' sensibilities and emotional inclinations; in fact, if they did, we would see, given what I have witnessed about social workers' generosity and kindness, a great deal more forthcoming aid and compassion for the low-income. Instead, the amounts of aid, the criteria built into qualifying for aid, and the regulations for assessment and review of clients, reflect a high degree of endemic tolerance for struggle and suffering. By social workers' own accounts, the chronic and unfulfilled needs of many poor households are rarely resolved in a sustainable way.[9]

Poverty as an individual 'mindset' problem

In the problem-solving mandate of specialized institutions and personnel, poverty is framed primarily in individual terms, very much in accordance with the ethic of individualism and differentiated deservedness of a neoliberal capitalist state.[10] The procedures and processes embedded within the institutions, which structure the everyday work of social service providers, often consider the problems faced by individuals as the outcome of individual 'mindsets' and 'behaviors.' For social workers too, the problem of poverty is partly conceptualized as one that stems from attitudinal-behavioral orientations. Faced with actual, material circumstances that are unlikely to radically change, social workers are induced—through the need to establish targets for their everyday work—to search for changes in 'mindset' in their clients. Working in an environment of scarcity—where aid is limited, finite, and highly contingent on narrow criteria— social service providing organizations and workers operate fundamentally within a world where resources are understood *and* experienced as limited. In this context, it makes sense that they look out for signs of deservedness as manifested in performances of 'mindsets' so as to decide how to distribute scarce resources. Moreover, the processes that guide their work formalize this search for deservedness in their candidates. These are the bases to the belief that poverty should be resolved by people changing *their* sensibilities, their ways of thinking about themselves and how *they* relate to the world.[11]

To illustrate, let me describe what happens when someone enters a Family Service Centre for the first time. They first go through what was known as 'I & R'—Information and Referral— and now called 'Intake.' Staff who greet them will find out basic information about them that includes their familial and household circumstances—theirs and their family members' employment situation and income, and whether they are receiving or have received aid. Workers will also find out what people are at the FSC for, and how best to refer them. If it turns out they have issues or problems that require deep intervention that cannot be referred out, there is at this or a second meeting a charting of a 'genogram' and an 'ecogram.' The genogram and ecogram map out their larger familial network as well as ties to other people within the community. The social worker's role is to try to draw out a

picture of an individual's relationship to others in order to see what resources they might be able to tap on, and also to figure out what schemes and programs they might qualify for. The genogram and ecogram also serve the purpose, however, of figuring out the extent to which help-seekers have exhausted all other options. It is the very initial gauge for figuring out if help-seekers have the 'right mindset' of 'independence.'

This evaluation is deepened when social workers conduct home visits. Since self-reliance and independence are fundamental principles set out by their institutions, social workers are duty-bound to look for signs of these. First of all, the context of limited aid for finite time periods means that the moment someone seeks and receives help, the social worker's task is essentially to work toward getting them off aid. Rather than aid as long-term solution, the aid is a patch, a quick fix, and meant and understood to be enough only to tide over short-term crises. Understandably, then, social workers are immediately looking for signs of change, of movement toward 'self-reliance.'

One social worker framed their goals (and barriers) this way:

> as social workers, I guess, we always aim to *help people to help themselves*, you know...eventually. So, sometimes it gets a bit discouraging when, you know, the clients are not really putting in effort on their part (emphasis mine).

Another puts into sharp relief why social workers have to emphasize self-reliance through work right from the outset:

> I'm sorry to say this but, if you have no hands and no legs, only then will the government come but even then they give you just minimal to survive. That's all. But if you've got hands and legs, you'd better do some work. And nowadays, even if you've got no hands or legs you can be on call, you can do some work. You have to.

In the context of scarcity of aid, social workers are also compelled to identify the 'truly needy.' This is signaled in a variety of ways. For example, in many conversations with social workers, the issue of television ownership came up. They told me that they have been surprised by how, no matter how deprived people seem —no money for food, no money for rental and other bills—too many seem to have flat-screen televisions in their flats. They report that some buy these televisions using installment plans and that they may default on their payments. The subtext here is this: if you can afford a flat-screen television, you are either not as needy as you say you are or more importantly, you do not have the right attitude toward money. This is *not* to say that social workers make big distinctions among clients that lead to highly different outcomes. Yet, given that at various points in the process, clients depend on social workers' willingness to reach out across agencies, to pay extra visits to coach families on what to do to get help, the workers' experiences of families as being more or less motivated, having better or worse attitudes, inevitably shapes the degree to which they advocate for a given individual or family. The right display of 'mindset' can mean a little extra nudge so that social workers champion a case just a tad more.

From the accounts given by social workers, people's problems are deep and complex, and it is no surprise that situations rarely change soon after people begin receiving aid. Yet, social workers are required to review and reevaluate cases over short time periods. What happens, then? What are they to look for? The expectation of change that is embedded into institutional reviews can only be fulfilled by looking for slight adjustments. Absent of real change, social workers are compelled to look at clients for their subjective orientations. In this context, social workers look to signs that people have the 'right attitude' and are open to change. One major thing they look for is the willingness to find paid work.

Describing a mother who does not want to work though that would allow her to qualify for childcare center subsidies, one social worker told me:

As in they're asking for financial assistance and everything. But on their

> part, they're not really putting in, like, effort, you know, to solve their problem.

She expresses her frustration that her client is not displaying the right orientation after receiving aid. What she wants is not necessarily a wholly different outcome, but some sign that "effort" has been put in. This is an entirely understandable frustration that I can relate to: as teachers, professors too talk about wanting students to demonstrate not just knowledge but hard work, effort to understand the material. The point I am making here, however, is that, unlike students who have a number of years to prove themselves and where many will have the capacity to emerge from a course with more knowledge than before, these clients really have little chance of 'succeeding' in the sense of radically improving their financial circumstances at the end of the period of aid. Their "effort," then, becomes the only sign of their change. The short review periods oblige social workers to look for these, even though they also have a deep appreciation for the limitations of aid.

Hence, although social workers are well aware that their clients have deep and complex problems and are very sympathetic to their challenges for finding good employment, the conditions in which social workers operate push them toward focusing on the individual's response to their problems. Rather than emphasizing the structural challenges and limits faced by the poor, they return regularly to the issue of mindsets. This long quote illustrates this well:

> Because I always tell my clients, you can, you know, it, it's very easy to rely on the government or VWOs but you must think, you know, the money they give you ah, is not very substantial. School pocket money how much? One primary school kid, $55 a month. One secondary school kid, $90. You get $100 plus from us, you go out to work, $1,000. How many more times? You provide for your family, you save, you know. And, and you can buy for your family, I mean, $150 from us, for two

> years versus you go and work, $800, you get more money you see. So sometimes, you have to really show them that, eh, yah, actually if I go and work, I earn much more, you know? And I can provide for my family, rather than relying on these coupons from VWOs and government. Sometimes they don't really see it that way. I mean sometimes they are just, I don't know, is it because their siblings are doing it, their parents have been doing it, or their relatives have been doing it, so it's like, it becomes a norm, you know, that if I don't have money, I don't think about going out to work first, I think about going to FSC or what, think about going to government. *So it's really changing this mindset of people, and letting them know that if you can be self-reliant, you provide more for yourself and your children will not follow your footsteps you know.* Yah, because we really see the generation is really, your generation after generation just repeats. Yah, children drop out of school and then, you see the cycle. *Yah, I think that's the challenge lah. Changing the mindset of these people* (emphasis mine).

The understanding that help is scarce and finite leads social workers to look for signs that clients are trying to become independent, primarily through work. They are discouraged when people "are not really putting in effort." Insofar as the performance of attitudes, sensibilities and orientations are unlikely to change very much overnight, persistent problems still become identified with individual mindsets, obscuring if not entirely masking the constraints presented by welfare policies.



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Over the past few years, as I have presented my work to different audiences, I have come to see that this belief that low-income persons need to change their attitudes is a pretty deep belief. It is a belief held by the general public, but it is especially pronounced among civil servants and/or policy makers. After hearing me talk about the hardworking people I meet, the desperate people I speak to, there will be those who insist on shifting the conversation to those who are "just unmotivated" to help

themselves. They worry that I am assigning too much blame to the system and not granting "agency" to the low-income. They want me to say more about this group and they want me to suggest the right "nudges" that would push people to behave in certain ways. They want to know: what can we do to help "empower" the low-income so that they can help themselves?

The problem with this mindset—not of those who are powerless but those who are relatively powerful—is that power is not a frame of mind but a material condition. People sitting in positions of authority are powerful not because they *feel* empowered but because they *have* power. Their feelings of empowerment are an outcome of their actual ownership of power, not the cause. One can think—and indeed many of the low-income people I speak with do this—"I can do this. I must try." But if one is in fact lacking in power—lacking in control over time; lacking in leverage in the labor market; lacking in bargaining power with managers, teachers, social workers, landlords, creditors—no amount of merely changing how they think about themselves will change these realities.

The invocation of motivation, of mindsets, of agency—they are powerful distractions from looking at poverty as linked to inequality. They are bait-and-switch moves to avoid acknowledging poverty as that which is reproduced within a system. In being asked these questions, I am, ironically, reminded that there is agency: this system, it is produced by people. Many of these people have the mindset that low-income persons' problems are about not having the right mindsets.

Dignity needs

Trying to access financial aid in Singapore is stigmatizing.[12] The programs are very clearly framed as exceptional and for a minority. This is what we know from the international research on social policies: when programs are exceptional rather than universal, and especially when they are targeted at the lowest-income, there is a

stigma attached to accessing them.[13] Stigma is the opposite of dignity. It makes a person feel ashamed, of lower worth. There is stigma in accessing ComCare in a way there is no stigma accessing, say, the Baby Bonus. I saw people who are already at the end of their rope insisting that they are "still ok," telling me that they would rather exhaust other avenues than go to the Social Service Office.

Process matters.

This sums up what people say when they tell me why they are reluctant to seek help after they have had prior experiences: they will ask me A to Z, all kinds of personal questions. They tell me to bring ten different documents, and then if one thing is wrong, I have to go again. I have no time to do this because I have to work, I have to pick up my kid, I have to cook, I need to do housework. My kids need me at home and I don't want them to go astray like I did, but last time I went, the officer there just told me to get a job. And finally, importantly, after I have done everything right and I qualify and everything, they give me a tiny bit of help, for which I am grateful, but which only helps me get out of this crisis but doesn't prevent the next one. And then in another three months, six months, I need to go through the process all over again. This time, I need to answer questions about why I have this $50 in my bank account, what I did to improve my pay, why don't my children want to go to Student Care. On and on the questions go.

The overall experience with the process is two-fold: one, you don't trust me, you think I'm trying to cheat you. Two, you are not going to understand the big picture of my life and you are telling me what to do even though you don't understand and you are never going to truly see me. The process undermines one's esteem and sense of respect and value. The context I sketched out earlier is important. When a person whose role is supposed to help you, instead of trying to see you as a whole person with complex problems, goes down a checklist, launches questions at you like they're interrogating you, it further intensifies the lack of dignity that is already a part of daily life.

What is dignity if it is conditional?

One morning, as I was drafting this essay, I watched a series of short films commissioned by the Lien Foundation. It is a project called Genki Kaki and features a visit by two older Singaporean women to Japan to see some instances of what has been done in Japan as it transitions into an older population. The pair visited "elderly-friendly malls, restaurants, shopping streets, gyms and places that provide residential and day-care in and around Tokyo."[14]

The films moved me deeply. They featured various organizations designing spaces and objects to suit the changing needs of ageing bodies. In them, young people talked to older people in regular, non-condescending tones, and they spoke sincerely of valuing older persons' wisdom and knowledge. The respect accorded to older persons, the feeling one got of their continued belonging in society as they aged, the expressions and body language of security in one's self-worth among older people—these were images that felt alien to me. I thought to myself: Oh. *This* is what dignity really looks like.

It occurred to me then that the examples I gave of myself feeling esteem, respect, self-worth—they are fleeting. The respect I am accorded are conditional on my participation in society as an economically productive and relatively wealthy person. It has little to do with my inherent right to respect as a human being and member of this society. That it is conditional is palpable because I see that those who do not meet the conditions I currently have do not get it. It is also palpable when I look at people with more power and/or wealth than me and I see how they are treated with what *looks like* more respect. If the performance of respect can vary so much by rank, can it be esteem for the person rather than their position?

Respect that is conditional on narrow practices can easily be withheld. I think it is different, qualitatively, from the respect that is given and received between people who believe in the inherent worth and integrity of other human beings.

This is a book about inequality and poverty. It is not a book about poverty. I hope

we can manage as a society to bring the poorest of our fellow members out of poverty and into a situation where they can meet their basic needs, have a decent life. And there are things that can be done to aid-dispensing systems so that they are not so stigmatized. There are things we can and must do to address the problems of those living with low income. When I reflect on the issue of dignity, however, I am reminded that this really is not just 'their' problem. The precarity of dignity needs at first glance looks like something that affects only those with low income, but on second scrutiny appears to be a condition everyone is in. As long as our well-being and worth as persons are deeply linked to economic productivity, income, a specific way of doing family, then every person's dignity is essentially at risk. In this ethos, no one has inherent worth as persons.

What I saw in the films is probably an incomplete picture of what life feels like in Japan. Still, it offers a glimpse of possibility, a sense of what an ideal might look like. It allows for an imagination of respect and worth and esteem that persists in the face of diverse and/or changing life circumstances. This dignity doesn't have an expiration date attached to economic productivity. It affirms the worth of personhood. It feels different from what we have. It looks amazing.

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1 See “Differentiated Deservedness” in this book.

2 See Chua and Tan (1999); Lim and Lee (2012).

3 Indeed, in 2013, when researchers from the Lien Centre for Social Innovation suggested the establishment of a poverty line, they were met with swift and public disagreement from various state officials. See Basu (2013); Chan (2013).

4 Irene Ng (2013) too has pointed out that there is division of labor among social service providers. She argues that this leads to families “falling through the cracks.”

5 The HOPE Scheme (Home Ownership Plus Education) provides housing grants and various subsidies to low-income and less-educated married couples (or divorced/widowed women with child custody), on condition that they limit their fertility to two children. The maximum benefits of the scheme are reaped when applicants undergo irreversible sterilization.

6 For an analysis of such transnational marriages, see Jongwilaiwan and Thompson (2013).

7 See also Ng (2013).

8 For information on ComCare, see Ministry of Social and Family Development (2017).

9 This institutionalized tolerance for suffering may also explain the high turnover rate that my social worker respondents told me about. The ‘burn out’ that people experience seems to come about partly from individual workers’ sense that they are working so hard and wanting so much to help, but seeing so much continual suffering among their clients. What the system can tolerate, individual social workers often cannot. See, also, Ng et. al. (2008).

10 See “Differentiated Deservedness” in this book.

11 This is not unique to the Singapore case. As Mullainathan and Shafir (2013) point out in Scarcity: Why Having Too Little Means So Much, there is widespread belief in the U.S. that the poor’s problems have much to do with how they think and behave, and their inability to make good decisions.

12 The previous section describes processes at FSCs, which are staffed by social workers. As mentioned earlier, monetary aid through FSCs is limited. For financial assistance, people are to turn to SSOs. It is here that dignity becomes an especially salient issue. One must note, however, that people’s experiences are never ‘just’ about FSCs, or ‘just’ about SSOs, since the division of labor may be clear from the perspective of social service sector employees, but people seeking assistance often see them as a bloc, and indeed often think of all of these as ‘the government.’

13 See Gugushvili and Hirsch (2014).

Airing Dirty Laundry

IN MY CAREER AS A SOCIOLOGIST thus far, I have chosen research projects that involve the state and state policies. In the process, based on my empirical findings, I have been compelled to be critical of the state and state policies. Over the years, I have received support as well as witnessed resistance to what I have to say, as any scholar should expect. This is most palpably felt at conferences and workshops located within Singapore, as people come to the microphone to ask questions or make comments. Because there are certain patterns in who tends to be supportive and who tends to be critical, I see too that there are some concrete anchors for any given person's views. Specifically, where and how people make their careers, and the level of independence these careers are from the state, are somewhat associated with their inclinations and sensibilities. These directly shape their interpretations of what I say as well as how they see my work as either bolstering or undermining their sense of the world. This should not be a surprise—our concrete material interests and the institutions in which we spend our everyday lives shape our worldviews, our judgment and, more often than we probably realize, our loyalties.

For years, I stayed at this interpretation of what is going on, and it mostly served me well. I learnt not to take criticism too personally. I figured out the importance of adjusting my tone in speaking to different audiences. I understood, and to an extent respect, that some people do not want to hear what I have to say in the way I am inclined to say it. In many ways, this has done me a lot of good—I learnt to see other perspectives even if I did not agree with them, and I learnt to communicate better, in what I hope are ways that allow for real exchanges and not just monologues.

My work on poverty and inequality has brought a new layer to these experiences. Sometimes we do not fully recognize what we are doing until we get reactions we have not seen before.

Hitting a nerve

In an earlier essay, I talk about national narratives and internal narratives. I mentioned two specific incidents at two workshops: after I described how one of my respondents experienced being homeless and her children having to take cold showers in a public bathroom every morning at 4am, one man quipped that he also took cold showers and that this is fine because Singapore is very hot; after I talked about the ubiquity of bed bugs, another person downplayed this by saying that he grew up in a time when there were a lot of bed bugs. In the essay, I talk about how these quips render the speakers dignified rather than ashamed because their internal narratives are of progress, about overcoming hardship and ultimate triumph. Importantly, their internal narratives map nicely onto our national narratives of economic development, growth, wealth, prosperity. The speakers do not want to hear stories of people whose life stories disrupt the *national* narrative. A disruption of the national narrative is a disruption of their internal, personal narratives. Stories about people living in 2017-Singapore inhabiting what sounds more like their 1965-Singapore are stories that are troubling—they challenge the coherence of their stories, they disturb the moral goodness of their trajectories, they raise questions about their deservedness.

For people who have unambiguously 'made it,' as the two men had, the comments about my work are made lightheartedly. I use the word 'quip' because that was how they were launched— delivered quickly, a little under the breath, almost as an aside, accompanied by big smiles and small chuckles, aimed at rousing laughter in the room. They were meant to be heard as magnanimous rather than petty, light rather than profound. I have no doubt that part of the effect of their words, in those rooms where they were spoken, was to reduce the weight of my findings and trivialize the hardships of my respondents.

Where, in their defense of the national narrative, the tone of these men was triumphant but light, I soon encountered other kinds of resistance tinged with

anger and indignity. This makes me see more clearly the depth, complexities, and contradictions embedded in Singaporean nationalism. It also raises new questions about what I, and others like me, are doing when we apply critical lenses to the national narrative, and what costs we bear in the process.

"Why are you telling people this about Singapore?"

In 2017, I presented my work at a conference in Singapore. By this time, I had presented various findings about my research on low-income Singaporeans multiple times. Many of these presentations were to nonacademic audiences consisting mainly of Singaporeans. I had encountered both encouraging support as well as expressions of skepticism. In general, because of the self-selection process in the attendance of these talks and perhaps because Singaporeans are not generally confrontational, it was primarily the former. This particular workshop and my presentation turned out to be disturbing for one very unhappy audience member partly because the conference participants were from many other places besides Singapore.

I opened my presentation by saying that I will talk about a group of people who are often out of sight when people discuss the Singapore case. In the short time I had, I mentioned a few details about their hardships and challenges, and about the ways in which social policies have not seriously dealt with their needs. I ended by calling attention to the importance of dignity and made the claim that what we have at stake is not just about a small group of Singaporeans but about our shared notions of social worth and belonging. At the question-and-answer segment, I saw an older person put up her hand. By the time we got through an initial round of questions, she did not have time to ask hers.

As soon as the session ended, she came up to me and very indignantly told me that "you researchers shouldn't believe those people." Before I could speak, she went on to tell me that I was seeing only what "those people" wanted me to see. She

sighed impatiently and told me they are in fact very well taken care of by the government, and they can go and seek help from the CDCs and MPs.[1] She told me I should just write to tell the Prime Minister about their problems, and that the government will help them. I was initially willing to engage her, and wanted to find out why she was so convinced that I was wrong and she was right. But when I spoke, she started to get more riled up and raised her voice more and interrupted me multiple times. Then she started gesturing, waving her index finger about, and saying repeatedly, "Aiyah, you academics, you really shouldn't believe those people. Those people are not telling you the real thing. I know those people." Her repeated reference to "those people" triggered something in me, and I started to feel angry. I asked her why she kept referring to the low-income as "those people" and why she would speak so disrespectfully of them. At this point, the organizers noticed this heated interaction and came over to separate us and encourage us to take lunch.

I did not think too much about the incident, but throughout the rest of the day and the next, I made sure there was space between her and me. At the final half-hour of the workshop, as the organizers opened up a conversation about the proceedings of the two days, I was surprised to see her go up to the microphone. She remained deeply unhappy about what I, and another presenter on Singapore, had said. In her second, this time public, rant—for this is what I think is a fair characterization of what it was—she rearticulated that we/I had got it wrong. She said that migrants (the topic of the other presenter's paper) are actually very rich. She then turned to my paper. She said that it is herself, and other 'Pioneer Generation' folks like her, who are really precarious. "Those people" in rental flats are "actually very well taken care of." She then suggested that I accompany them to seek help, and even offered to come with me.

Two things struck me about her second outburst: first, her position, unlike the two people I had spoken about earlier, probably *is* significantly different. There was something in her tone that suggests she is angry that academics like myself are not talking about *her* precarity and instead focusing on "those people"—the migrants, and rental-flat dwellers who, on paper at least, already qualify for much of the social

assistance that is available. On this, I must agree that there are other Singaporeans who are not the focus of my research who also deserve attention.

But a second dimension of her reaction is perplexing: if she is feeling precarious and upset about her situation, why was *I* the focus of her ire? More strikingly, why does the government come out smelling like roses? How is her precarity my responsibility but not the state's? And here, how she launched her comments are telling. The reason she wanted to say all this in public at the microphone, even though she had spoken to me the day before is because she wanted the *non-Singaporean* audience to hear. She was upset not just because she thought I was wrong, but because to her, I was "presenting the wrong things" to "people who don't know about Singapore." She was, in other words, trying to set the record straight on *behalf of Singapore*.

Majulah Singapura

The same night, I had difficulty sleeping and spent more time than I should have scrolling through my newsfeed on Facebook. Several people and news media pages had posted segments of Prime Minister Lee Hsien Loong's interview on the BBC program HARDTalk. One post stood out to me for its extracted quote: "I would not presume to tell you how your press council should operate. Why should you presume to tell me how my country should run?" This was part of the answer the Prime Minister gave when the host Stephen Sackur asked him how he would respond if the UK pressed Singapore on freedom of expression and freedom of the press. I immediately thought, well, that's going to be a crowd pleaser. And indeed, it was. On Prime Minister Lee's Facebook page, accolades, which I reproduce here verbatim, poured in:

> Great response sir! Hats off to you and yes, Spore maybe small but we're strong enough to stand side by side with the big boys!

PM, you answered the questions with so much grace and dignity and calm. … Your answers showed an educated society that is always forward looking, an Asian society that holds on to her values and yet, is articulate in thoughts.

Well done PM, MM Lee and Mrs Lee are (I still prefer to use present tense) definately proud of you, as we Singaporeans are. Majulah Singapura

Sir, you answered with style and power and I'm sure the interviewer can felt your punches. I'm so proud that my PM handled it so well and I believe many others got to agree with me. Majullah Singapura!!!

PM Lee Hsien Loong: you represented Singapore honorably and your reply was what I would have enunciated. The progressive achievements Singapore has made speak volumes of the correct path Singapore has adopted. We Asians know best that we gotta be well fed and must sustain a deep pocket so that when we speak people in other parts of the world shall listen.

What I most proud of you is your CONFIDENCE. You show the world we know what we are doing and we know what we want. And most of all, we know who we are. We don't live in self-delusion. We don't feel inferior. We will just focus in our growth as a nation and as one people. Once again, thank you Sir.

Well said. Our PM is a true gentleman and diplomat as he has shown time and time again. A lot of countries could learn a great deal from Singapore including my own. Huge respect for this man and for Singapore

The 'west' like to use the term 'democracy' to bog us down so that they

> can plant puppets for their own political or economic agenda. Singapore is a sovereign nation, lead by a trustworthy leader which from time to time has prove the world, how to run a nation with good balance between leadership and democracy.... We are on the right path, do not fix what is not broken... You have replied well, Sir PM
>
> Proud of you as our PM! Such a fair and objective response to his curt question and attitude.
>
> you tell 'em, mr lee!

The framing of the question by Sackur and the full response by Lee were actually quite interesting. Sackur's question was framed as almost a threat—that addressing the lacks in freedoms would be a precondition to continual trade. To this, in the world where we live, one can only laugh, and this the Prime Minister did. He went on to essentially mock the question for its naiveté— pointing out that countries which purportedly value certain freedoms, such as the US, have and will continue to trade with countries, such as the oil-rich ones, which continually violate human rights, because "you have to do business." He then made some more conciliatory comments about diversity in the world and the need to understand that no values are universal. This proved immensely popular, and several commentators, both on his page and elsewhere online, would later proudly repeat his line: "The world is a diverse place. Nobody has a monopoly on virtue or wisdom."

Yet, although there is plenty to unpack in the 30-minute interview, as well as lots to debate, the positive, almost gleeful responses from certain segments of the population fixated not on the substance of what he said but on the *tone* of what they felt he accomplished on that global media stage that is the BBC: Lee Hsien Loong did Singapore proud by showing "them" that a little country can punch big.

Airing dirty laundry

What does it mean to punch big? And what does this have to do with responses to my work?

There is of course something partial about the comments on the Prime Minister's own Facebook page. The people who are in disagreement with his comments are probably not going to post them there. I am by no means suggesting that this is the only response to his interview. What I am pointing to is that the positive comments are framed largely in terms of national pride, *and* that this national pride is tied up in Singapore's purported progress and prosperity in spite of its limited size. As I saw in my earlier work, this is *the* script people go to when they think about Singapore vis-à-vis the world.[2]

Stories about poverty and inequality disrupt this script. Judging by complaints, in recent years, about increases in costs of living, about intensifying senses of insecurity, and about the role of immigrants in many of these trends, Singaporeans are not entirely enamored with state-led economic development nor blind to the chips in the script of progress and prosperity. These, however and apparently, are not for others, for *outsiders*, to see or comment on. These gripes are compartmentalized—saved for different settings and for separate discussions, when there are no outsiders. When the Prime Minister is on BBC, his job is to present the best face forward. Majulah Singapura.

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Stories about poverty and inequality create a lot of discomfort, as I think they should. It is this discomfort that will propel us into action. It is this discomfort that will compel various members of this society to push for change, to push for widening the circle in which people can enjoy the successes of economic wealth.

The resistance to this disruption and discomfort, I had mostly interpreted as people unwilling to give up their own privileges. And I saw my role as continually trying to get people to see that we can disrupt our narrative and build alternative narratives, and that some of us can and should give up some things because what we

will gain in return will be worthwhile. But I now see that there is an additional dimension to this that may be an equally large, if not larger, impediment to disrupting the narrative.

Accepting that there is poverty and inequality is difficult if nationalist pride is a high priority. In this mode, we lose face as a nation if we foreground such problems. At the conference, I evoked such a strong reaction, and one that was targeted at me so personally, essentially because I was airing dirty laundry. I was basically a traitor.

What I have written in this essay will not be news to activists working in Singapore. The vitriol I have seen online, launched at friends and acquaintances who work on various issues to do with human rights, has been as sustained as it has been shocking. The attacks sometimes essentially take this form: you liberal, western-educated elites. That's it. That is the entire argument of the attack. A sentence fragment constituting the whole punch. One cannot comprehend this without juxtaposing it against "you tell em, mr lee!" Despite having English as an official language; using British colonial names as a matter of pride on our most elite institutions; accepting as common sense that our top students must go to Harvard, Stanford, Cambridge, Oxford; and generally embracing pop cultures and lifestyles that are 'western,' or perhaps precisely because of all this, there is a desire—when the outcome places Singapore as superior— to reject 'the west.'

But what is this 'Singapore' that is so terrific, and who are in this 'Singapore'? Who are these 'Singaporeans' invoked who are supposed to always feel pride? Once on this mental path, differences must be flattened. You are either with us, or against us. And if you are with us, you cannot speak of all the variations and inequalities within the 'us.' Once you do, you are against us, your loyalties must lie elsewhere.

Resist nationalist tendencies, we must

We need to get beyond this. This nationalism—willing to ignore problems to protect pride; able to overlook complexities in order to satisfy momentary pleasures of being 'winners'; insisting on seeing society through narrow lenses in order to justify complacency—is as stifling to progress as it is dangerous to social harmony.

Poverty and inequality in Singapore are real. You can cut the data in different ways to present different interpretations of how it has come about and how it will go away. But no matter how you cut it, there are real lives, real people, real hardships. These grind against real rules, real policies, real institutions. Denying its existence and its seriousness, as well as its relationality to wealth, represents a double-violence. Ignoring the accountability and obligations of wealthier and more powerful segments of society is morally problematic. For these reasons, we should not let either our individual narratives or our national narratives and nationalist pride compel us to look away.

2017 is, for anyone who cares about goodness and decency and fairness and justice, a despairing time to live in. We should look outside Singapore. When we do, we should do so not just to satisfy base instincts for affirmation. If it is so that Singapore is small and global and at the mercy of global trends, then there are trends we must pay attention to and take heed. Among the things we must learn when we look at the world is that nationalism is an ugly beast. It is a beast that is tempting for people to feed. The fallout of the feeding is probably not complete, but as we see societies torn apart—by profound cruelty manifesting between persons, by an unraveling of civility and respect for personhood— our response cannot be to celebrate our awesomeness or exceptionalism. For, in the ethos of that act of celebration, in that articulation of simplistic and incomplete visions of our society, lies the same base instinct toward drawing boundaries without consideration for current realities of inequalities and future dreams of justice.

When I began thinking about writing this book of essays, I had in mind a relatively modest set of writings—keeping to the topic, staying on the narrow scope of my empirical research. The reality of thinking and writing about poverty and

inequality, however, is that one is forced to see that many things are related to many other things. And so it is that this book touches on many things that did not appear at the onset to be related—housing, schools, mothers, social workers, individualism, family holidays, soccer boots, nationalism, dignity.

If social life is made up of many things that are interconnected and interrelated, then two things follow: the specialist academic cannot afford to stay in her safe corner, studying and commenting only very narrowly on a small realm of expertise. Second, and more importantly, the generation of ideas, of knowledge, of understanding, cannot be limited to academics or other 'experts,' but must be the right, the work, *and* the responsibility of everyone who lives in and cares about this place. For this to work, one's engagement has to be deep and sustained. It cannot be oriented primarily toward silencing the engagement of others.

This book, I hope, does not read like prescriptions. Although I have a viewpoint and opinions about how things should be done and ought to be, I believe we do and should see and act from many different places. I invite anyone who has read this far to consider how their everyday lives, their work, their families, their choices, their refusals, can be understood from the perspectives I have presented. In the process of doing this work, I have had the privilege of knowing that there is in fact already a community—of scholars, activists, social workers, artists, and thinkers of various backgrounds—who resist cynicism, who refuse the notion that this is it. I invite everyone who cares to step in to be part of the creation of new directions, new narratives, new imaginations, new dreams.

Laundry needs to be aired. Don't shy. Maju, lah.

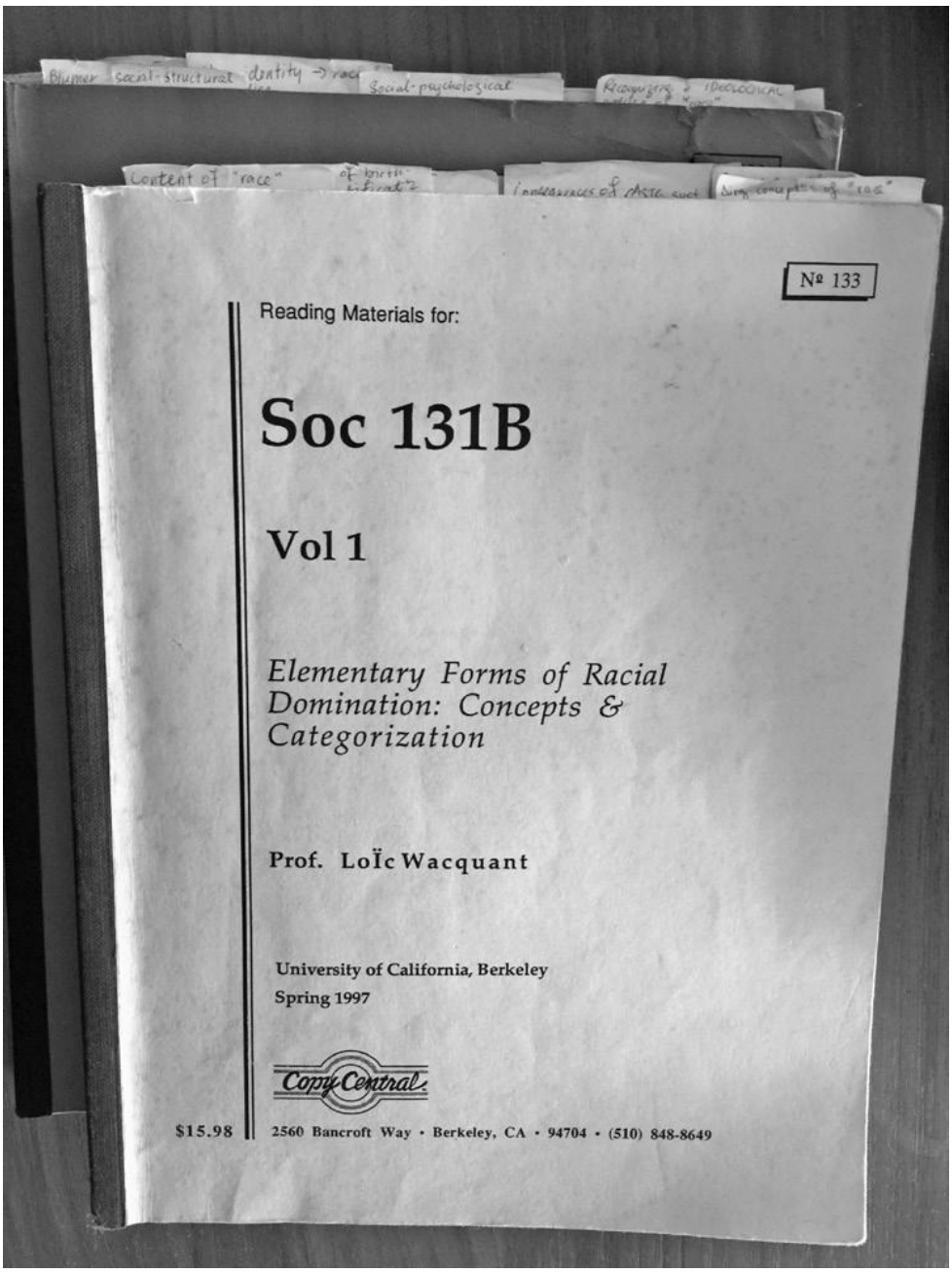
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1 CDC: Community Development Council; MP: Member of Parliament.

2 Teo (2011).

A Memo on 'Race'



Reading materials for Soc 131B. Photo by Teo You Yenn, 2017.

IN 1997, I took a class from Loïc Wacquant titled *Elementary Forms of Racial Domination*. It radically and permanently altered the way I understood 'race.'[1]

In his first lecture, Professor Wacquant set two ground rules: whenever we use

the word 'race,' we are to put it in quotation marks. Second, we are not allowed to use the word 'racism.' These struck students as odd rules for a course about 'race'; the latter instruction, in particular, generated angst among a student body with heightened sensitivities toward the problems of 'racism.'

I still find these starting points compelling.

Quotation marks around 'race' prevent analytical slippage and forgetfulness—the act forces the person uttering or writing the word to remember that 'race' is a social construct. How 'race' is understood and experienced, how it is enacted, and the consequences of its particular enactments, vary over time and place. 'Race' is not a static, universal fact—what principles are used to establish group boundaries, how it comes to be meaningful, and what effects it has on people's lives change with time and vary across places. We think we know what we are talking about when we talk about 'race'; it turns out that, when we compare societies or time periods, people's views of what 'race' a person belongs to can be based on phenotype, can depend on socioeconomic status, and in some societies multiple principles are simultaneously at work such that some groups' offspring are categorized on the basis of one principle (e.g. ancestral geographical origins) while those of other groups' are categorized based on other principles (e.g. cultural practices such as language or religion).[2]

Wacquant pointed out that folk beliefs about 'race'—which cast 'race' as primordial and stable entities—are so strong that they sometimes overwhelm; scholars or students who are supposed to be analyzing it easily fall into the trap of talking about it as if it is a universal and self-evident truth, a stable fact rather than an outcome driven by specific social and political processes.[3] When folk beliefs are confused with analytical categories, 'race' too quickly becomes the thing claimed to explain phenomena such as inequality, rather than that which needs to be unpacked and itself explained. How 'race' works and what racialization *processes* are like in specific contexts were what we were to focus on in Soc 131B, not what 'race' is or is not, nor what 'impact' it does or does not have on other 'variables.'[4]

Two decades on, when I read Ta-Nehisi Coates repeatedly refer to so-called

white Americans as "people who believe they are white" in his brilliant book, *Between the World and Me*,[5] I appreciate the importance of Coates' jarring articulation. Folk beliefs about 'race'—which assume it to be timeless and self-evident— are dangerous because people who believe themselves to be X and not Y tend also to take for granted that X is superior and Y is inferior and that this must always be true because X and Y have always existed in such an equation since the beginning of time. The willful forgetting of how some people became Xs and some compelled to become Ys, through specific carving of boundaries and precise acts of power, has the effect of perpetuating the imbalances between people who believe themselves to be X and those they believe to be Y. Quotation-marks-'race' keeps the floor beneath one's feet liquid, so we can remember that we are not on solid ground when it comes to claims about 'race.' Claims to its solidity, in fact, are acts of power and should be scrutinized closely.

Why ban 'racism' from the classroom? This was to avoid a second obfuscation —that of the multiplicity of processes, institutions, ideologies, and practices that enact and reenact racial domination. 'Racism' is a tool too crude to get at the fact that 'race' becomes meaningful and consequential through specific means: "categorization (including classification, prejudice, and stigma), discrimination (differential treatment based on imputed group membership), segregation (group separation in physical and social space), ghettoization (the forced development of parallel social and organizational structures), and racial violence (ranging from interpersonal intimidation and aggression, to lynching, riots and pogroms, and climaxing with racial war and extermination)."[6] To understand how 'race' comes to be significant in a given society and how racial domination is produced and perpetuated, we need these analytical lenses to look at specific empirical cases. We were not allowed to use the word 'racist' because it is a barrier to analysis. There are important distinctions to be made about how categorization works versus how discrimination does, between acts of segregation and those of ghettoization. Wacquant's list of 'elementary forms of racial domination' indicate that the degree and intensity of racial domination can be precisely captured, and that some

elements of racial domination may be present while others are absent. Most importantly, in opening the black box that 'racism' has become, the elements—categorization, discrimination, segregation, ghettoization, violence—compel us to specify mechanisms and name actors. Each of these elementary forms call to mind that they are acts of power; acts of power imply agents who exercise power.

Folk beliefs and the tendency to see differences: the racialization of the poverty problem

Is the poverty issue a problem caused by (so-called) race? No. Is it a problem linked to 'race' and racialization? Yes. Can we understand poverty by attributing it to 'racism'? No. Are there racialized patterns of categorization, discrimination, segregation we should pay attention to as we seek to better understand poverty and inequality? Probably.

What are folk beliefs about 'race' and poverty in Singapore? Our folk beliefs are that people categorized as Chinese are indisputably 'Chinese,' Malay always 'Malay,' Indian undeniably 'Indian'; people who are not 'Other' generally have no idea what 'Other' is supposed to be and do not care, rending the othering complete. Although these categories have come to be significant in Singapore society in the relatively recent past and have a specific traceable history as constructed categories generated somewhat haphazardly by rulers colonial and post-colonial,[7] and despite the fact that the principles underlying categorization have from time to time been revealed to be inconsistent and arbitrary,[8] many Singaporeans take CMIO[9] as demarcating self-evident 'races' that are primordial, rooted in biology and therefore immutable, that signal genuine similarities within categories and differences between the categories in terms of cultural practices, sensibilities and orientations.

One important presumed 'racial' difference embedded within this folk belief is that there are differences across groups in how they are oriented toward economic

activities. There follows a common-sense racialization of poverty and of wealth— in which 'Chineseness' and 'Malayness' are presumed to play a part in shaping the motivations, desires, habits of these groups. It is a small step from here to further folk beliefs that 'Malays' are poor and 'Chinese' are rich because 'Malays' are lazy and 'Chinese' are greedy.[10]

How would we know if these folk beliefs about 'racial' differences are empirically true or empirically false? For the most part, where folk lenses drive analyses, people will focus on trends that prove their validity. Presumed and imputed 'racial' differences can therefore be detected in assertions that Malays are overrepresented among the low-income; we continually see studies, reports, or news articles that abandon comparison entirely and go straight to problematizing only 'the Malay community.' There is value in highlighting racialized patterns in inequality trends, and I will return to this later. First, however, I would like to point out that taking 'racial' difference as starting point, without unpacking what the differences are, how differences have come about and how they are perpetuated, push us as a society to continually highlight differences without necessarily interrogating and comprehending them. Talking about 'difference' without asking questions about categorization, discrimination, segregation, et cetera, is like trying to drive through a rainstorm without windshield wipers.

How would we know if these folk beliefs about difference are empirically true or empirically false? One way is to control for class. What does that mean? If it is the case that 'Malays' and 'Chinese' are very distinct peoples, with widely varying habits, sensibilities, orientations, then we should see these differences play out even among people who share the same class backgrounds. If 'race' per se is supposed to be an explanation for how some people end up poor and others end up rich, then it must be a strong predictor of worldviews, inclinations, habits, decisions. One way to see how strong a predictor it is is thus to compare people who are of different racial categories but similar class backgrounds.

In fact, among the people I spoke with who are low-income, I did not find major differences between being a low-income 'Malay' person versus a low-income

'Chinese' person (and for that matter people in other categories). Respondents sometimes referenced 'race'—they too live in this society and draw on its folk beliefs. They often referred to people they had met by their racial categories, and they spoke languages and partook in cultural and religious practices associated with their 'race.' I do not mean to imply that *they* are 'race'-blind or that notions of Chineseness, Malayness, Indianness, never came up or were meaningless. But, focusing on the question of how 'race' matters or does not, I must emphasize this: the contours of life I have illustrated in this book—about the living environment, about work-life imbalance, about struggles with school and raising kids, about challenges with accessing public goods, about the failures to meet dignity needs—apply widely and deeply to people categorized as 'Chinese,' 'Malay,' 'Indian,' and also to people categorized in other groups. If one is bent on detecting differences between these groups, one can probably find them. But analyzing people's everyday experiences, circumstances, habits, sensibilities, decisions, the reality is that belonging to different racial categories did not matter very much.

To say that the inequality problem is *not* related to so-called race is to say that, contrary to folk beliefs that there are deep differences between people categorized as 'Chinese,' 'Malay,' 'Indian,' 'Other,' there are more *similarities* than differences among the people I met. To put it differently, a low-income 'Chinese' has more in common with a low-income 'Malay' than with a high-income 'Chinese.' In other words, class location is more significant than racial categories; class can tell us more about the lives people lead, the options they have, the steps they take, the decisions they make. The *explanatory* value of 'race' must therefore be called into question.

Nonetheless, we must return to the question of how it is Malays are overrepresented among the low-income and/or less educated and Chinese overrepresented among the high income and/or more educated in contemporary Singapore. Consistent with these trends, in my research on low-income persons, I spoke with a disproportionately high number of Malays and a disproportionately low number of Chinese, relative to their respective sizes in the population. These trends are important to pay attention to. My approach in this project, however, did

not and cannot throw up the necessary empirical data to adequately explain these trends.

Understanding how 'race' works was not a central goal of this project. I was sensitive to the folk beliefs about 'race' I was entering into, that are read in my own ostensibly 'Chinese' embodiment, and I was aware of the dangers of not seeing or misreading 'race.' As I detail in the Methodological Appendix, my approach was to capture as much as I could about the everyday experiences of living with low income. I recorded responses from people in various racial categories, in both genders, within this class of persons. I looked for patterns that could tell me what life is like from the vantage point of a low-income Singaporean. From this approach, the strongest claim I can make regarding 'race' is the one I made earlier—that one's membership in and identification with a particular racial category is *not* a strong predictor of sensibilities, habits, and decisions among people who are low-income. At the level of analysis where I was located, class is more salient.

To better understand how 'race' works, how it matters, why it is that 'Malays' are overrepresented among the low-income and 'Chinese' overrepresented among the high-income, we need a great deal of other research—conducted with explicit intention and systematic tools to address these questions. My empirical data, focused on the lives of the low-income, cannot and therefore *must not* pretend to answer this question. Research on 'race' that illuminates the *categorization* principles and practices of states; scholarship that scrutinizes *discriminatory* practices of employers, landlords/homeowners, schools, courts; studies that track concerted efforts of *segregation* and *ghettoization*, and work that documents racialized *violent* histories against certain peoples—this massive and rich scholarship point to the fact that to really understand and then explain how 'race' works and how racial domination is produced and reproduced, scholars have to interrogate the taken-for-granted, carefully generate data, rigorously scrutinize and analyze what they observe, and then in their presentation of their work, scaffold knowledge, unpack, fight off folk beliefs, build new knowledge that challenges, disrupts, discomforts. There is more work to be done before the question can be adequately answered.

*

After I present my work on poverty and inequality, there is invariably at least one audience member who will ask me to say more about 'race.' I understand why people want to know better than I have understood why I do not want to answer. This essay has come about because my editors strong-armed me into it. I did not want to bring all this out into the open; I am anxious that uttering 'race' without accounting for it can do more harm than good. But they have convinced me that my *not* talking about 'race' is unsatisfactory, because we live in a society where being 'Chinese,' 'Malay,' 'Indian,' 'Other' is so salient; whether or not I speak of it, Singaporeans presume that we know that 'race' matters in shaping poverty and wealth.

It is tremendously difficult for me to explain that I do not want to bring in 'race' based on the data I collected. I hope this essay illuminates why: we should not toss 'race' into the mix lightly and in passing because folk beliefs about it will dominate and people will see difference even where differences are essentially irrelevant. As I write this, I worry that some will take my words out of context and make the claim that I argue that 'race' is "essentially irrelevant."[11]

What, then, should you take away from this essay? This: our folk belief about 'race'—that it is a strong factor predictive of sensibilities, worldviews, decisions, practices—is wrong; there are more similarities across 'racial' groups than our folk beliefs lead us to think. Second, we have unanswered questions about our poverty and inequality trends, and there is more work to be done. To understand more about why/how 'race' seems to matter in reproducing inequality, we need more research that seeks to understand specific dynamics, processes, institutions, research that helps us see the effects of categorizations and the workings of discrimination. Until then, we must stay vigilant: use 'race' with quotation marks, and abandon 'racism' in favor of the elementary forms of racial domination.

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1 I recommend a read of his syllabus: http://sociology.berkeley.edu/sites/default/files/documents/syllabi/F13/SOC182-RACIALDOM2013%20PROV.pdf

2 See, for example, Wagley (1959), Davis (1991), Lancaster (1991), Chun (1996).

3 See also Banton (1979).

4 Wacquant (1997). See also Loveman (1999).

5 Coates (2015).

6 Wacquant (1997).

7 See Kathiravelu (2017); PuruShotam (1998); Chua (2003); Rahim (1998); Syed Hussein Alatas (2013 [1977]).

8 See, for example, Nur Asyiqin Mohamad Salleh (2017).

9 The Singapore state's official designations of 'race'—Chinese, Malay, Indian, Other.

10 See Syed Hussein Alatas (2013 [1977]).

11 Do not take my words out of context.

Now What

THIS IS WHAT INEQUALITY LOOKS LIKE. Now what? This essay explores what I have learnt thus far about how to think this question.

Learning and reflecting

There is a lot of collective knowledge on inequality and poverty. It is waiting to be read and reflected on.

If we look to scholarship by sociologists, anthropologists, economists, psychologists, geographers, we learn this: inequality is bad. It is bad for the well-being of societies and persons. It is bad not only for people at the very bottom but for societies more generally. Inequality is damaging for social cohesion and detrimental to political harmony and function.

We know about the causes of and solutions to inequality. Inequality is not an agentless phenomenon although it has been historically persistent. There is a wealth of empirical evidence that points to the central roles of government and social policies in its reproduction. In other words, for countries that do better in terms of equality, it is no accident. Countries that do worse—also no accident. There is empirical work we can look to to better understand what countries that have done better have done that have helped to reduce inequalities.

Learning requires humility and a willingness to change one's views. The narrative of Third World to First, poor to wealthy; the narrative of Singapore as exceptional and amazing; the narrative of inequality as an inevitable outcome of globalization and economic development; the narrative of successes and failures as emerging fairly and based on 'merit'—these are barriers to learning. The knowledge that exists about inequality begins from a very simple point: there is a high level of inequality in Singapore. To begin to learn, one must be able to hear that and then

to resist the inner urge to defend and explain away that empirical fact. One has to make conscious effort to move beyond defensiveness and ideology.

Information is not knowledge. Access to factoids and figures does not automatically translate to the capacity to unlock understanding. Information alone also does not inspire the asking of fundamental questions nor provide the impetus to act.

While working on this book, numerous novels, essays, short stories, plays, comics, poems, energized my imagination and deepened my resolve. There are writers and thinkers not cited in my bibliography but whose work moved me: David Rakoff, Chimamanda Ngozi Adichie, Elena Ferrante, Andrew Soloman, Jolene Tan, Elizabeth Strout, Tash Aw, Natalia Ginzburg, Tania de Rozario, Ta-Nehisi Coates, Balli Kaur Jaswal, Amanda Lee Koe, Ann Patchett, Viet Thanh Nguyen, Mohamed Latiff Mohamed, Philip Holden, Zadie Smith, Jhumpa Lahiri, Lindy West, Alan Cumming, Alfian Sa'at, Patti Smith, Paulo Freire, Arundhati Roy, Ian McEwan, Yiyun Li, Mohsin Hamid, Yaa Gyasi, Haresh Sharma, Lai Chee Kien, George Pérez, Sonny Liew, Teju Cole, Mary Oliver, G. Willow Wilson, Rebecca Solnit.

I would be hard put to describe what these writers have in common from a literary point of view. I read them with no specific purpose in mind; they fulfilled the purpose of freeing me from the shackles of academia. They allowed me to return to the big questions sociologists have historically been concerned about but now rarely openly and unabashedly ask: what is it to be human? Who are we? Who can we dream of becoming?

When I began training to be a sociologist, I harbored a view that knowledge and understanding from the kind of work sociologists do would have transformative potential. I still believe this to some extent; systematic empirical evidence remains my main orienting force—the place I go to figure out what needs to change and how. But to feed the craving for possibilities of progressive change; to nurture the courage to imagine alternative realities; to bridge the linkages—from information to knowledge, knowledge to empathy, empathy to conviction, conviction to action;

social science cannot work alone.

The 'now what' question is a continual challenge, not a static endpoint. It means to open up creativity, exploration, ongoing efforts from multiple places. To do all that, we have to keep reading, keep listening, keep reflecting, keep learning. And we have to seek out knowledge that will make us un-shy to ask big questions.

Adapting and acting

I am a sociologist. My work is to uncover, analyze, rethink, write. Through sharing my research, I have met social workers, counselors, business owners, teachers, policy makers, activists, writers, theater practitioners, filmmakers, photographers, students, volunteers, parents. Each of these categories of persons have varying work and disparate goals. They are placed in various and sometimes multiple locations in society—with particular roles, conditions, resources, opportunities, constraints, commitments. They have a range of reasons for wanting to hear about my findings. When they leave my seminars or put aside my writings, they walk away in different directions. Their work is something else, everywhere else.

My students joke about Sociology spoiling everything. Seeing the world through sociological lenses turns things topsy-turvy, ruins simplicity, sucks the joy out of things that they accepted as everyday common sense. Worst of all, knowledge about the world without capacity to change it feels immensely disempowering. Because I am the messenger, some of them mistakenly see my path as the only path for trying to effect change.

Many years ago, when I first met someone who was to become one of my best friends, I too felt disempowered by my encounter with Sociology. We had many conversations about disempowerment and she taught me two things: first, we have to do what we can wherever we happen to be located; all acts are meaningful as long as we take them. Second, what effect we ultimately have will be because we do not act alone.

What can we do about the inequality problem? I hope a lot, and I believe it will include many things I cannot imagine. A solution a playwright, a policy maker, or a student designs will be something I am incapable of conceptualizing. I am doing what I can from where I am, and I know many others will do what they can from where they are. We each take what knowledge we have and adapt and apply it given the resources and opportunities we have. There will be times we feel all is futile and we are powerless. There will be days when we have opportunities and years when we continually slam ourselves against shut doors. We must remind each other then that we are not alone. We act because we have to and we act because, together, we can create something new, something else.

Goals: learning from Sweden

In 2017, the Development Finance International and Oxfam released a report on a new measure they developed called the Commitment to Reducing Inequality Index.[1] In it, they look at 152 countries' commitment to reducing income and wealth inequalities. The 'commitment' is operationalized by looking at social spending (on health, education, and social protection); taxation (structure and incidence); and the protection of labor rights, because each of these have redistributive effects. The report is insightful for capturing what most measures of inequality do not: what countries are actually doing to deal with the problem of growing inequality, as opposed to where they are at now in terms of inequality measures. This is key for two related reasons: inequality measures capture where countries are at at any given point in time without necessarily signaling where they may be headed. This tends toward overlooking trends in wealthier states that have had high levels of commitment to redistribution but which have moved away from this in recent decades (e.g. the United Kingdom) and less wealthy states that continue to have high rates of inequality but which are making significant efforts toward redistribution (e.g. Namibia). Second, then, the index is potentially a tool

through which citizens can hold states accountable for actions they are or are not taking toward improving on equality measures.

Sweden, unsurprisingly, was on top of the list, signaling it had the highest level of commitment to reducing inequality. A striking thing happened when the report was released, shocking in its contrast to what happens when news breaks of Singapore (the country, or specific institutions in it) being ranked highly in any global index. *The Guardian* published an article featuring Sweden.[2] In it, political leaders from various parties talked about how worried they are that inequality is increasing and how much harder they have to work to reduce inequality. I had to read it twice to make sure I was not misinterpreting its main thrust. The country that consistently ranks near the top in various equality and social well-being measures is now ranked top in measures of its commitment, and the news is not of them celebrating this achievement but their lament of how bad things have gotten and how much better they need to do. On one hand, it is the perfect enactment of the word 'commitment' indicated by the index. On the other hand, wow.

There is a lot we can learn from the report. The authors explain the choice of measures—illuminating how each factor contributes to reducing income inequalities by better spreading the wealth in any given society across to its members. They are unapologetic about pointing out that the policy moves represented by the measures are partly to correct for the monopolization of resources by political and economic elites across the globe. They are also explicit in pointing out that many of the moves are as yet unable to prevent the siphoning and hiding of wealth by said elites. The inequality we see in the world today has specific actors. When states commit to addressing them, they are committing to being a little more on the side of most people and taking some stance to scale back ever so slightly the interests of the wealthy and powerful.

The report thus allows citizens to hold states accountable in two ways: the first is more obvious—there is a ranking and citizens can say, "this is where we rank now —can we do better than this the next time the report comes out?" The second is perhaps even more important—it opens up the conversation about these social

policy moves—spending on education, health, social protection; taxation; and labor protections—and frames these as issues of fairness and equity. To ask that a given country's wealth be spread out and distributed among its members—who have contributed to generating the wealth in the first place—and to ask that wealth not be captured and monopolized by a small group of elites by virtue of policies that allow them to do so legally, these are not unreasonable asks. Fairness and justice are sensible principles—with material benefits potentially accruing to a majority of humankind—and not some quirky subculture.

This long description of the Commitment to Reducing Inequality index is, in the end, an illustrative example. Like any other report or ranking system, there are limitations. The point is that tools exist that allow us to set reasonable goals. We can call for accountability toward achieving goals, but only if they are set.

Owning it: forget Sweden

I have noticed that some people don't like it when I talk about Sweden. They jump in to remind me we have different cultures: Singaporeans are not culturally ready and would not accept the high level of taxes. They are particularly fond of saying that we are multicultural and Sweden is not. They never explain the causal mechanism between multiculturalism and social policy but I know they have the discursive upper hand because the minute they say this, no one, myself included, wants to talk about Sweden. It appears they have won me over. I am actually silenced because their proclamation reminds me we have 84 other countries to aspire to before reaching Sweden anyway.

If the mention of Sweden bothers you, forget Sweden.

Jeremy Lim, in his book *Myth or Magic*, explains in detail the healthcare system in Singapore and how it has changed and evolved over time. Donald Low and Sudhir Vadaketh explore in the book, *Hard Choices*, various dimensions of economic and social policy and how they have developed. In *Living with Myths in*

Singapore, a volume put together by Loh Kah Seng, Thum Ping Tjin, and Jack Chia, they and others think through various stories that inform us about Singapore's past and present.[3]

All these works shed historical insight even if not all the authors are historians. One key insight is this: there is, within Singapore's recent history, a strong set of ethical commitments centered on equality and justice. Within our own recent past, there has been a desire to place these as the central goals of development. Economic growth and wealth is a means to an end, not an end in itself. This ethos is embedded in our culture, even if at this particular historical moment it is regularly obscured.

I often think of comebacks two days after a moment has passed. But in one instance, I had the presence of mind to bring up Jeremy Lim's book and the passages he quoted of Toh Chin Chye, JB Jeyaretnam, and Goh Chok Tong arguing about what a healthcare system is meant to do.[4] The passages illustrate that in the 1980s there were serious arguments about policy design and systemic processes. More than that, there were deep disagreements stemming from different philosophies about human nature, human worth, the role of the state, and the place of the social. I cannot say for sure where the Singapore state is now and where it is headed, but my response to "but we are not Sweden" was and is this: forget Sweden. Within our own history, our own culture, these debates live. The contrasts, disagreements, and contestations—between a side that valorizes the social, equality, and justice, and a side that valorizes individual self-reliance and 'the market'—are within our society.

Back at my field site, I have the privilege of meeting people who compel me to continue to love this country. There is nothing beautiful about living below a decent standard of living, nothing romantic about living outside social norms. But there is everything worthy about people who, under trying conditions, love their families, take pride in their work, make time for strangers, appreciate beauty and strengths, share with neighbors, bounce back from crises, face up to mistakes, talk

about fairness, resolve to try to be good. I am forced to undo my inner cynic.

Hard work, self-reliance, family values, community—these words that have come to be slogans and tropes, when performed by real people living real lives, become something like beauty. What is black and white bleeds into color. Values manifest in ways that stray outside the lines of policy rules, their imperfection a stunning reminder that humanity cannot be crammed into narrow pathways. They emerge and reemerge in spite of conditions that are unfavorable, like grass growing through gaps between concrete slabs. I am a visitor from a different social world, tasked with figuring out how to fix them. It turns out there are important values here to aspire to and emulate.

Maybe Sweden is different. Of course Sweden is different. But within our own culture—past and present—live values, beliefs, habits, aspirations, that we can fight to own.

This is what inequality looks like. Now what?

Now we refuse.

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4 See pages 52-56 in Lim (2013).

A methodological appendix for all readers: This Is What Data Looks Like

THE ETHNOGRAPHIC METHOD—though it has a rich tradition in disciplines such as Sociology, Anthropology, and Geography—is not well-understood by larger publics. I include this methodological appendix to explain what this approach entails and why it matters to know it. I include it even though this is not a book for academics—who are usually the ones who want to know about methodology—because understanding how knowledge is produced matters. Knowing how questions are crafted, how data is collected, and how people who use data use it—these are important skills in the contemporary world, and a crucial precondition to building a democratic public. So this appendix is not just for people interested in doing research, but for everyone who has to engage with the complex and noisy range of ideas, information, and facts both real and pseudo in the contemporary world. To know about the underlying mechanics and principles for how people ask questions, how they collect data to answer those questions, and how they use the data to tell stories about society, is to learn to critically evaluate what we hear about ourselves. Knowledge about data—its creation, its interpretations, its uses—is our democratic right and our civic responsibility.

How we ask questions shape what we are able to know about the world

I began my research with a simple goal: to better understand the everyday experiences of people living with low income. I visited primarily two HDB rental flat neighborhoods over the course of three years, mostly between 2013 and 2016. In addition to the two neighborhoods, I visited six other neighborhoods across the island a few times to get a sense of how variant neighborhoods might be. Some

months during these years, I visited the neighborhoods two or three times a week; other months, because of other professional commitments, my visits were less frequent. Although only partially deliberate, the pattern of my visits was important to the process of understanding: being there regularly allowed me to grow to feel comfortable in the space and more at ease when I hung out with people in their flats; time away and then returning, particularly at later stages when I was writing and presenting my work more, reminded me of the starkness of what I was witnessing and prevented me from accepting and normalizing people's hardships.

I spent three to four hours each time I was in the neighborhoods, speaking to two or three families each visit. In total, I visited about 90 times and spoke with more than 200 people. I focused most of my attention on families with children, and not much on the elderly, because I was especially interested in better understanding the dynamics of mobility or lack thereof across generations. We talked about a range of things—about their kids, their families, their homes and neighborhoods, their jobs, their crises, their aspirations, and their everyday routines. After each visit, I spent another two to three hours writing fieldnotes, recording as closely as I could the details of what people shared with me, and the specifics of what I heard and saw. Over time, I began to identify patterns and salient themes, and to more systematically code my data. Continual reading; reflections on my earlier work; conversations with others working as academics, social workers, activists, volunteers; verification of findings through looking at policy documents, speeches, other studies; writing of memos, talks, papers—all these gave further shape to ideas about how to make sense of my findings.

The approach undertaken in my research is ethnographic. What this means is that the data is generated through repeated visits to the same neighborhoods, through many informal conversations (often about things that seem mundane), and through observations of interactions and space. In a few cases, I did a few formal interviews—with a fixed list of interview questions. But after spending some time in the field, I realized that this approach did not work well for my purposes. I found that informal conversations were much more effective in capturing a wide *range* of

people's experiences; this is crucial since my purpose was to understand everyday experiences. Importantly, I also discovered that I was better able to build trust and rapport through informal conversations than through formal interviews; people were more relaxed and forthcoming in informal chats than in formal interviews. By talking less, listening more, and indeed by not insisting on shaping the direction of our chats, the complexity of people's experiences could find space to enter our conversations. Approaching thus, I learnt about things I could not have thought to ask. It is through an ethnographic approach that I came to see, hear, and learn things that I did not fully anticipate.

With certain types of questions about the social world, where there are things we do not understand well, where there are phenomena that are hidden, stigmatized, sensitive, or complicated, the ethnographic approach generates valuable data and insights that alternative approaches to asking questions, such as survey questionnaires, cannot. One way to think about this is to imagine yourself being confronted by a person carrying a clipboard, standing at your door or speaking to you over the phone, and asking you a series of questions along the lines of, "On a scale of 1 to 5, would you say the general well-being of your children is '5-very good,' '4-good,' '3-somewhat good,' '2-not good,' or '1-unsure'?" There are normal, socially appropriate, safe ways to answer that question. Perhaps your child is struggling with school, perhaps you are having difficulties communicating with your teenagers and have barely spoken to them all week, perhaps you really want to answer 2 or 1 or something else altogether that is not captured by the options presented to you. But you do not know what the person with the clipboard, or the voice over the phone, wants to hear; you can barely understand the question because it is read out so quickly and it is one question out of twenty questions; anyway, it is none of their business and they do not look/sound like they care to hear the real answer. Some of these same barriers confront researchers who do ethnographic work, but the space for answers to be expanded on, the time to allow people to first say things that are socially appropriate before they reveal all the ways in which things are challenging or complex, create opportunities for researchers to

more fully capture what is going on in families' lives. In other words, the data generated is not just different, it is better—it more accurately reflects what is actually going on in people's lives. The survey method is important for certain kinds of research questions. I write this not to undermine its value in knowledge production. However, since we live in a society that thinks of numbers and statistics as irrefutable 'facts' and since findings from in-depth interviews and ethnographic observations are often dismissed as 'anecdotes,' it is necessary to point out that there are many types of data and the route by which researchers generate data must depend on the nature of the questions they are asking rather than be driven by what are mistakenly perceived as more factual. In questions about hidden experiences and stigmatized identities, qualitative approaches yield more precise, more robust, and more holistic data. Asking the same question three times, with different words, making eye contact and paying attention to body language that signals interest and capacity to empathize, yields layers of answers. These layers allow us to get a little closer to comprehending things that are not easily spoken and not easily heard.

Speaking is always done by someone, someone is speaking

One of the first things I had to unlearn when I went to the US to attend university was writing in the passive voice. It has been said, I said. It was argued, I argued. It is a belief, I believed. Red lines struck out line after line in every assignment I turned in. Who said? Who argued? Who believed?

The passive voice is not just a matter of style, it is a matter of accountability. Who speaks? From where? What do they represent? Where lies their interests? What are their likely blindspots? What are they not saying? When someone speaks as if no one in particular is speaking, why? For how long and in what context is what they say supposed to apply? The active voice forces into the light: I am speaking;

someone in particular said; a specific study (citation included) argued; these groups, living in this specific time and place, believed. When my teachers forced me to write in the active voice, I had to be more precise, more concrete, and I had to back up my claims with empirical evidence.

When I am in the field, I exist. When I write at my desk, I exist. When I speak from a podium, I exist. To exist is to have certain life experiences that shape the questions I am interested in. To exist is to have acquired what Pierre Bourdieu refers to as 'habitus'—a set of bodily comportments, habits, manners of speaking—that rest in the individual body but are shaped by one's social positioning and hence reflects one's class status, one's ethnoracial background, one's gendered position. To exist is to have people respond to you in various ways that you cannot control. To exist is to agree with some people and disagree with others. To exist is to have a point of view—interests, inclinations, capacities, limitations, blindspots.

Every researcher—in every discipline, doing any kind of research—brings with them their existence in the world and therefore their subjectivity. They ask questions that interest them because of their life experiences and social positions; they think about data collection in certain ways because of their relationships with others and all the influences this entails; and they analyze—organize, interpret, make sense of—their data in certain ways because their worldviews and experiences both professionally and personally push them in some directions more than others. In the tradition of qualitative research, subjectivity per se does not undermine research, but a lack of reflexivity about how subjectivity matters does.

The reader cannot control the writer, but when faced with any presentation of knowledge about the world, you must ask: who is doing the speaking? From where do they stand? Critical evaluation of knowledge produced and presented about the world involves not just knowing how to read charts or sentences, but also knowing how to interrogate underlying and often unspoken assumptions, premises, biases.

The enterprise of knowledge production: who gets to

produce knowledge and on what terms?

On hearing that I was writing this book and publishing it with Ethos Books, many academic friends commended me for my courage. I am human and like to be affirmed. But it should not take courage to write a book about our society for a nonacademic audience. I am employed in a public university, funded through public moneys, as a social scientist. It should be part of my job description and a central component of my professional duty to share what expertise I have with the rest of society, with the very people who allow me to do the work that I do. Yet, it is extremely rare for academics to publish outside of academic journals or with nonacademic publishers. It took some time, and indeed after a partially drafted academic book, before I finally began to write this one. In making the decision, I had to first decide that it is alright that this book would not be legible in the schema of university evaluation systems.

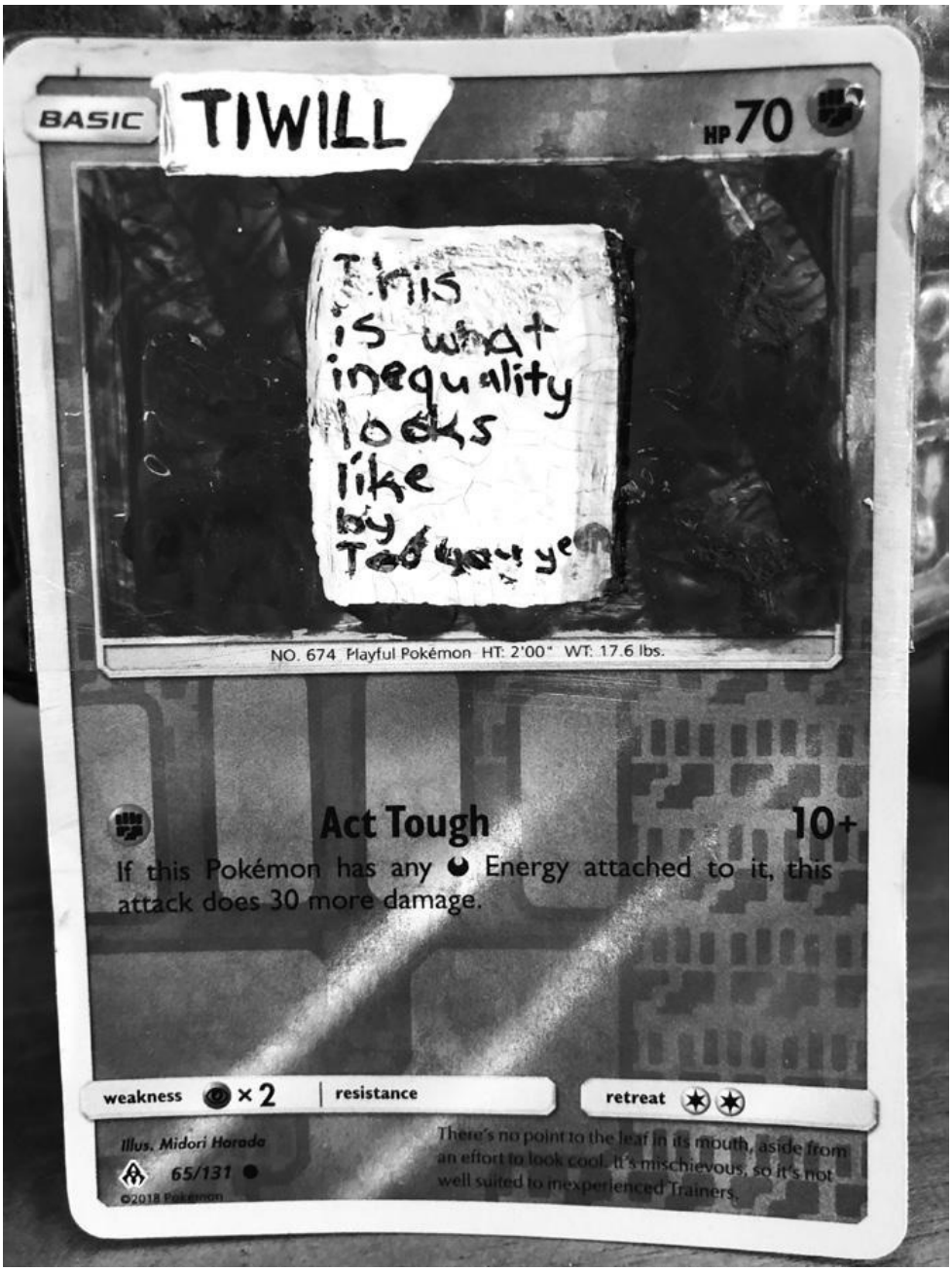
This book is also my post-tenure book. It is not a book I could have written when I was building up a credible body of work to prove my worth in a Singaporean university. It took various turns in my biography to actually know how to write it—a turning-point conversation with a mentor, a stumbling into civil society, numerous contacts with people living in realities starkly different from mine, the building of another meaning-making lifeworld.

I am lucky to have had the choices I've had and happy to have made the decisions I've made. The process of working on this book has felt like my dream of becoming a sociologist finally coming to fruition. But I am troubled and I think everyone should be troubled that this was a difficult decision to come to. We should be very worried that it came about through so many unpredictable and unintended incidences, depended so deeply on sheer luck. It should not take *accidents* to produce knowledge about our society that can actually be read, critiqued, evaluated, discussed by members of our society. A book like this should be a regular outcome of our knowledge-production system, not an accident, a blip.

Understanding data is part of our democratic right and duty. But if data is not forthcoming—if research that asks questions researchers know to be important to ask is not conducted; if research findings are not shared outside of closed-door sessions; if analyses are not widely shared and circulated, in various media, outside of small academic audiences—then people cannot exercise these rights or duties. Beyond knowing how to read and critically evaluate data, readers also need to understand that this is where our knowledge-production system is at. To understand our world in such a context, we need to actively, hungrily seek out varied sources, and to read them skeptically and cautiously.

Knowledge is always incomplete. This book is a finished product for now, but there remain many other questions to ask and other research projects to conduct. Within the limitations and constraints of our knowledge-production systems, I remain hopeful that this is a beginning.

Later:
An unanticipated year of autoethnography



Gift from my daughter, December 2018.

WHEN I FILED MY LAST EDIT in December 2017, a month before *This is What Inequality Looks Like* was first released, I fully expected to begin a gradual

backing away from the book. That is what academics do: we work on a research project, draft articles and books reporting our findings, revise them over a couple of years. By the time they are reviewed, revised, and published, we are already working on some other project. After publication, there may be a handful of opportunities to speak about the work; five to ten years later, we may discover that our work has been read when it is cited by a few other scholars in their publications. That is all. It must seem incredibly strange to people not in this world, but academics write even though we do not expect many people to read or comment on our work. From this perch, I was unprepared for what was to come after the release of TIWILL.

Ethos Books released *This is What Inequality Looks Like* on January 5, 2018. It hit the bookstores and went straight onto the nonfiction weekly bestseller list, where it remains one year on. By the time of the book launch event on February 2, about 800 copies had been sold. There was enough traction that about two hundred people showed up for the book launch, the vast majority of them unfamiliar faces. In the Budget debates in February, parliamentarians cited the book in their speeches, some quoting direct passages.[1] The mainstream media quickly picked up on the book—editorial reviews appeared and references to it were made in various articles about inequality and social mobility in both the English and Chinese press.[2] Outside of *The Straits Times* and *Lianhe Zaobao*, other articles also appeared.[3] Between January and July, I received regular requests from journalists asking me to comment on articles and to be profiled in newspapers and magazines. I turned down most of these. One I did accept was an interview by Bharati Jagdish, because she sent me in-depth questions about the book that I thought would clarify certain issues, and hers was a radio program with sufficient time to flesh out some complexity.[4] That interview ended up being widely circulated and created another spike, in May, in sales of TIWILL. Between January and July, I wrote seven op-eds directly engaging in some of the conversations and debates.[5] It was of course not all rainbows and sunshine. Several critiques also appeared.[6] Friends sent me texts when they thought it was probably I who was being called a "bleeding heart" and probably I who had triggered the negative use of the words "theory" and

"academic." I watched, slightly disoriented, as other people's articles and talks took "This is what…" as their titles. Sometimes I was directly named, other times I was Voldemort. Around August or so, requests from the local press stopped. I thought it was time then to take a break. But no rest for the wicked, because the movie *Crazy Rich Asians* was released and much to my surprise, commentators of the movie critiqued it using the lens of inequality; TIWILL stayed in national discourse, including on social media, because other people were refusing to unsee.[7] International press picked up on this and contacted me; I didn't comment since others had made such incisive interventions that I felt I had little value to add. Soon after, *Channel NewsAsia* produced a television program titled "Regardless of Class."[8] Again, other voices spoke up to critically evaluate it and TIWILL stayed in the news on the basis of other people's—strangers'—refusal to stop invoking it.[9] Between August and December, I watched closely and with mixed emotions as inequality continued to dominate public debate—sometimes in ways that seemed progressive and other times in ways that deflated me because it felt like the needle had hardly moved and we were back to speaking in circles and whispering in shadows. December rolled around and I found myself on *The Straits Times'* Power List and then nominated for their Singaporean of the Year Award. TIWILL was among the year's best-selling non-fiction books, having moved about 20,000 copies in 11 months. In various year-end commentaries, inequality-TIWILL was mentioned as a major thing that happened.[10] I ended 2018 confused about how to make sense of the year TIWILL, and I, had just lived.

While all of this was unfolding in the public arena, at eye-contact level a separate set of encounters were taking place. Letters arrived. Week after week after week, emails requesting meetings and invitations to give talks. Dear Professor Teo. I do not have a secretary so I communicated directly with people's personal assistants. Being an obsessive record keeper, I discovered when I looked that my "no list" in 2018—to invitations to speak, write, or collaborate—was an astounding 73. And this after I thought I had said yes to more things than I really could manage. I drank more tea than I had expected to, and saw the insides of buildings I had never been

in. I ended up doing 12 talks, probably a modest number to some people but a lot to me. I prepare new material each time I speak, so it was non-stop writing—working out new ways to present the same work, searching for the right tone to address questions. It was deeply satisfying to be able to engage with other people's questions, to observe where various audiences were seeing TIWILL, but also unsettling to feel "unproductive" because I was writing page after page that I knew would never be published. At the speaking events, seats were taken up and waitlists formed the moment registrations went live; on a few occasions, organizers switched venues to accommodate more people.[11] I started carrying a pen with me because people were asking for autographs; I was touched as much by the brand-new copies they intended to give friends as I was by the dog-eared, highlighted copies that some sheepishly put in my hand. I smiled for wefies—a professor accidentally living someone else's life— wondering where on social media my face was going to end up. I tried to be cool, hoping my complexion hadn't betrayed me, when young people openly declared that they were fangirls/ boys. There was a frenzy to these activities, as if I was running, running, running, anxious that I was about to run out of time. Surely, sooner rather than later, everyone would walk off, look away, forget. Because I could not say no without a tinge of regret, I became slightly relieved and uncharacteristically half-glass-full when some invitations became easier to turn down as keynote invitations awkwardly morphed into panel plans so that other speakers could "balance" me out.

But I digress. The letters. The letters I intend to someday reread arrived with no asks. Thank you. You've said something I have been feeling but couldn't put words to. Thank you. Your book was hard to read because it spoke to my experiences. Thank you. Your book changed the way I look at Singapore and my own life. Thank you for writing. Please keep going. Thank you. As a young Singaporean. Thank you. As an older Singaporean. Thank you. As a relative newcomer. Thank you. I hope I will also be able to do something to change things. Thank you. A cascading sea of gratitude that goes on and on as my replies, too, are thank-yous. What magic is this response, wonders the academic accustomed to

sending letters in a bottle.

From the early days after the release of this book when people started to thank me for speaking on behalf of the low-income, I have maintained that I cannot claim to be speaking on anyone's behalf. What I present in the book is what I see—from my vantage point of a sociologist living in this society. The book bears both the strengths of my sociological expertise as well as my limitations as a human being with her own standpoint and biases. That is how it should be read. I put myself in the book, contrasting my class position to my respondents', precisely to emphasize that we have vastly different experiences, different vantage points. I emphasize our shared humanity and what I think should be our inherent worth and inherent dignity. But I hope I have been clear: the voice speaking is me speaking, the story I tell is the story I am telling from a sociological standpoint. In the year since the book's publication, many other voices have emerged, and a few of these have been from people who have experiences of living with low income; these should be taken seriously, because those are indeed the voices which do not often get heard nor amplified.

As a sociologist, the story I tell is aimed at amplifying social phenomenon more than it is about giving voice to individual lives.[12] Another way of putting that is to say that my aspiration is for the book to speak of those things which are, for various reasons, unspeakable in our society. In this view, the voiceless is not only those who are low-income but everyone living in this society. When there are things we find difficult to say out loud about our society, that we cannot clearly and explicitly acknowledge and debate, that we do not have mental tools and vocabularies to properly describe, we are, all of us and collectively, voiceless.

"Thank you."
"Thank *you*."
"Thank you."
"Thank *you*."

If we are all voiceless, what is it we find unspeakable? First, that poverty exists amidst great wealth. Under the shiny Global City, there are uneven consequences for different classes of people. TIWILL is an attempt at shining light into the dark corners, speaking about that which is out of sight from Singapore's shiny veneer. Accompanying this unspeakability is a second one: that many of us cannot see these features of Singapore society is because we are wearing particular shades; these shades flatten, turn into monochrome, everything we look at. How is the Emerald City so green? The refusal or inability to see is a kind of double-violence, a complicity and collective denial that has costs, uneven ones, with burdens borne disproportionately by marginalized groups. Third, there are specific structural levers and power relations that matter in shaping our lives and well-being, and in shaping our lenses for viewing the world. Public policy matters in shaping the contours of our relations with one another as well as the uneven ground on which we find each other standing; capitalist practices of exploitation must be named; dominant narratives that obscure have to be identified. This is not some invisible hand of a non-agentic global economy, and we cannot understand social phenomena without talking about power and its exercise.

It is true that I have never received so many unsolicited letters from ordinary members of the public before TIWILL. Judging from the letter-writers' sheepish, sometimes apologetic, tones, it is equally right to note that *they* had probably never looked up a writer's email address in order to thank them. I was not as aware a year ago as I am now that I have spoken some unspeakable things. I did not fully anticipate that the book would trigger so many nerves and strike so many chords. Because I am a sociologist, I try to think through this as a social phenomenon. The interior of my life has been intense and idiosyncratically so, but what I have described can ultimately be detached from me.

People's responses to TIWILL reveal something about where our society is at. The book finds resonance because there is existing experience, understanding, discomfort, wisdom, that it resonates with. For there to be things people

recognized, there had to be existing knowledge. For there to be things that people found relief in having spoken out loud, there had to be unspeakable things.

TIWILL was produced while I lived in this society and absorbed its tones and tensions, wisdoms and pains. TIWILL entered into this society and became what it became through its multiple encounters with the concerns and idealisms of its people. My voice in the book meets the reader's voice as she or he reads. In that magical moment, something emerges that is a little louder than usual. Yet, still, I think we remain a murmur, not quite a song; experiencing a moment, not yet a movement. What happens next?

Toward the end of 2018, I was asked by several journalists how I felt about the impact of the book. I mumbled vaguely that it is too soon to say. TIWILL has sold a lot of copies for something written by an academic. But only a fool would think she has changed the world with a book. I look up from my desk and around, and it is clear that inequality has wreaked havoc—on material well-being, social solidarity, and political stability—in many parts of the world. The old-fashioned or disingenuous continue to reference "globalization" to mask actors and asymmetries, but evidence mounts that it is inequality that has done the job. The increasing sense that elites—political and economic—have hoarded with no limits, at cost to everyone else, has paved roads for populist demagogues to rush into the vacuum of trust and hope. Populism is not, of course, democratic, but we continue to witness just how deeply inequality had already damaged democracy in democracies in recent decades before populism and authoritarianism could swoop in and take root.[13] To presume, in the absence of strong evidence of robust social solidarity ties and deep democratic habits, that Singapore will automatically be exceptional, is to be a damned fool.[14]

Yet, still, my mind wanders back to those letters and the responses to the call. A certain wide-eyed desire, to build a better country, lives. A sincere earnestness seeps through. Civil society—small, body full of injuries—sticks around. The book has surfaced deep tensions, and TIWILL's year-long journey revealed a populace

sensitive to and willing to address those tensions. There is work to do.

This is a book with space, gaps, lightness, possibility. Questions raised, not fully answered; answers sketched out, not colored in. The book is, should be, a gathering —with an open invitation. An invitation only works if people accept, show up, stay, mingle, converse, connect. In the process of making this book, I found my voice. I added it to the voices that existed before mine. It remains, I think, for the book to continue doing the work of enlarging the space in which others, too, can find their voices. My invitation stands. I hope people will keep showing up to the gathering. And I hope they, you, will stay.

Teo You Yenn
January 2019
Singapore

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11 One of these events, a public lecture titled "Growing up in an unequal society" delivered at the Singapore Children's Society on September 15, was video recorded. I thank the Singapore Children's Society for sharing the recording

and Jolene Tan for skillfully editing and turning it into an animation video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=N9G5nKnpTWA&feature=youtu.be

12 I elaborate on this methodological point in an essay, "Seeing a story to get to a case," in *They Told Us to Move*, edited by Ng Kok Hoe and the Cassia Resettlement Team, 34-41. 2019. Singapore: Ethos Books.

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